



KING *of* TEETH



THE BLOOD CODE — BOOK ONE

Aurelia Thorn

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and events are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is coincidental. New Orleans is real. Its witches keep their own counsel.

This book contains explicit sexual content, graphic violence, and themes intended for adult readers. A full content list follows.

First edition, 2026.

For every woman who was ever somebody's collateral.

Name your price.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN



This is a dark romance. It is not a safe book, and it is not trying to be one.

Silas Roche is the King's enforcer. He breaks men's necks on doorsteps and doesn't lose sleep over it, because he doesn't sleep. He was owned once, and he has never said so out loud. He is not going to become a gentle man. He's going to become a man who stays.

Ondine Marchand is a witch who brewed the poison that nearly killed a king, and she'd do it again for the right reasons. She saves herself. Nobody carries her out.

What you'll find inside, so you can decide:

- Blood drinking, on the page. A first feeding that is voluntary, aware, and remembered, and very explicit.
- Explicit sex, a lot of it, described plainly. Oral both ways. Rough sex and tender sex. Sex outdoors, on the water. Sex in a bathtub.
- A hand over her mouth, with a signal she can use at any time: knock twice on the wall and he stops. He says it out loud before, and he asks afterward whether it was right.
- Restraints: she binds his wrists with a working, and he offers them.
- Graphic violence. A neck broken on a porch. A beheading carried out under the law.
- The hero's past: he was turned in the road after a fire and forced to track people for a slave catcher. It is told in his own words, briefly and without looking away.
- Grief. A heroine who pays for her magic with her memories, including the ones she can't spare.
- A villain who is unfailingly polite. That's the worst part.

- Strong language. She's a witch with a temper. He's two hundred years old and was raised in a yard.

Every character in every sexual situation is an adult.

The cat lives. The cat is fine. The cat has opinions.

There is a happy ending. It is earned, it is not soft, and it leaves a grave in the woods for the next book.

If you're still here, you already know what you are.

Welcome back to New Orleans. Mind your name.

PLAYLIST



I Put a Spell on You — Nina Simone
Bad Things — Jace Everett
Work Song — Hozier
Poison & Wine — The Civil Wars
Dog Days Are Over — Florence + the Machine
Arsonist's Lullabye — Hozier
River — Leon Bridges
Witchy Woman — Eagles
The Night We Met — Lord Huron
Salt and the Sea — The Lone Bellow
Nothing Else Matters — Metallica
Home — Edward Sharpe & the Magnetic Zeros

THE BLOOD CODE



Five books. One city. A different couple in each, and one question under all of them.

1. **King of Teeth** — Lucian and Selene
2. **Vow of Poison** — Silas and Ondine
3. **Son of Wolves** — Rémy and Isabeau
4. **Heir of Ash** — Tobias and Severine
5. **God of Blood** — Delphine and Elias

Each book has its own happy ending. Read them in order. The city remembers what you skip.

KING OF TEETH

CHAPTER ONE



The witch who nearly killed my king is making soup.

I can smell it from the road. Onion, bay, the dark roux her grandmother taught her, and something under it that isn't food. Rosemary burned on purpose. She does that when she's worried and doesn't want the house to know.

I've walked past this house most nights for a year.

I walk past because some nights her bedroom window is open, and I can smell her from the gate: rosemary and warm skin and, late, after her lamp goes out, the sharp sweet musk of a woman touching herself in the dark. I know that smell. I've stood under her streetlamp with my cock hard in my trousers and my jaw locked, listening to her breathing change through the shutters, listening to her come, and then I've walked home.

I've never once gone in.

I tell myself it's the route. It isn't the route. The route goes along the canal and this house is a turn off it, and I take the turn, and I've never once written it down.

Tonight I stop at the gate.



Somebody stood on her step.

A man. Good shoes, thin soles, the kind that don't know what mud is. He came up the walk slowly and stopped at the second board, the one that gives, and he stayed on it. Weight on the left foot. Then the right. Then the left again.

He didn't knock.

He wanted her to hear the board and wonder. He stood there long enough for the worry to get into the rosemary.

Then he left, and he didn't hurry that either.

I know the shoes. I've been following those shoes around this city since the crowning, a step behind, and every time I get close he's been somewhere else first and left a door open behind him, polite as a wedding guest.

Absalom Cray has been on Ondine Marchand's porch.

I was on the other side of the canal, asking a man about a boat.

I was—

It doesn't matter where I was.



S he opens the kitchen door before I reach it.

"You're letting the cold in," she says.

"I haven't come in yet."

"You're letting it in from out there. I can feel you thinking at my porch." She stands aside. "In or out, Silas. The roux's at the stage where it'll burn if I look at it wrong."

I go in.

The kitchen is what it always is. Jars on every shelf, labeled in a hand I can read and a script I can't. Bundles hanging from the beams. The long table scarred with a hundred years of knives, and at the far end of it, a working half-finished under a cloth. Her cat is asleep on the sill in a patch of lamp and pretends I don't exist, which is the only courtesy I've ever had from a cat.

She goes back to the stove. She's barefoot. She's wearing a man's cardigan with holes in both elbows, and her hair is up in a knot with a pencil through it, and there's flour on her jaw she doesn't know about. Her nipples are hard against the wool. Her bare thighs flash

pale under the hem when she reaches for the salt, and I look at the stove instead.

She's forty-one. She looks thirty. She looks like she hasn't slept since the poison.

She looks like a woman I'd like to put on her own table. I'd like to push that cardigan off her shoulders and spread her thighs and find out whether her pussy tastes like the rosemary she burns. I've thought about her tits under that wool more nights than I'll ever admit. I've thought about her mouth. I've thought about her on her knees on these boards, and on her back on this table, and I've never touched her. Not once. Not a fucking finger.

"Sit," she says.

I don't sit.

"Suit yourself." She pours a cup from the pot at the back of the stove without turning around. Sets it at the end of the table where I always stand. Doesn't ask how I take it.

She's never once asked how I take it. She's never once been wrong.

I drink it.

//



"Somebody was on your step," I say.

Her spoon stops. Then it goes on stirring.

"Was somebody."

"Tonight. Before dark. He stood on the board that gives and waited for you to hear it."

"I heard it."

"You didn't open the door."

"I'm a witch, Silas. Not an idiot." She taps the spoon on the rim of the pot. "I heard a man stand on my step for as long as it takes to make a woman nervous, and then I heard him leave, and then I burned a great deal of rosemary."

"He left something."

She turns around.

"Under the mat," I say. "He crouched. The left knee. There's a mark in the dust where it went down."

She looks at me. Then she wipes her hands on a towel and walks past me, close enough that I have to turn my shoulder, and she opens the front door and bends and lifts the corner of the mat.

There's an envelope. Cream. Heavy stock. Sealed with wax, and pressed into the wax, a small neat mark I've never seen before.

She doesn't touch it.

"You picked it up with your eyes before I did," she says.

"Don't touch it with your hands."

"I wasn't going to touch it with my hands." She takes the tongs off the hook by the door. The fireplace tongs, iron, black with years of use. She lifts the envelope with them like a dead mouse and carries it back to the table and sets it down on the cloth over the working.

Then she looks at the seal and all the color goes out of her face.

"I know that mark," she says.



She opens it with a knife that has never cut food.

Inside, one page. I can read it upside down. I read everything upside down. It's the first thing you learn when you're standing behind a man at a desk.

The Marchand obligation falls due at the new moon. A. Cray, broker, will accept the stated collateral.

Under that, a copy of a signature. Old ink, a woman's hand, careful and upright. Just the surname. *Marchand*.

Under that, the collateral.

One word.

Ondine.

She reads it twice. Her mouth doesn't move. The roux on the stove starts to catch, a sweet burnt smell creeping in at the edge, and she doesn't turn around to save it.

I reach past her and take the pot off the heat.

"She signed my name," Ondine says. "She signed my name before I was born."

"Your grandmother."

"She put up my name as surety. For the line. For the debt. And then she died with it in a drawer and never told me." She laughs, badly. "You can use salt for bone, you know. If you have to. You can use bone for hair, at a pinch. There's nothing you can use for a name."

"Ondine."

"I brewed that poison to pay the interest on this." She puts the page down very carefully, like it might go off. "I didn't ask who it was for. I never ask. Not knowing was the only clean thing I had left in this house."

"I know."

"You *know*." Her eyes come up. "You've known since the day you walked in here with Lucian and a sick man's blood on his sleeve. You knew I made it. You sat at my table and drank my coffee and you knew."

"Yes."

"And you didn't take me in."

"No."

"Why not?"

I open my mouth.

I've been asked a lot of questions in two hundred years. I've answered most of them. The ones I haven't answered are about me.

"Because I—"

"It doesn't matter why," I say.

"It matters to *me*."

"It doesn't matter." I take the paper out of my coat. Mine, not his. Folded once, with my own hand on the front. "This does."



She reads it standing up.

I watch her read it. I watch her find the seal, the King's seal, the wax gone soft from three months in a coat pocket, and the signature

under it, which is Lucian's and still looks like it was written by a man with blood drying on his wrists. I watch her get to the line that says *the Marchand house and its keeper* and stop.

"A writ of protection," she says.

"Yes."

"Signed by the crown."

"Yes."

"How did you get the King of New Orleans to sign a writ of protection for the witch who poisoned him?"

"I asked."

She stares at me.

"You've never asked him for anything," she says slowly. "Everybody knows that. Aurelian bought you out of that — out of wherever you were — and you never once said thank you, and you never once asked, and you *asked him for this*."

"He didn't read it."

"Silas."

"He'd just killed his uncle. He'd have signed a laundry list."

"*Silas*."

I don't say anything else. I've already said more tonight than in the last month, and my throat feels like it's been used.

She puts the writ down beside Cray's letter. The two papers lie next to each other on the cloth. One of them takes her name. One of them is my name, put where it shouldn't go.

She looks at them for a long time.

Then she crosses the kitchen to me, barefoot on the boards, and stops in front of me.

She's close. I can smell the rosemary on her, and the roux, and under that just her. Clean skin. Flour. A woman who has been afraid all evening in her own house and is done being afraid.

She reaches up and takes my hand.

My right hand. The scarred one. She turns it over and looks at the palm, where the old burns are, the ones that never healed right because I was turned too soon after I got them. Nobody looks at that hand. I keep it in my coat.

She runs her thumb over the worst of the scars.

I don't move. I have stood still under a lot of things in my life. I've never stood this still. My cock is so hard it hurts. Her thumb is on my palm and every nerve still alive in that dead skin is standing up, and all I can think about is that thumb on my cock, her fist around me, her wet mouth, her thighs spread on this scarred table under the lamp.

"That'll cost," she says quietly. "You know that. A writ from the crown. It'll cost you with the court, and with him, and with whatever you are when you're not standing at the end of my table."

"I know."

"You spent your one favor on me."

"I had one." My voice does something I don't let it do. "I wasn't—"

"You weren't what?"

"Using it."

She smiles. It's small and tired and it goes straight through me.

"You're a terrible liar," she says.

"I'm an excellent liar."

"Not in my kitchen."

Her thumb stays on my palm.

I want her on her back on this table with her knees spread and her hips in my fists. I want to lick her until she's wet and shaking and coming on my tongue, and then fuck her until she forgets the man on her step. I want it so badly my throat aches.

I don't move.



The knock comes at the front door.

Three knocks. Even. Unhurried. The rhythm of a man who has already decided what the knocking means.

Her hand goes still in mine.

I know the knock. I've never heard it, and I know it. It's the knock of a man who could have walked in and chose not to, so that the choosing would be the first thing you learned about him.

The cat on the sill wakes up and flattens itself to the glass.

"That'll be him," Ondine says. Very calm. "He said the new moon. It isn't the new moon."

"He's early."

"He's never early. He's never anything but exactly on time."

"Then he's here for me."

She looks up at me. Her grip tightens on my hand.

"Stay behind me," I tell her.

"It's my house."

"Witch."

"It is my *house*, Silas Roche, and I have never once in my life stood behind a man in my own—"

"Tonight you do."

She holds my eyes. I watch her decide. I watch her not like it.

She lets go of my hand.

She steps behind me.

I cross the kitchen and put my palm flat on the front door and feel the man on the other side of it. Warm. Patient. Smiling, even through wood. Standing on the board that gives, and not shifting his weight at all.

I open the door.

Absalom Cray is on the step in a good coat and thin-soled shoes, holding a bottle of wine by the neck like a gift.

"Mr. Roche," he says, delighted. "I was so hoping you'd be here. It saves me a trip."

CHAPTER TWO



“

I won't ask to come in," Absalom Cray says. "Neutral ground has manners, and so do I."

He says it to Silas, pleasantly, from the second board of my porch, the one that gives. He's holding a bottle of wine by the neck as if it were a bouquet.

His shoes are the thinnest I've ever seen on a grown man. They're spotless, and it rained this afternoon.

I'm standing behind Silas Roche in my own kitchen doorway, and I hate every second of it.



I can see about a third of Cray past Silas's shoulder. Good coat, and silver at the temples, the expensive kind. A face so friendly I want to wash my hands after looking at it.

Nobody who stands on a witch's step at night with that much patience is friendly.

Silas doesn't move. He fills my doorway as a locked gate fills a fence line, and his right palm has gone into his coat pocket and stayed there.

"You're early," Silas says.

"I'm exactly on time for what I came to do. The collection is at the new moon." Cray inclines his head past him, to me. "Miss

Marchand. We've never been properly introduced, though I knew your grandmother. You have a look of her."

"Get off my step, broker."

"In a moment. I'd hate for there to be any confusion about the terms, and there so often is with old paper." He shifts his grip on the bottle. "The obligation falls due at the new moon, when the collateral is delivered. The collateral is your name, and with it every name your house holds. That's the whole of it."

"And if I don't deliver?"

"Then it's collected. No threat is meant, Miss Marchand. Paper simply does that."

He smiles.

"There is another way, of course. The obligation may be discharged by substitution. Any name at all, of equal weight, freely given."

He isn't looking at me when he says it.

He's looking at Silas, the whole time. Eyes steady and warm and interested, as if Silas were a house he'd been meaning to buy for years.

"And do tell Mr. Roche," Cray adds, still looking right at him, "that killing me only makes it someone else's paper. Someone much less agreeable than I am. I'd hate for him to go to the trouble."

Silas says nothing.

His silence fills the doorway better than he does.

"Well." Cray bends and sets the bottle on my top step, squared neatly to the edge. "For the kitchen. It's a good year. Goodnight, Miss Marchand. Goodnight, Mr. Roche."

He goes down my walk without hurrying. The board that gives creaks under him once, and then he's gone into the dark past the gate.

My lungs start working again. I hadn't noticed they'd stopped.

"Inside, witch," Silas says, without turning around.

"I *am* inside. It's my goddamn house."

He shuts the door.



He doesn't come back to the table. He goes to the window over the sink and stands to one side of it, reading the street.

I stand in the middle of my kitchen and try to think like my grandmother.

Butter for lard, lard for suet, honey for sugar if you don't mind it heavy. There's a substitute for nearly everything in a working, and for most things in a pot.

There's nothing you can use for a name.

That's the first rule she ever taught me.

I was sitting on this table with salt in my hair, small enough that my feet didn't reach the bench. She said it in the voice other grandmothers use for *don't touch the stove*. A name is the one thing that stands for itself.

And she signed mine away.

I try to picture her doing it.

Honorine Marchand at this table in the wet years, her chest rattling as it did at the end, every breath sounding like a roux about to catch. Did she hesitate? Did she think about me at all, or was I just a grocery item, a line on a page?

I'll never get to ask her. That's the part I can't fucking stand.

Out on my porch, a bottle of wine sits in the dark with a price I can't read written all over it.

"Pour it out," I say.

Silas is already moving.

He brings the bottle in and pulls the cork with his teeth and spits it into the sink. Then he upends the whole thing into the gutter outside my back door. The smell of it rolls back in on the night air, dark cherry and oak with pepper underneath.

"That'll cost," I tell him. "It was a good year."

"It was his year."

"It was still a good year. You just poured somebody's grandfather's vineyard into my gutter, and the slugs are going to be drunk for a week."

He looks at me. His jaw does its almost, the loosening that never turns into anything.

"Good," he says.



Here's what nobody in this city knows about me, and what I will never, ever tell him.

I've wanted Silas Roche for a year.

Not politely, and not in some *what a handsome enforcer the King keeps* way. I've wanted him like you want to eat straight off the stove, knowing you'll burn your mouth and not caring. He's been stopping at my kitchen door every night for a year, making up reasons. He stands at the end of my table with a coffee he never lets me see him enjoy. And every night when he leaves, I lock the door behind him and go to bed and fuck myself thinking about him.

Every single goddamn night. I'm a grown woman with a business and a cat, and I've been fingering myself raw over a man who won't sit down.

It's always his hand.

The right one, the scarred one, the one he keeps in his coat as if he stole it. I lie on my back with my knees spread and my nightgown shoved up to my tits. I think about the rough seams of those old burns dragging up the inside of my thigh.

I think about him not saying a word, because he never says a word. Just looking down at me while those ruined fingers spread me open. Reading my pussy the way he reads a street at night, working out exactly where it wants him to go.

I push two fingers inside myself and pretend they're his, thicker and rougher, curling exactly where I need them because he already read where I need them. I hear him tell me to hold still. I don't. When I come I come hard, thighs clamped on my own wrist, gasping his name into the pillowcase so the cat won't hear it.

The cat hears it. The cat always hears it.

It's pathetic. As of tonight, it's also the least of my fucking problems.

Because tonight he walked into my kitchen with a writ from the crown in his coat and gave it to me. I took that scarred hand and turned it over and ran my thumb across the palm. He stood stiller than I've ever seen a living thing stand.

He carried that paper for a whole season and never said a word.

What does a man like that want, if he doesn't want what I want?



He's too close.

He's come back from the window and he's standing right behind me at the counter while I scrape the burnt roux out of the pot.

He doesn't touch me. He's close enough that I can feel the cool coming off him through the back of my cardigan. Vampires don't give off heat. He gives off weight instead, the feeling of being stood beside by a wall that's decided to guard you.

My nipples are hard under the wool, and I'd rather die than let him see it.

"You'll come to the King's house," he says.

"No."

"Ondine."

"No." I scrape harder. "This house is neutral ground. That's what's kept it standing between the canal and the bayou since before the Code. I walk into the King's house, I'm a Croix witch. Then every wolf who ever paid me for a working wants to know what I told the vampires."

"Cray was on your step."

"Cray was on my *step*. He didn't come in. He said so himself, neutral ground has manners."

I put the spoon down.

"Shit, Silas, think. My ledger lives in this house. My clients' names live on those shelves. If I run, I leave all of it for him to walk in and pick up like groceries."

"And if you stay, he collects you."

"Then I'll be collected at home. In my own kitchen. With my own shit around me."

He doesn't answer. His palm goes to the inside pocket of his coat, where the writ lived, and pats it once, and finds it empty.

I watch him realize it. I watch him not know what to do with his hand now.

He's been touching that paper every time he's worried. It's been his rosemary.

I want to turn around and put my mouth on his throat so badly my teeth ache. I want to climb him like the pantry shelves. I want to take that scarred hand out of his pocket and put it back where it lives in my head, between my legs. I want to find out whether the real thing is anything like the one I've been making up.

I don't. I have a debt collector and a dead grandmother and a pot of burnt roux. I am not going to climb the King's enforcer in my kitchen the night I find out I've been sold.

Probably not. Jesus. Probably.



He takes a folded page out of his other pocket and lays it on my table.

He doesn't explain it. He puts it down, unfolded, on the cloth beside Cray's letter and the writ, and steps back as if it might bite.

It's a column of names. A different one on every line, in different handwriting, in a pattern that makes my skin prickle. Every one of them is written over the same account.

"What is that?"

"What I asked my king for," he says. "This morning."

"What does it mean?"

He looks at the window.

I've known him a year. I know that look now. It means *I'm not going to tell you that*, and it means it very kindly.

"I'm going to walk your fence," he says. "Lock the door."

"It's my door."

"Lock your door," he says, and goes out into the dark.



I don't lock the door.

I wait until I hear his boots go around the side of the house, slow and careful, reading every inch of my fence line. Then I kneel in front of the old stove. I work my fingers into the gap beside the third brick from the bottom, and I pull.

It comes out stiff and gritty with a century of soot. Behind it is my grandmother's ledger. She told me where it was the week before she died, and made me swear never to touch it.

Small. Bound in black leather gone soft as skin, with a brass clasp.

I put my thumb on the clasp.

The ward bites.

It's sharp and fast and it draws blood, a bright bead on the pad of my thumb, and the clasp doesn't give. It knows me. It tasted me and said no.

My grandmother warded her ledger against Marchand blood.

Against *me*.

Why? Who was she keeping it for, if she was keeping it from me?

I sit back on my heels on the kitchen floor with my thumb in my mouth and the taste of my own blood on my tongue. Outside, Silas is walking my fence line, reading the dark, trying to keep me safe from a paper he doesn't know the half of.

Well, shit.

I put the ledger back behind the brick.

I don't tell him.

CHAPTER THREE



I walk her fence line twice before midnight, and both times I end up at her kitchen door.



The first time around, I read the walk.

Cray came up it slowly, as a man comes up a walk he already owns. His thin soles barely marked the gravel, but gravel shifts, and every stone he moved is still lying a little wrong. He stopped at the gate. He stopped again at the second board of the step, the one that gives, and he rocked on it, left and right and left, so she'd hear it through the wall.

Then he turned his head.

I can see where. There's a scuff at the heel of his left print, a quarter turn toward the canal road. He wasn't looking at her door. He was watching the road behind him, the patch of sidewalk under the streetlamp, where I stop every night and pretend I'm not stopping.

He was looking at my shadow.

He came to her step and made her wait and burned her rosemary for her, and the whole time the bastard was looking at me.

Why? He has her name on a paper and her body behind a door. What the fuck does he want with mine?

The second time around, I don't read anything. I walk, and I end up at her kitchen door, and her light is still on.

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It's past one when I knock.

"It's open," she says. "It's always open. That's the whole problem, apparently."

She's at the long table with the working uncovered in front of her: sprigs and twine, a saucer of salt, a bone needle, a spool of red thread. She hasn't touched any of it. She's sitting with her elbows on the wood and her chin on her fists, staring at it as if it's a dish she's forgotten the recipe for.

She's still in the cardigan with the holes in the elbows, and a pair of cotton sleep shorts. The pencil is gone from her hair. It's down around her shoulders, dark and heavier than I thought it would be.

"You walked my fence twice," she says.

"Yes."

"I heard you both times." She doesn't look up. "Did it tell you anything?"

"He was watching the road."

"The road."

"The spot where I stand."

That makes her look up.

I'm at the end of the table, where I always stand. She hasn't asked me to sit since the first night, and I've never sat. There's a cup at my place. She poured it before I knocked.

Of course she fucking did.

"He came for you," she says slowly.

"He came for the paper. He looked at me."

"With a man like him, that's the same thing. You heard him. *Any name at all.*" She sits back, and the cardigan slides off one shoulder, and she doesn't fix it. "So which is it, Silas? Are you here to guard me or arrest me?"

"Neither."

"Then what are you for, Silas Roche?"

I open my mouth.

"I'm—"

Two hundred years of questions, and this one is sitting in her kitchen with its hair down.

"It doesn't matter," I say.

"It matters to me."

She stands up.



She comes around the table without hurrying, a woman who knows where every board in her kitchen is. She stops in front of me and holds out her palm.

"Give it to me."

"Ondine."

"The right one. The one you keep in your coat. Give it."

I take my fist out of my coat and open it, and I feel like a fool doing it.

She takes it by the wrist and turns it over as she did at dusk, palm up, the old burns pale and roped in the lamplight. She studies it for a long time. Then she runs her thumb across the worst of the scar, slow, and every nerve still alive in that palm stands up and pays attention.

"You've been coming to my door every night for a year," she says. "You think I don't know? You take the turn off the canal. You stop at the gate. Some nights you come in and drink my coffee, and some nights you don't, and either way you walk home at dawn like a man who lost his keys in my yard."

I say nothing. I don't have one fucking true thing to say that I can finish.

"I've wanted this for a year," she says, and her thumb presses into my palm. "On me. In me. Every night you walk out that door, I lie in bed and think about it, and I'm not ashamed of it anymore."

My whole body goes still.

"Tonight a man stood on my step and sold me," she says. "I'm done waiting. So arrest me or finish me."

She lifts my scarred palm and presses it flat to her breast, over the cardigan.



She's warm.

That's the first thing. Christ, she's warm. The heat of her comes through the wool into the dead tissue of my palm, and it's more than the burns have felt since the fire.

The second thing is her heart. It's going hard and fast under my palm, and I know that rhythm. I've read it in the chests of men I've run to ground, and this isn't fear.

It's want. She wants this. She wants me.

"Say something," she says. "Anything."

I don't. I push the cardigan off her other shoulder instead, and it falls down her arms and catches at her elbows, and she's bare under it.

I look at her.

I spend a long time looking. I read before I move. I always have.

Her tits are full and heavy, her nipples dark and already hard in the cool of the kitchen. A flush is climbing her chest and up her throat into her face. There's a faint smudge of flour in the crease under one breast, where she brushed the counter. She smells of rosemary and burnt roux and warm skin, and under all of it, rising now, the sharp sweet smell of her getting wet.

I know that smell on her. I've caught it on the air at the end of this table more nights than I'll ever admit. I've walked home with it in my coat.

"Silas. Please. You're looking at me like I'm evidence."

I close my scarred palm over her breast. The rough seams of the burns drag across her nipple, and she gasps, and her fingers dig into my wrist.

"Yes," she says. "God, yes, like that. Harder."

I squeeze harder. I roll her nipple between my thumb and the side of my finger, and she arches into it, and her mouth falls open.

"Now the other one," she breathes. "Don't you dare neglect the other one."



She backs up until she hits the table and sits on the edge of it, beside the working, the bone needle and the red thread by her hip. She spreads her knees and pulls me in between them by the wrist.

Then she takes my scarred palm and guides it down her belly, under the waistband of her sleep shorts.

"Here," she says. "This one. Not the good one. I want this one."

Her pussy is soaked.

She's slick and hot against the dead skin of my palm, so wet my fingers slide through her with no resistance at all. I can feel her more than I've felt anything this palm has touched since the fire: the heat, the wet, the swollen give of her.

She makes a sound low in her throat, ragged, and her thighs press in on either side of my wrist.

"Slower," she says. "Slower. You're not tracking me, you're—oh."

I find her clit.

She doesn't have to tell me where. I've been reading her for a year. Her breath changes the second I touch it, catches and stutters, and her hips roll up into my palm on their own.

"Oh. Oh, fuck. There. Don't move. No, move. Move exactly like that."

I move exactly like that.

I circle her clit with the rough pad of my middle finger, slow and tight, and she drops her head back and stares up at the ceiling beams and pants. Her fingers grip the table edge. The saucer of salt rattles against the wood.

"Take them off," she says. "The shorts. I want to see you do it."

I take them off. I drag them down her thighs and off her ankles and let them fall on the floor, and she sits spread on her grandmother's table in the lamplight, naked except for the cardigan

caught at her elbows, her pussy flushed and glistening and open for me.

I look at that too, for a long time, and it's the most beautiful fucking thing I've ever read.

"You're doing it again," she says, breathless. "The looking."

"Yes."

"It's the filthiest thing anyone's ever done to me and you haven't even— Silas. *Please.*"

I put my scarred palm back where it was.

"Inside," she begs. "Put them inside me. Two. Now."

I push two fingers into her.

She's tight around them, hot and wet and gripping, and she swears, long and loud and filthy, and her heels hook behind my knees and drag me closer. I curl my fingers and feel for it, as I'd feel for a trail gone cold in wet grass, and I find it: the rough swollen spot inside her that makes her whole body jerk.

"There. There, there, *there*—"

"Look at me, witch."

She looks at me.

Her eyes are wet and black and wide. Her mouth is open. She's grinding on my palm, riding my fingers, her pussy clenching around them every time I drag them out and push back in. My thumb stays on her clit and I don't let up.

"Tell me how," I say.

"Your fingers," she pants. "Deeper. Fuck my pussy with them. Rub my clit with your thumb while you do it. Don't you dare stop till I come all over your hand."

"Keep telling me."

She laughs, shaky, as if nobody has ever asked. "Faster. Deeper. Curl them. Yes. Keep your thumb right there, don't you move it, don't you *dare*—"

Her knee knocks the saucer.

Salt goes everywhere: across the working, across the table, down the front of her bare thigh. She looks down at it and starts to laugh, a helpless, breathless, ridiculous laugh with my fingers buried in her.

Without stopping, without even looking, she pinches a little of it off the wood and throws it over her left shoulder.

"You don't waste spilled salt," she gasps. "Not in this house. Oh, God, don't stop, I'm laughing, don't you dare stop—"

I don't stop.

I fuck her with my fingers through the laughing until the laughing breaks, and then she's only breathing, hard and high and fast, her thighs trembling around me and her wet dripping down my wrist.

"Silas. Silas, I'm going to come—"

"I know."

"Don't let go of me."

"I've got you."

She comes on my fingers.

It goes through her from the inside out. I feel it before I hear it. Her pussy clamps down on my fingers in hard rhythmic pulses, her clit jumps under my thumb, and her whole body locks and then shakes. She throws her head back and cries out at the ceiling beams. Her heels dig into the backs of my legs, and her nails leave marks in my wrist.

I hold her through it. I don't move my palm. I watch her face come apart and put itself back together: the flush on her throat, the wet shine of her mouth, the tremor in her thighs. I read every piece of it, and I keep every piece.

"Again," I say.

She stares at me. "What?"

"Again."

"You're out of your fucking mind, I can't—"

I curl my fingers, slow, right where she's swollen and tender, and press my thumb down on her clit, and her protest turns into a whimper halfway through.

"Oh," she says. "Oh. Okay. I can."

She comes a second time faster than the first, grinding down onto my fingers with both palms braced on the table and her head dropped forward onto my shoulder. She sobs into my coat. Her

pussy pulses around me until it's too much, and she clamps her thighs shut on my wrist to make me stop.

I stop.



When she can breathe again, she reaches for my belt.

"No."

Her fingers stop on the buckle. She looks up at me, hazy and startled.

"You're hard," she says. "I can see it. I can feel it against my knee, Silas, don't you tell me you're not—"

"I know what I am."

"Then let me touch you. Let me put my mouth on you. Let me do something, I want—"

"Not—"

I stop.

Not tonight, with Cray's fucking shoes still printed on her step and her grandmother's paper lying open on her table. Not with her so frightened she threw salt over her shoulder with my fingers inside her. Not while I don't know what that bastard wants from me.

Not until I know what I'm for.

None of it comes out. It never does.

"Not—" I say again, and let it go.

She studies me for a long moment. I don't know what she reads. She reads too. It's a different kind of reading from mine, but it's reading.

Then she takes her fingers off my belt and lays her palm flat on my chest instead.

"All right," she says quietly. "All right. Not."

I ease my fingers out of her. She shivers. They're wet to the knuckle, and I don't wipe them. I don't know what I'm supposed to do with them.

She takes my scarred palm in both of hers and turns it over and looks at it, slick and shining with her.

"Well," she says. "It's not a gun. But I'll count it."

◆ ◆ ◆

She makes coffee afterward.

She doesn't bother with the cardigan. She stands at the stove bare to the waist with her hair down her back and salt still stuck to her thigh, and she grinds the beans and heats the water and pours. She sets the cup at the end of the table, at my place.

She doesn't ask how I take it. She never has.

I drink it standing up.

She sits on the edge of the table again, sipping from her own cup, one bare foot swinging, and watches me over the rim. There's a mark on my wrist from her nails. There's salt on the floor by my boot, where she threw it over her shoulder for luck.

"Walk my fence again before you go," she says.

"I will."

"And Silas."

"What?"

"Next time you can finish your sentence," she says, "or you can finish me. I'm not particular which."

◆ ◆ ◆

Iwalk the fence a third time before dawn.

The prints are where I left them. His, thin and clean and patient, stopping at the gate, rocking on the board, turning a quarter turn toward the road to find the place where I stand.

How long has the bastard been watching me stand there?

I stand under the streetlamp, in the exact spot he looked at, and I turn and face her house. Her light goes out.

I have until the new moon. So does she.

Only one of us knows what Cray was looking at.

CHAPTER FOUR



I 've had three men in my kitchen in my life who didn't want something from me, and two of them were plumbers.

The third one left before dawn to go and see his king. He left a clean cup upside down on the drainboard, and a pinch of salt on the floor where I threw it over my shoulder with his fingers inside me. I haven't swept it up yet, and I'm not going to examine why.



I don't sleep.

I lie in bed until the light comes gray through the shutters, with my thighs pressed together and the ache between them still sweet and sore, and I think about his fingers until I want to scream.

God help me, I think about nothing else.

The scarred one inside me, rough where the burns healed wrong, curling up into me as though he'd drawn a map of my body and memorized it on the walk over. His thumb on my clit, steady and merciless, never losing the rhythm while I bucked and swore and threw salt around my kitchen as if I'd lost my mind. His voice, low, telling me to look at him.

Look at me, witch.

And his face while I came. Watching me as he watches a road, taking notes on every inch of me.

I roll onto my side and press the heel of my palm between my legs, just to feel it, and I'm swollen and tender and already getting wet again at the memory. I can still feel exactly where he was. I can feel the shape of his two fingers in me like a bruise I want to keep pressing.

He made me come twice on his hand, the second time on command, one word. *Again*. And my body just did it, a trained dog hearing its name. Jesus wept.

Then he wouldn't let me touch him.

I could feel his cock through his trousers the whole time, hard as a fence post against the inside of my knee. I wanted it so badly I would have gotten down on the kitchen floor. I would have sucked him off right there on my grandmother's boards with the cat watching and the salt everywhere and not been sorry for one second.

Not—

Not what, Silas? Not tonight, not me, not ever?

I last about four breaths of that before I give up.

I shove my underwear down to my knees and put two fingers straight into my pussy, still slick from last night and swollen from him. I don't bother being gentle. I don't bother with a fantasy, either. I just hear his voice.

Again.

That's all it takes. One word from a man who isn't even in the room, and I come in about a minute flat, toes curled against the footboard, swearing at the ceiling like a sailor with a stubbed toe.

Fuck. Fuck him. Fuck him and his *again*.

The cat, from the foot of the bed, sighs.

I've had men. I'm not a nun, for Christ's sake. I've had men with more experience than sense, and men with more sense than rhythm, and one very enthusiastic sous-chef from Lafayette who thought the clit was a rumor. None of them ever looked at me as if I were worth reading twice.

I get up and make coffee for one, and it tastes wrong.



By eight I'm on my knees in front of the stove again, with the brick out and the ledger in my lap.

I don't touch the clasp. I've learned that lesson, and the pad of my thumb is still tender from last night's bite. I just hold the book and look at it and try to think as she taught me to think.

Substitution. What stands in for what.

A ward against Marchand blood means my grandmother wanted this book shut to anyone with her blood in their veins. My mother, if she'd lived long enough to go looking. Me. Any cousin who came sniffing around after the house.

But a ward against one thing is always a ward *for* another. You don't lock a door unless you're keeping the room for somebody. That's the first week of learning to ward, the week you burn your fingers on hot wax and cry and she makes you do it again anyway.

She wanted it read. Just not by us.

So who did Honorine Marchand trust more than her own granddaughter, and why the hell didn't she leave me a goddamn note?

I put the ledger back behind the brick. I sweep up the salt after all. I'm still furious about it when the knock comes.



It's Isabeau Vale, and she's early.

She comes every other week for the tea, a blend I make for her with lemon balm and valerian and one more ingredient I don't write down. She sits in the same chair every time, by the window, with her gloves in her lap. She's small and pale and very straight-backed, with the kind of old-court manners that make you check your own posture.

Her father is dead. Her father was Cassian Vale. I've never once mentioned it, she's never once raised it, and that's our arrangement.

"Good morning, Ondine."

"Morning. Sit. The kettle's on."

She sits. She pulls off her gloves, finger by finger, and lays them in her lap, and her eyes go around my kitchen out of habit: the

shelves, the working covered again under its cloth, the table.

The envelope.

Cray's envelope is still lying on the table where I left it, cream stock, the wax seal cracked but still clinging to the flap.

Isabeau goes still.

She doesn't gasp or clutch at anything. She just stops, all at once and completely, as a clock stops. Her eyes are on the seal. Then they drop to the floor between her shoes, and they stay there.

"Isabeau?"

"The usual," she says to the floor. "If you'd be so kind."

I make it slowly, watching her out of the corner of my eye, and she doesn't lift her gaze once. When I set the cup down in front of her, her fingers are steady on the saucer, and the tea shivers anyway.

"You know that seal," I say.

She doesn't answer. She drinks half the cup in small careful sips. Then she stands, pulls her gloves back on, and picks up her bag.

"Thank you, Ondine. It was lovely, as always."

"The kettle's still hot."

"I've just remembered an appointment." She looks at me then, finally, with her father's gray eyes. "Please be careful who you let on your step."

She leaves early, and she leaves the tea half-drunk, and behind her she leaves a smell I've never caught on her before: fear, thin and sour, under the valerian.

I stand in my kitchen and stare at the door she went out.



At eleven I get a client I don't want.

She's a pretty human girl from Uptown with expensive highlights and a boyfriend who's stopped texting back. She sits in Isabeau's chair and cries into a tissue and tells me the whole story, and I pour her a cup of chamomile and let her get to the point.

"I want a love working," she says finally. "Whatever it costs. I just want him to want me again."

"No."

She blinks at me. "I can pay."

"I know you can pay, honey. That isn't the problem." I sit down across from her. "You can't use anything for wanting. There's no substitute for it. I can make a man notice you. I can make him think about you at odd hours. I can make him regret you so bad his teeth hurt. I can't make him want you. Nobody can. Not me, not the vampires, not God himself."

"Then what's the point of you?"

I laugh. I can't help it.

"That's a very good question," I tell her. "I asked a man the same thing last night, and he didn't have an answer either."

I send her away with a cup of tea in her hand and a working for sleep, the kind that costs a single bad dream. She pays it without asking what it is. They never ask.

I think about wanting for the rest of the afternoon.

About how you can't manufacture it. About how he stood between my knees with his cock straining against his trousers and his fingers dripping with me and still said *not*. That should feel like being turned down. It doesn't. It feels like watching a man hold back a flood with both arms and his teeth.

What would it take to make him let go?

◆ ◆ ◆

My phone buzzes at two.

Did you sleep.

No question mark. Of course there's no question mark. He texts as he talks, as if every letter costs him money.

No, I type. Your fault.

A long pause. The dots appear and disappear, and then appear again.

I'm sorry.

Don't be. I'm not. I bite my lip and type the rest before I can stop myself. *I'm still sore. I can still feel exactly where your fingers were. I had to change my underwear twice this morning because I kept thinking about how you made me come on command.*

The dots come and go and come and go. Then nothing, for a full minute.

Then: *Ondine*.

Just my name. I stare at it on the screen, and my whole body goes hot from the scalp down.

What, I type. You started this. You're the one who put your hand in my shorts on my grandmother's table and then wouldn't let me touch your cock.

I'm in the King's library.

So?

Lucian is across the table.

Then don't read your phone at the table, Silas Roche. It's rude.

Another long pause.

You wanted my hand, he writes. You had it. Tonight you'll behave.

I laugh out loud, alone in my kitchen, and the cat looks at me with open contempt.

Make me, I write. Then I put the phone face down on the counter and leave it there all afternoon, and it's the longest afternoon of my life.

When I finally turn it over, there's one message.

I will.

I have to sit down on the kitchen floor. Holy shit.



He comes back at dusk.

I hear him at the gate. I know his step now, heavy but careful, as if the ground might be holding something he needs to read. He comes up the walk and doesn't stop on the second board, because he always steps over it. There's a leather bag over his shoulder, old and scarred like everything else he owns.

I meet him at the kitchen door with a wooden spoon in my fist and my heart going stupid in my chest.

"What's that?"

"A bag."

"I can see it's a bag, Silas. What the hell is it doing on my porch?"

He doesn't answer. He sets it down on the boards, and then he steps up into the doorway with me, so close that I have to tip my head back to keep looking at him.

He doesn't touch me. He puts one palm flat on the doorframe beside my head and leans in, slow, until his mouth is at my temple, and he breathes in.

He's smelling me.

"You changed them a third time," he says, very low. "At noon. You're wet right now."

Jesus Christ.

My knees actually wobble. The spoon shakes in my fist. I can feel exactly how wet I am, slick and hot against the cotton, and he can smell every drop of it, and he's standing in my doorway reading me like tracks in a flowerbed, and he still hasn't laid one finger on me.

"That's not fair," I whisper.

"No."

"You said I'd behave."

"You will." He draws back just far enough to look at me. His eyes have gone dark at the center. "So will I."

He looks past me into my kitchen: at the shelves, at the table where he made me come twice last night, at the swept floor where the salt used to be. Then he looks back at me.

"I'm taking the guest room," he says.

"The one with the lock?"

"The lock's on the inside, witch."

He picks up his bag and walks past me into my house.

I stand in the doorway holding my spoon. I have no idea whether I've just been protected or threatened.

I'm so turned on I could scream.

CHAPTER FIVE



I lie to my king before breakfast, and he watches me do it.



Lucian takes reports in the small study now, not the big one. He says the big one still smells of his uncle.

It doesn't. I've been in both, and the big one smells of beeswax and old leather and nothing else, but I don't tell him so. A man is allowed to decide which rooms are haunted.

Selene is in the window seat with her knees drawn up and a cup of coffee going cold on the sill beside her. She doesn't pretend she isn't listening. She never does. It's one of the few things about her that I've always liked without effort.

"Tell me," Lucian says.

I tell him.

The envelope under the mat. The seal. Absalom Cray on the step with a bottle of wine, polite as a wedding guest. The Marchand obligation, falling due at the new moon. The collateral: a name of weight, pledged by Honorine Marchand before she died.

I tell him the terms. I tell him that the paper can't be broken by killing the man who holds it, that it passes up to whatever sits above him. I tell him the moon is thinner every night.

I don't tell him whose name it is.

I don't tell him that Cray looked at me the whole time he said *any name at all, of equal weight*. I don't tell him about my scarred palm between her thighs on her grandmother's table, or that I've moved a bag into her guest room, or that I'd put my own name on that paper before breakfast if I thought it would take hers off.

I give him the debt, and I give him Cray, and I give him the moon, and I keep the rest.

Lucian listens without moving. He's very good at that. He was very good at it before the crown, and he's better now.

When I'm done, he lets the quiet sit.

"Whose name?" he says.

"The Marchand line's."

"That's not a name, Silas. That's a family."

"It's what the paper says."

He looks at me. Selene, in the window, takes a sip of her cold coffee and says nothing at all.

I look at the window.

I don't mean to. I never mean to. My eyes go to the glass behind Selene's shoulder, to the courtyard, to the plane tree and the bench and the gray morning, and they stay there a beat too long.

"You looked at the window," Lucian says.

My jaw goes tight.

He's learned it. Of course he's learned it. I've been standing at his shoulder for years, and I taught him half of what he knows about reading a room, and somewhere along the way he turned it around and started reading me.

He could push. He's the King, God help us all. He could order it out of me, and I'd have to decide whether I'm still the kind of man who obeys that order.

He doesn't push.

"You asked me for a week once," he says instead, very low. "When all this started. You said you were still confirming a name, and you asked for a week. I didn't notice. I should have."

"Sire—"

He leans back in his chair. "Keep your window, Silas. For now. But you'll tell me before the moon goes dark."

"Yes."

"Say it like you mean it."

"I'll tell you before the moon goes dark."

It's true, and incomplete, and exactly what I do.

In the window seat, Selene sets down her cup, and for one second her eyes meet mine. She's a translator. She spent years hearing the difference between what a man says and what he means in three languages, and I watch her hear the grammar of what I just left out.

She doesn't say a word. She just looks at me, and then back out at the courtyard, and I'm more grateful to her than I'll ever find a way to say.



//

The account," Lucian says. "You asked for it. It's yours. What do you need?"

"Tobias. The registry. And the Roche brothers, when I need doors watched."

"Done." He pulls a folder across the desk and opens it. On top is Bastien's list. The money trail, in Bastien's cramped slanting hand: the shipping account, the two sideways moves, the broker. Three names. A company, a dead woman, and Cray.

Bastien wrote it the week he died in a doorway.

I put his hands down after. I folded them on his chest, because nobody else was going to and because he'd have hated lying there with them flung out as if he'd been surprised.

He was never surprised by anything. He was surprised by that.

"He'd want to know where it goes," Lucian says, watching me look at it.

"He'd want to know who."

"Then find out who."

I close the folder.



Tobias Vale keeps the court registry in three rooms under the east wing, and all three of them smell of paper and lamp oil and very strong tea.

He's small and neat and precise, with ink on the side of his middle finger and a pair of spectacles he doesn't need, and he writes the smallest hand I've ever seen. He spent a whole month last season organizing the evidence against his own cousin without once putting his name on it. I respect that more than he'll ever know.

"The Bywater firm," he says, before I've finished asking. "Yes. I pulled it the day the King gave you the account." He slides a folder across the table to me. "It's a holding firm. One brass plate, one clerk, one partner who died before the war and still signs the annual filings."

"How?"

"Somebody signs for him. Beautifully." He taps the charter. "Look here. And here."

I look. The charter is old, thick paper, much handled. There are places along the margins where the text is faintly different, the ink a shade too fresh, the letters a fraction too careful.

"It's been mended," Tobias says. "Badly. By someone in a hurry. Somebody took out a clause and wrote a new one in, very recently, and tried to make it look old." He sits back, and his mouth goes thin with something close to offense. "It's shoddy work. Whoever did it has never had to hurry before and didn't know how."

"When?"

"Within the year. Probably within the season." He pushes his useless spectacles up his nose. "And the firm has exactly one other client on the books."

"Daniel Ward's estate."

"You knew."

"I knew."

I push the folder back to him. "The King knew. Selene knew. Nobody's known what it means."

“Well,” Tobias says, “it means somebody’s been paying for things through that firm for a very long time, and something has recently frightened them into mending their paperwork.” He hesitates. “Be careful with it, Silas. Old paper bites.”



I watch the firm for the rest of the day.

It’s on a side street in Bywater, a narrow two-story building painted the color of dried mud, with a brass plate by the door so polished it’s nearly unreadable. I stand across the street in the shade of a live oak and read everyone who goes in or out.

Not many do.

A mail carrier at ten. A delivery boy with a box of printer paper at noon. The clerk, at one, going out for a sandwich and coming back with a paper bag and a coffee: middle-aged, sensible shoes, a man who’s been told very little and has decided to want to know less.

And at four, nobody. But there’s a mark on the step.

I cross the street when the clerk’s gone back in and crouch by the door as if I’m tying my boot. A print, faint, on the worn stone. A narrow sole, very thin, pressed into a smear of damp from the gutter.

Thin-soled. Patient. Somebody stood on this step and rocked, left and right and left, and waited for something.

Cray has been here today.

Or someone with his shoes has, and I like that thought even less.

Who the fuck is the account, and why now? What did Honorine Marchand buy with her granddaughter’s name? And what does a broker want with a man who’s already been sold once?

I don’t have one answer. I stand up, and the step creaks under me, and I walk home to a house that isn’t mine.



She’s asleep at the table when I get back.

Her head is down on her folded arms beside the working, uncovered again, the red thread half-wound around the bone needle. Her hair has come loose across her cheek.

The lamp is still lit. There's a cup of coffee at the end of the table, at my place, cold, with a skin on it.

She poured it for me hours ago and then fell asleep waiting.

I stand in the doorway and look at that cup for longer than I'd like to admit.

Then I go to her. I slide one arm under her knees and one behind her back, and I lift her out of the chair. She's warm and heavy with sleep, and she makes a small annoyed sound and turns her face into my coat.

She's wearing a thin cotton nightgown, the kind that goes see-through when the lamp's behind it, and nothing under it. I can feel the whole warm length of her through it: the weight of her tits against my chest, the curve of her hip in the crook of my arm, the soft bare backs of her thighs over my forearm.

I can smell her. Rosemary and sleep and the faint sweet musk of her skin, and under that, fainter, from this morning, the smell of her own fingers.

I know what she did this morning. I knew it the moment I walked into her kitchen at dusk. I stood in that doorway and smelled it on her, and I held the doorframe instead of her.

I carry her down the hall.

"Silas," she mumbles into my collar.

"Go back to sleep."

"You're home."

I don't answer that. I don't know how.

I lay her down in her bed. I pull the sheet up to her waist. Her nightgown has ridden up her thighs, and I pull it down, carefully, with two fingers, and I don't look at what I'm covering.

That's a lie. I look. I look at the dark shadow of her pussy through the thin white cotton, at the soft curve of her belly, at her nipples pushing hard against the fabric in the cool air.

I know what she tastes like on my fingers. I've never tasted her from the source.

I stand there and think about it in detail: spreading her thighs on this bed, putting my tongue in her until she wakes up coming. My cock has more opinions about that than I do. I'm standing in her bedroom in my coat with my fists at my sides, and I want to climb in beside her and push that nightgown up to her throat and put my mouth on every inch I just covered.

Her eyes open, slitted, drowsy.

"You could stay," she says. "You could get in. I wouldn't mind. I'd mind if you didn't."

"Ondine."

"You smell like outside." She reaches out and hooks two fingers in my belt. "Come here. Let me take care of that. I can feel it from here, you know."

"No."

"Why not?"

I don't have a sentence for why not. I have a paper with her name on it and a man who wants mine, and a king I lied to at breakfast. None of it goes into words.

I take her fingers off my belt, gently, and put her hand back on the sheet, and hold it there a moment longer than I have to.

"Sleep, witch."

"You're a terrible man," she mumbles, already drifting.

"I know."

She's asleep again before I reach the door.

I stand in her hallway with my back to the wall for a long while, breathing when I don't need to, until my body agrees to stand down.



I check the step before I go to bed. I always check the step.

There are prints on it.

Fresh ones. Thin soles, very clean, pressed into the dew on the second board, the one that gives.

Left, right, left. Somebody stood here tonight while I was across the city reading a brass plate, and rocked on that board, and waited, and she slept through it.

And on the top step, squared neatly to the edge, is a bottle of wine.

Same label. Same year. The one I poured into her gutter last night.

It's full.

The polite motherfucker replaced it.

INTERSTITIAL

Cray



I did not come early for her.

The witch was never in doubt. The witch has been promised since before she had teeth, and a promised thing keeps. I could have left the envelope under her mat and gone home to my tea.

The moon would have done the rest, and the paper would have been perfectly content.

I came early for him.

I have stood at the end of that canal road on more nights than I would like to confess to anyone with a sense of proportion. There is a live oak on the corner with a root that heaves the sidewalk, and if you stand behind it in a dark coat, the streetlamp does not find you. I found it the first week. I have been fond of it ever since.

From behind that oak, I have watched Silas Roche take the turn off the canal.

Every night. Every single night. In rain and in the wet heat and in the week of the crowning, when the whole court was drunk and he was the only sober man in the city.

He comes along the canal at the pace of a man with somewhere to be, and at the turn he slows, and he takes it, and he stops under the lamp at the witch's gate and he stands there.

He does not go in, most nights. He stands. He looks at her kitchen window. Then he goes on.

I have introduced a great many people to a great many things.

I know what a man looks like when he is standing at the door of the thing he wants and has not been introduced.



The instruction I was given names the witch.

Only the witch. It is a very short instruction, as they always are, written on good paper in a hand that has never once hurried. The Marchand name and every name her house holds, delivered at the new moon. Nothing more is asked of me. Nothing more is ever asked.

I could deliver exactly that, and be thanked, and go home.

I find I would rather not.

It is a great deal to know that a principal exists, and to serve, and to be permitted into the correspondence, and never once to be told the intention behind the letters.

One does not complain. I have never complained. But one notices, over a very long career, that the people who are only ever useful are the first to be set down when they stop.

Is that disloyal? I prefer to call it thrift. A man should have something in his pocket that belongs to nobody else.

A King's enforcer, freely given, would be a lovely thing to have in one's pocket.



He poured my wine into her gutter.

I watched him do it from the oak. He pulled the cork with his teeth and upended the bottle into the drain behind her kitchen, and the witch stood in the doorway and said something that made his jaw move.

Was I offended? Not in the least. A refused gift is simply a gift owed. It sits on the ledger between people like a door left ajar, and

sooner or later one of them has to decide whether to close it.

So I sent for another bottle of the same, and I carried it up her walk myself while he was across the city reading my step on the firm's doorstone. I stood on the board that gives, until I was quite sure she was asleep and would not come to the door. I set the bottle where the first had stood, squared to the edge.

I did not knock. Knocking is for people who expect an answer.



Tonight I sat in my front room with the lamp low and chose the evening.

That is the whole of my art, really. Anyone can make an offer. The skill is in choosing the evening on which the offer will be heard as a kindness.

It will not be tomorrow. Tomorrow he is angry about the bottle, and an angry man hears a threat in everything.

It will not be the night he beds her, either. A man is very generous that night, and very stupid, and he would give me his name for the asking and hate me for it by morning. I have no use for a gift that curdles.

No. I will wait for the evening he finds out what he is, on paper, in a clerk's brown ink. The evening he learns who stood at the edge of the pen.

That evening, a man is very lonely. That evening, he will want to be told he was worth something once.

I will tell him.

I will set out another glass before he knocks, and open something good, and tell him the truth, which is always the most persuasive thing I own.

Then I will ask him for his name.

And he will think about it.

CHAPTER SIX



The French Market at seven in the morning smells like crushed bay and diesel, and somebody is following me.



I clock them at the bay stall, the one where old Thibodeaux's cousin sells bay by the armload and pretends not to know what I use it for. There are two of them, both human, both trying very hard to look like men who came to the market for satsumas.

Nobody comes to the French Market at seven for satsumas.

The tall one has a baseball cap and a neck as thick as a fence post. The short one is wearing cheap white sneakers with the sole coming loose on the left foot, so every other step goes *slap* on the wet concrete.

They stay a few stalls back.

Amateur hour. When I stop, they stop. When I pick up a bundle of bay and smell it, the tall one picks up a mango and holds it as though he's never seen fruit before.

Hired, then. Nobody who works for Absalom Cray directly would be caught dead in those shoes.

So Cray hired out, and Cray thinks I'm worth two idiots and a pair of Payless sneakers.

I don't know whether to be relieved or insulted.

I settle on both.

I pay for the bay. I don't hurry.

Hurrying is for people with shit to hide.

My grandmother used to say you should never let them see you run. It tells them what you're afraid of, and then they know where to push.



I've got a list, and I work it.

Salt first, from the man at the end who sells it gray and coarse out of barrels, dug from the marsh down by Grand Isle.

Table salt is fine for a pot. For a ward you want salt that remembers the water it came out of. I buy a sack of it and he wraps it in newspaper and winks at me, because he's known me since I was a girl buying it for Honorine.

Then bone. There's a woman two rows over who sells soup bones out of a cooler, and if you ask her the right way, she'll reach under the table and sell you the other kind. Knucklebones, clean and dry.

I don't ask where they come from. She doesn't tell. That's the arrangement.

Then hair. That one's harder. Hair only works if it was willingly given, so you can't buy it off a barber's floor. You have to buy it from the person who grew it. There's a girl who braids hair on the corner of Decatur, and she saves me the cuttings from customers who say yes when she asks.

"Something big?" she says, handing me the paper twist.

"Something stupid," I tell her. "Something really fucking stupid."

The whole time, the sneaker goes *slap, slap, slap* a few stalls behind me, a metronome for idiots.

A working needs salt, bone and hair, and a price. I have three of the four. The price is the part I'm still trying to figure out, and it's the part I'd give almost anything not to be the one paying.



At the corner of Decatur and Ursulines, I stop pretending I haven't seen them.

I turn around. I look straight at the tall one, right in his mango face, and I give him my nicest customer-service smile.

"Follow me, then," I say. "I'll wait."

His mouth falls open. The short one actually steps behind a lamppost, as though that helps.

I turn and walk into the botanica on the corner.



Mireille's shop is older than both of us. Candles, powders, saint cards and dried snakeskins, a whole wall of oils in brown glass bottles, and a back room behind a bead curtain where Mireille keeps the things tourists can't handle.

She looks up from the counter when the bell goes. She sees my face, and she sees the two men through the front window, loitering on the corner and pretending to read a menu.

"Oh, *chère*," she says. "Who'd you piss off?"

"A banker."

"Jesus, Mary and Joseph. That's the worst kind." She lifts the counter flap. "Back room's open. You want me to call somebody?"

"No. I'm going to handle it myself, like a grown-ass woman."

"Course you are." She sighs. "Don't break anything expensive."

I go through the bead curtain into the back room and set my bag down. Then I get to work, fast, my heart going like a rabbit's.

I tear open the newspaper of marsh salt and lay a line across the doorway, right under the beads, wrist loose, never stopping. I lay it thick. Then I take one of the knucklebones out of its paper and set it at the center of the line, where the threshold would be if there were a real door, and I cut the tip of my finger with the little blade I keep on my keys and put one drop of blood on the bone.

Salt for the boundary. Bone for the lock. Blood for the price.

It's a small working. A cheap one.

It won't stop a vampire or a wolf, and it won't stop anybody who's been invited. It'll stop two hired humans who came in without asking.

I step back and wait.



They come in a few minutes later. Of course they do. I hear the bell, and Mireille's voice, bright and sweet, saying *can I help you boys with something?* I hear the sneaker, *slap*, and the tall one saying something low.

Then the bead curtain rattles, and the tall one puts his hand through it.

He stops.

I watch it hit him. His arm is through the beads and his foot is on the threshold, right over my salt, and he stops dead. He stops as a man stops when he's walked into a room and forgotten why he came in.

His face goes blank. He stands there with his hand in the air and his mouth a little open.

Behind him, the short one bumps into his back.

"Go," the short one says. "What are you doing? She's right there."

"I—" says the tall one.

He pulls his arm back out of the beads, and turns around, and walks out of the shop. I hear the bell go. The short one stands there for a second, looking from the curtain to the door, and then he follows, *slap, slap, slap*, out into the street.

The working will hold them off me until it wears through, sometime around lunch. After that they'll remember exactly what they came for, and they'll be angrier about it.

That's fine. By lunch I'll be home, and they can go cry to their boss about it.

I go out the back door into the alley with my salt and my bones and my hair, and I walk the long way home along the river, and

nobody follows me.

No rescue. No enforcer. Just a witch and a sack of goddamn salt.
Holy shit, I did that.

I'm shaking the whole way. My fingers are shaking so hard I nearly drop the salt. There's a stupid, drunk kind of heat running all through me, the kind that comes after a close call, and it's settled right between my legs, and it's all his fault.

Every time I got scared this morning, what I thought about was his hand.

Never the King, never my grandmother, never the goddamn salt. His scarred palm on my tits, and his two fingers curling up inside me, and his voice telling me to look at him.

What kind of woman gets turned on by a close call? What kind of witch lays a ward with her pussy throbbing?

This kind, apparently. Fuck my life.



My phone rings as I'm crossing Esplanade.

"Where are you?"

No hello. There's never a hello.

"Crossing Esplanade."

"You went out alone."

"I went to the market, Silas. People do it every day. Nobody's ever died buying bay leaves."

"Somebody followed you."

I stop in the middle of the sidewalk. A man with a dog walks around me.

"How the hell do you know that?"

"Mireille called Lucian. Lucian called me." His voice is very flat and very even, and I've learned that flat means something terrible is happening underneath it. "Two men."

"Two very stupid men. One of them has shitty shoes. I handled it."

"You handled it."

"I laid a line in Mireille's back room and walked them out of it as easily as shooing dogs off a porch. I'm fine. I'm walking home. I'm perfectly fine."

A long silence on the line. I can hear his breathing, and he doesn't need to breathe, so I know he's doing it on purpose, to keep his temper.

"You didn't tell me you were going," he says.

"You were asleep."

"I don't sleep."

"You were doing that thing where you lie on the guest bed with your eyes shut and pretend. I heard you not sleeping through the wall. It was very loud."

"You'd have said no."

"I'd have come with you."

"Same fucking thing." I start walking again. "And speaking of saying no. You asked me this morning what the ledger needs. I told you it bites me. I've been thinking about it. It needs blood that isn't Marchand."

"Then use mine."

He says it at once. No pause at all.

I have to stop again.

"No," I say.

"Ondine."

"No. Absolutely not. Vampire blood in a witch's lock is a contract, Silas. It binds the one who bleeds to the one who owns the lock, and neither of them gets to see the terms until they come due." My voice is shaking now, and I hate it. "That'll cost more than you've got."

"You don't know what I've got."

"Neither do you. That's the whole fucking problem with you."

Silence again. Then, lower:

"Come home, witch."

It goes through me as hot as a shot of whiskey. Heat, straight down my spine, pooling between my thighs.

"I *am* coming home. Jesus. I'm walking."

"Walk faster."

"Or what?"

"Or I'll come and get you. And I won't carry you, this time." He pauses. "I'll put you over my shoulder in front of the whole Marigny."

I laugh. It comes out breathless, too high.

"You wouldn't."

"Try me."

"You're furious."

"Yes."

"Good." I cross against the light. "I'm soaking wet, and I've been soaking wet since the market, and it's your fault for being the only thing I think about when I'm scared. So you can be furious all you want, Silas Roche. You can yell at me when I get home. Just do it with your mouth on me."

A sound comes down the line. It's not quite a word. It's the sound he made with his mouth on my tits at the table.

"Walk faster," he says, rough.

"Say please."

"Ondine."

"Say it."

A long pause. I can hear him breathing again. I can hear, I swear to God, the creak of his leather coat as he shifts, as if he's standing somewhere with his fist clenched against a wall.

"Please," he says. "Come home. I want to see you're whole. Then I'm going to put you on that table and find out how wet you are for myself."

He hangs up.

I walk so fast I nearly break into a run, and I'm grinning like an idiot the whole way down Chartres Street.



He isn't there when I get home. There's a note on the kitchen table in his square, careful hand: *Tobias. Back by dark. Lock the door.*

I don't lock the door.

I lay out my salt and my bone and my hair on the long table, and I stand there looking at them, and I think about my grandmother.

She taught me salt for bone at this table. I was a little girl, sitting on the edge of it with my feet swinging, and she had the paper twist in her fingers, and she was pouring a line around a saucer so slowly I thought she'd never finish.

You can use salt for bone if you have to, she said. If you're caught short. Salt remembers the water. Bone remembers the body. Salt can stand in, a little, if the bone's not there.

What can stand in for salt?

Nothing, baby. She tipped the twist and let the last grains fall. Some things have to be what they are.

She got sick the winter after. The wet years, she called them, though I think they were just the years she was dying. Her chest rattled when she breathed, and at the end she couldn't get up from the bed in the back room, and I used to sit on the floor beside it and pour salt lines for her to look at, because it made her smile.

The last night, she took hold of my wrist.

Her fingers were so thin. I remember that. I remember how hot her skin was, and how dry, and how hard she held on, harder than I thought a dying woman could hold anything.

She pulled me close. Her breath smelled of camphor and blood.

Ondine, she said. Listen to me. Don't let them read you, baby. Whatever they—

CHAPTER SEVEN



“

Two men,” Ondine says, “and one of them has terrible shoes.”

She’s sitting on the edge of her kitchen table with her bare feet swinging, telling me about her morning as if she were telling me about the weather. A sack of gray salt at her hip. Knucklebones in a paper twist. A braid of somebody else’s hair. She’s cut the tip of her finger, and there’s a smear of dried blood on the knucklebone she used, and she’s so proud of herself she’s practically glowing.

I’ve been standing in her doorway for a full minute, and I haven’t moved.

“Tall one had a neck as thick as a tree stump,” she says. “Short one had sneakers with the sole flapping. Slap, slap, slap, all down Decatur. I’ve never been followed by anyone so embarrassing in my life.”

“You walked them into a ward.”

“I walked them into Mireille’s back room and they walked right back out again with their mouths open.” She grins. “Salt, bone, blood. The cheap version. It’ll have worn off by now, but they won’t know why they left.”

“They’ll know by tonight.”

“Then they’ll be very confused by tonight.” She tilts her head. “You’re doing it again.”

“Doing what?”

"Standing in my door with your jaw set, deciding whether you're angry." She leans back on her palms. "You said on the phone you were going to find out for yourself how wet I was. I've been waiting all afternoon. I'm starting to think you're all talk, Silas Roche."



I cross her kitchen.

I don't decide to. My body does it. Three long strides and I'm between her knees, and she stops swinging her feet and looks up at me, and her breath goes short.

"Are you hurt?" I ask.

"No."

"Anywhere."

"I said no."

I go down on one knee in front of her anyway.

I take her ankle in my good palm and turn it to the lamplight. A scrape across the bone where she caught it on a curb. I run my thumb over it. Then up, slowly, over the curve of her calf, the back of her knee, the soft skin on the inside of her thigh, under the hem of her skirt.

Checking. Reading. Every inch of her, for any mark a man might have left on her today.

There's nothing. Just her, warm and whole, her thighs trembling under my palm.

And the smell of her.

It hits me the moment my face is level with her knees. Salt and bay and marsh water from her morning, and under all of it, rising, the sharp sweet musk of her getting wet.

She wasn't lying on the phone.

"Silas," she whispers.

I look up at her. She's gripping the table edge with both fists, lips parted.

"You said you'd find out," she says. "So find out."

I push her skirt up her thighs.

She spreads her knees for me without being asked. She's wearing nothing under it.

Of course she's wearing nothing under it. Her pussy is flushed and slick in the lamplight, glistening, and I lean in and breathe her in, and she makes a sound in the back of her throat that goes straight down my spine and into my cock.

I put my thumb on her. Just my thumb, flat, against the wet heat of her, not moving.

"Soaked," I say.

"Told you." Her voice shakes. "Since the market. Since the goddamn market, Silas."

I drag my thumb up through her, slow, from her hole to her clit, and she jerks, and her thighs clamp on my shoulders—

The second board of her porch creaks.



I'm on my feet before the sound finishes.

She hears it a heartbeat after me. Her whole body goes rigid on the table. Her eyes go to the front hall, where her front door stands open to the night, because her door is always open, because that's the whole fucking problem.

Another creak. Then a third.

Somebody heavy, shifting on the board that gives.

And then a slap. Rubber on wood.

A loose sole.

"Stay here," I say.

"It's my—"

"Witch. Stay."

She stays. I don't look back to check.

I walk down her front hall with my fist closed and my blood going cold and slow and heavy. It always goes like that when I'm about to be what I was bought for.



They're on the porch. Both of them.

The tall one is on the top step, already reaching for her door frame. The short one is behind him on the walk, bouncing on his toes in his split sneaker, holding a coil of plastic zip ties in one fist like a man carrying a bouquet to the wrong funeral.

They weren't expecting me.

I watch it land on both of them at once. The tall one sees me fill her doorway and his reaching arm stops in the air. The short one's bouncing stops. For one second nobody moves, and I read everything there is to read about them.

Humans. Hired. Paid half up front and promised the rest on delivery.

The tall one has done this before: there's a fight scar through his eyebrow and a gun in the back of his jeans, and he's already shifting his weight to get to it. The short one hasn't. He's terrified, and trying to look like he isn't, and he smells of cheap beer and fear sweat.

Neither of them has any idea what I am.

Who sent them this time, and why the fuck so early?

"Evening," the tall one says. "We're here for the lady."

"No."

"Look, man, we don't want trouble. We got a job. She comes with us nice, nobody gets hurt—"

"She told you once already. This morning. In Mireille's shop."

The tall one's face twists. The working's gone.

He remembers now: the bead curtain, the salt, standing in that doorway with his arm in the air and no idea why he'd come. It makes him angry, and angry men are stupid.

"That bitch did something to me," he says.

He steps forward, and reaches past me, and grabs for her through the open door.

She's there. Of course she's there. She never stays where I put her. She's come up the hall behind me barefoot with her skirt still rucked up and a kitchen knife in her fist, and his fingers close on her wrist and yank.

She stumbles forward into the doorframe with a cry.

He's touching her.

His dirty fingers are wrapped around her wrist, on her step, in her house, and the animal I keep chained at the bottom of every day goes very, very still.

I take his wrist in my fist and I squeeze until he lets her go.

He lets her go. He screams while he does it.

Then I look at him, and I let him see all of it. My eyes. My mouth. The teeth I don't show anyone.

"Touch her again," I say softly. "Please."



He's a professional, so he tries for the gun.

His good arm goes to the back of his jeans and comes out with it. He's fast, for a human. He's bringing it up to my chest when I take it off him, and his finger with it, and I throw the gun into her hydrangeas.

He opens his mouth to scream again.

I put my palm over his throat and close it.

It takes almost nothing. I feel the cartilage give under my fingers, the ring of his windpipe folding flat as a paper cup. His eyes go wide and wet and stupid.

His good hand scrabbles at my wrist. His heels drum on her porch boards, on the board that gives, and it creaks and creaks and creaks under him.

I lift him off his feet by the throat.

His blood is right there. I can hear it. I can hear his heart slamming it through the big vein under my fingers, hot and fast and full of fear, and the smell of it comes up off him like steam off a pot.

My mouth floods. My teeth come down fully, sharp and aching, and every inch of me wants to put my mouth on that vein and drink until he's empty.

I don't.

I hold him there with his feet kicking and my fangs down and my whole body screaming at me to feed, and I don't.

What would she see, if I did? What would she think I was, every night after, standing at the end of her table?

I won't be an animal on her grandmother's porch, with her watching. I fucking won't.

I keep my mouth shut, and I break his neck instead.

It's quick. A twist and a crack, loud as a branch in a freeze.

He goes loose all at once, heavy and boneless, and I let him drop. He folds up on her top step with his head at a wrong angle and his eyes still open, looking at the porch ceiling.



The short one hasn't moved.

He's standing on her walk with his zip ties in his fist and his split sneaker planted in the gravel, staring at his partner, and he's pissed himself. I can smell it. His mouth is working with no sound coming out.

I come down the steps toward him.

He turns to run. I have him by the back of his collar before he's managed a step, and I turn him around to face me.

"Please," he says. "Please, man. Please, I didn't know, they didn't tell us, it's just a job, it's just a fucking job—"

"Who hired you?"

"I don't know. I swear to God. A guy. A guy in a coat. We never saw him, we got a phone call and an envelope with cash—"

"What kind of envelope?"

"Cream," he babbles. "Real thick. Fancy."

Of course it was.

I break his jaw first. One short hard punch with my left fist, and I feel it go under my knuckles, and his head snaps sideways.

He goes down on one knee in the gravel, spitting blood and teeth. Then I take the fist holding the zip ties and I break every finger in it, one after another, while he screams through the ruin of his mouth.

I leave his knees alone. He's going to need those.

I crouch down in front of him. He's sobbing. Blood is pouring from his mouth down his shirt, and his fingers are a crumpled wreck held against his chest, and he's staring at me like I'm the devil come up through the floor.

I've been called worse by better men.

"You're going to walk," I tell him. "You're going to walk back to wherever that phone call came from, and you're going to find the man in the good coat, and you're going to give him a message. Do you understand me?"

He nods, frantic. Blood flies.

"Tell him if he wants something from this house," I say, "he can come and ask me for it himself."

I stand up.

"Go."

He goes. He staggers up out of the gravel and runs, lurching, down her walk and out her gate and into the dark, one broken fist clutched to his chest and his split sneaker slapping on the sidewalk down the length of the street until I can't hear it anymore.



I stand on her walk in the dark with my fangs down and blood on my knuckles, breathing when I don't need to.

It takes a long time for my teeth to go back up. It always does, after. They ache in my gums, and the smell of the dead man's blood is all over her porch, thick and iron-sweet and hot, and every part of me is still leaning toward it.

When I finally turn around, she's in the doorway.

She's barefoot, in her rucked-up skirt, with a kitchen knife still in her fist and a red mark coming up on her wrist where he grabbed her. She's looking at the dead man folded up on her top step. Then she's looking at me.

She isn't afraid.

I read it on her, and it goes straight through me. There's no fear in her at all.

Her eyes are wide and bright and fixed on me, and her lips are parted, and her chest is rising and falling fast under her cardigan. She's watching me as she'd watch a pot she's never seen boil before, fascinated, taking notes.

Then her face changes.

"On my *step*," she says.

"Ondine—"

"On my goddamn step, Silas Roche." Her voice climbs. "Do you know what you've done? This is neutral ground. This house has been neutral ground since before the Code was written. Nobody bleeds on a Marchand step. Nobody. Not wolves, not vampires, not the King himself. That's the whole *point* of this house."

"He put his hands on you."

"I know he put his hands on me, I was *there*!" She throws the kitchen knife down on the boards, and it skitters and spins. "You think I didn't want to see him dead? I'd have put that knife in his eye myself if you hadn't been standing there. But not *here*. Not on the step my grandmother salted. You couldn't have walked him to the corner?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Because he touched you. Because he had your wrist in his fist and you cried out, and I would have killed him in the middle of the King's own hall for it.

None of it comes out.

"Because—" I say, and stop.

She stares at me. She's breathing hard. Behind her, down the hall, the kitchen lamp is still burning on the table where I had my thumb in her ten minutes ago.

"Every wolf in the bayou's going to hear about this by morning," she says, quieter. "Every client I've got on those shelves. A man died on the Marchand step, and a Croix vampire killed him. You know what that costs me? You know what that does to this house?"

"I'll pay it."

"You can't pay it. It isn't yours to pay." Her voice cracks. "That's how this house works, Silas. The costs always land on me."

She looks down at the dead man again, and her jaw sets, and I watch her decide. I watch her pick up whatever just broke and put it on a shelf for later.

"Get him off my step," she says. "Now. Before the neighbors wake up. Then come inside and wash. I'm not having his blood in my kitchen."



I carry the body around the side of the house and lay it in the dark by her fence. I call the Roche brothers. They'll be here within the hour with a truck and a tarp and no questions, because that's what they're for.

Then I stand at her kitchen sink and wash him off me.

She stands beside me the whole time, watching the water run pink and then clear. She doesn't touch me. She's holding her own wrist in her other palm, rubbing her thumb over the red marks where his fingers were.

When I'm done, I dry off on her dish towel and turn to her.

"Pack a bag, witch," I say. "You're sleeping at the King's house."

CHAPTER EIGHT



I don't pack a bag. I bake bread. It's a much better use of rage.



By five in the morning I've got flour to my elbows and a lump of dough the size of a newborn on the table, and I'm beating the shit out of it.

You're supposed to knead gently. Fold, push with the heel of your palm, turn, fold again. My grandmother used to say you should knead bread as gently as you'd rub a tired man's shoulders. I'm kneading this bread as if I'm strangling a broker, and it's coming along fucking beautifully.

My thighs ache while I do it. I can still feel his thumb from last night, flat and wet on my pussy, dragging up to my clit right before the board creaked. I can feel exactly how swollen I was, how slick, how my hips came off the table to chase it. I push the heel of my palm into the dough and think about his mouth between my thighs instead of his thumb, and my nipples go hard under my apron, and I pound the bread harder.

Silas is at the end of the table where he always stands.

He's been there since four. He didn't sleep either. I heard him through the guest-room wall, pacing, and then not pacing, and then standing so still I could hear the absence of him. When I came out to

start the dough, he was already dressed and waiting in the kitchen doorway with the bag he brought in over his shoulder.

"You didn't pack," he said.

"Very observant."

"Ondine."

"I'm not going."

That was an hour ago. He hasn't moved since.

He's standing there with his arms folded, watching me pummel a lump of flour and water, and the bag is still on his shoulder. As if I might change my mind and he wants to be ready.

"The King's house has wards, witch," he says now.

"So does mine."

"His are stronger."

"His are *different*." I fold the dough over and slam it down. Flour puffs up in a cloud. "Silas, listen to me for a goddamn minute without clenching your jaw. This house is neutral ground. You know what that means?"

"It means nobody bleeds on your step."

"It means nobody bleeds on my step." I push the heel of my palm into the dough so hard it squeals against the wood. "And last night somebody did. And if I leave today, if I pack up and go sleep in the King's big warded house, a good little Croix witch, then every wolf in the bayou knows exactly whose side the Marchand house is on now. And every one of those jars on my shelves has a wolf's name or a vampire's name in it, and half of them are going to come knocking to ask for their names back."

"Let them."

"I *can't* let them. That's my living. That's my grandmother's living, and her mother's." I turn the dough. "And the paper, Silas. The debt. It's a Marchand working. It knows this house. Off my own ground, the collection finds me easier, not harder. My salt is my salt. The King's salt is the King's."

He's silent for a long moment.

"You thought about this," he says.

"I've thought about nothing else since you went to bed and didn't sleep."

"I was guarding the door."

"You were guarding the wall between my room and yours. I could hear you not coming through it." I slam the dough down one more time. "Put the bag down. You look like you're waiting for a bus."

He looks at the bag on his shoulder. Then, slowly, he sets it down on the floor by his feet.

It's a start.



At six I shape the loaves, and at half past I go out to deal with the step.

The Roche brothers came in the night with a truck. I heard them, low voices and a tarp rustling, and then nothing, and when I went to the window the dead man was gone from beside my fence and so was the truck.

They're good at what they do. They didn't take the blood. It's still on my top step. Dried brown in the grain of the boards, in a long spray down the front of the riser where his mouth hit it. There are drips on the second board, the one that gives. There's a smear by the post where Silas dragged him.

I stand in my doorway with a bucket of hot water and a scrub brush and look at it.

Then I get down on my knees and scrub, and I swear the whole time, every filthy word I know, in two languages.

Shit. Fuck. *Merde*. Fuck him, fuck his cheap sneakers, fuck the broker who sent him, fuck this step.

Silas comes out behind me. I can feel him in the doorway without looking.

"I'll do that," he says.

"No."

"Ondine, it's my —"

"It's my step."

"I know, witch."

"Then act like it." I dunk the brush and scrub harder. "My step. My blood to clean. I don't care whose fist put it here. It's on Marchand boards, so it's mine."

He doesn't argue. He stands in the doorway and watches me do it, and I can feel him hating it, and I can feel him understanding it, and I don't know what's worse.

It takes a long time. Blood gets into old wood and doesn't want to leave, the stubborn bastard.

I scrub until my arms ache and my knees are soaked through and the water in the bucket is pink. I scrub until the boards are pale and raw and smell of lye soap and wet cedar instead of that man.

Then I sit back on my heels and get the salt.



A threshold line is no pinch of salt thrown at a door. It's a promise, laid down every time the house changes hands or the house is broken, and last night this house was broken.

My grandmother laid the first one when she took the house from her mother. I watched her lay it again when I was small, after a man who owed her came to the door drunk and put his fist through the screen. I laid my own the week she died.

Now I lay it again.

I pour it across the top step from one post to the other, gray marsh salt in a line so fine and even you could measure it with a ruler. Wrist loose, never stopping. And I say the words under my breath, the old ones, the ones about what's welcome and what isn't and what this house will and won't hold.

It costs me.

I feel it go. Every threshold working costs the keeper a little standing, a little of the weight the Marchand name carries in this city. It drains out of me down my arm and into the salt, and the salt holds it.

When I'm done, I'm lightheaded. Every time, it's worse than I remember. I have to put my palm on the post to stand up.

"What did that cost?" Silas says behind me.

"Enough."

"Tell me."

"A working's worth of standing." I dust my palms off on my skirt. "The house holds a little less weight today than it did yesterday. People will feel it. Some clients won't come back." I look at him. "That's what happens when blood hits a Marchand step. The house pays. The keeper pays."

His face twists.

"I'm sorry," he says.

"I know you are." I pick up the bucket. "Don't do it again."



He follows me back into the kitchen. The bread's rising under a cloth. The whole room smells of yeast and flour and the rosemary I burned at four without meaning to.

I put the bucket in the sink and turn on the tap, and he stands close behind me.

"You skipped my house," I say, without turning around.

"What?"

"In the raid. When Lucian took the city back from his uncle. Every house on the canal got turned over that night. The wolves told me after." I watch the water run into the bucket. "They said a vampire walked wide around my yard as if it were a church. Wouldn't come through the gate. Walked the long way round, three streets out of his way, so nobody would think to look here."

He doesn't say anything.

"That was you," I say. "Wasn't it."

"Ondine."

"Wasn't it?"

"Yes."

I turn around.

He's closer than I thought. There's flour on his coat where I brushed past him earlier, a white print of my palm on his dark sleeve. His scarred fist is at his side. He's looking at me as he looks at

a stretch of road he doesn't want to read.

"Why?" I ask him.

"I—"

It doesn't come. I watch it not come.

"Never mind," I say softly. "I know why."



I don't decide to kiss him. I just do it.

I reach up and take his face in both floury palms and pull him down, and I put my mouth on his.

He goes rigid. For a heartbeat he's a statue, a wall, a man made entirely of *not*. Then a knot gives in him, all at once, and he makes a low wrecked sound into my mouth and his arms lock around me.

He kisses me back.

God help me, he kisses me back. His mouth opens over mine, hungry and deep and not careful at all, and his tongue slides against mine, and he tastes of cold coffee and salt and something dark underneath that I don't have a name for. He backs me into the counter.

The edge of it hits my spine. He grips my hips and lifts me onto it, and flour goes everywhere, and I wrap my legs around his waist and pull him in tight.

He's hard. I can feel him through his trousers, pressed right up against my pussy through my skirt, thick and heavy and hot, and I grind down on him without thinking.

He groans into my mouth. His fingers dig into my ass.

"Ondine," he breathes against my lips.

"Don't talk."

"You always say that."

"You always talk at the wrong time."

He kisses me harder. His mouth moves down my jaw, to my throat, and I tip my head back and feel his lips on the pulse under my ear, and his teeth. Just the edges, just blunt, but I feel the shape of what he's holding back, and it sends a shudder through me so hard my thighs clamp on his hips.

My nipples are hard as pebbles against his chest. I'm soaking my own underwear. Is this what I've been fingering myself to for a year?

Holy shit, it's better. I'm grinding on him on my kitchen counter at dawn with flour in my hair and the smell of lye on my fingers, and I've never wanted anything this much in my whole life.

And then I think of the step.

The blood in the grain of the boards. The pink water in the bucket. The man with his head at a wrong angle, looking up at my porch ceiling.

I put my palm flat on his chest and push.

He stops instantly. He pulls back an inch, his mouth wet and his eyes black, breathing hard. He's shaking.

"Not today," I say. My voice is wrecked. "Not the morning after a man died on my step. I want you. I want you so much I can't see straight. But not today."

He looks at me for a long moment.

Then he laughs. It's short and rough and startled, and it's the first time I've ever heard it.

"What?" I demand.

"*Not*," he says.

I stare at him. Then I start laughing too, helplessly, with my legs still wrapped around his waist and my forehead dropping onto his shoulder.

"Oh, fuck you," I say into his coat. "Fuck you, that's not funny, you bastard."

"It's a little funny."

"It's a little funny," I admit.



He lifts me down off the counter. He does it carefully, as if I might break, and sets me on my feet and steadies me with both palms on my waist until I've stopped wobbling.

Then he looks down at his right fist.

He's split his knuckles. On the short one's jaw, last night. They've healed already, as vampire skin does, but the old burns around them

are raw and angry from the salt and the cold water, the scar tissue cracked in a line across the back of his palm.

"Sit down," I tell him.

"It's fine."

"It's not fine, it's cracked, for Christ's sake. Sit."

He sits. At my table. It's the first time in a year he's ever sat down at my table, and he does it because I told him to, and I have to turn away for a second so he won't see my face.

I get the salve from the shelf, the one I make for burns: beeswax and comfrey and calendula, lavender to take the sting. I sit down beside him and take his scarred palm in my lap and open it, and start working the salve into the cracks.

"It won't heal them," I say. "Nothing heals old burns. It'll make them softer, that's all."

He doesn't say anything. He watches my thumbs move on his skin.

The scars run from the heel of his palm to the base of his fingers. Ropes of them, pale and shiny, pulled tight where the skin healed wrong.

They go around his wrist like a cuff. I trace one with my fingertip, the thickest one, and he shivers.

"How did you get them?" I ask, low.

"They're from—"

He stops.

I wait. I keep rubbing the salve in, slow circles, and I don't look up, because I think if I look up he'll stop for good.

"They're from—" he says again, and his voice cracks, and then nothing. His fingers close on mine, tight, and hold on.

"It's all right," I say. "You don't have to."

"I want to."

"I know. You will."

I wrap his palm in clean linen, and I tie it off, and I don't let go of his fingers for a good while after.



The bread comes out at nine, gold and crackling. He eats a slice standing up, because apparently sitting once was all he had in him today, and I watch him chew and pretend not to be watching.

He's going to stay. I can see it on him. What does he think he's guarding me from, exactly? Cray, or himself?

He's going to sleep in my guest room with the lock on the inside, the same room Lucian and Selene hid in, the week the whole city went to hell. He's going to stand guard on a wall he won't walk through.

And I still haven't told him the whole goddamn truth about the ledger.

I told him it bites me. I told him it needs blood that isn't mine. I didn't tell him why my own grandmother would lock her book against her own granddaughter, because I don't know, and because every answer I can come up with is worse than the last one.

What was she hiding in there that she couldn't let me read?

I cut myself another slice of bread and keep my mouth shut. It's a Marchand talent, apparently.

CHAPTER NINE



The first rule of a warded room is that nobody goes in who wasn't invited, and I have never once invited a man.



My grandmother's workroom is at the back of the house, behind the pantry, through a door so low even I have to duck. It's small and windowless and it smells of beeswax and old paper and a century of burnt sage.

The walls are lined with shelves of jars too dangerous for the kitchen. There's a single table, a single chair, a single lamp, and a line of salt across the threshold so old it's gone gray and hard as mortar.

Nobody but a Marchand has ever crossed it.

I'm sitting at the table at midnight with the ledger in front of me, and I'm trying to cheat.

The ledger wants blood that isn't Marchand. Fine. Blood's not the only thing that stands in for a person in a working.

Hair can do it, at a pinch, if it was willingly given. So I've got the braid-girl's cuttings in a saucer, a pinch of hair from a customer on Decatur who said yes, and I've laid it across the clasp in a little nest, and I've pricked my thumb, and I'm saying the words.

The clasp doesn't even twitch.

I try it again, with more salt, because I'm a Marchand and we don't know when to fucking quit. Then with bone. Then with more hair and a sprig of rosemary and a very sincere prayer to whichever saint handles locks.

Nothing. The ledger sits there, fat and black and smug, and I want to throw it through the wall.

"Hair's not blood," I tell it. "I know that. But you could meet me halfway, you stubborn old bitch."

The book says nothing. The book was bound by Honorine Marchand, and it's as stubborn as she was.

“



Ondine.”

I jump so hard I knock the saucer over.

He's in the doorway, or nearly. He's on the other side of it, in the dark of the pantry, with his palm flat on the doorframe and his boots right up against the salt line.

He can't cross. I can feel the ward humming from here, a low thick buzz like a hive in the walls, pushing back against him.

"You scared the shit out of me."

"I knocked."

"You did not."

"I knocked on the pantry door. You didn't hear." He looks past me at the table, the spilled hair, the ledger. "It won't open."

"It won't open with hair. It won't open with bone. It won't open with a very nice prayer to Saint Anthony." I rub my eyes. "It wants blood. It wants blood that isn't mine, and I'm not giving it yours, so you can take that look off your face."

"I haven't said anything."

"You were about to."

He doesn't deny it. He stands beyond the line and looks at me, and even in the bad light I can see a weight on his face.

"What?" I ask.

He takes his time answering.

"Lucian called."

"And?"

"He asked me whose name it is. On the paper." He looks at the salt line under his boots. "I told him I was still confirming."

I go still.

"You lied to the goddamn King."

"Yes."

"Again."

"Yes."

"For me."

He doesn't answer that. He doesn't have to.

I stand up from the table. I walk across the tiny room to the threshold, until I'm standing right on my side of the salt line and he's standing right on his, so close I can feel the cold coming off him.

The ward hums between us. It raises every hair on my arms.

"Why?" I say.

He looks at me. His eyes are very dark.

"Because it's yours," he says. "Your name. You get to decide who knows it."



I've been waiting a year for him to say that to me.

I didn't know it until he said it. I thought I was waiting for his hands, for his mouth, for him to finally stop standing at the end of my table and come around it.

I was. But under all that, I was waiting for this: for somebody to look at me and decide that what's mine is mine.

I put my palm flat on his chest.

My fingers cross the salt line. The ward buzzes against my knuckles, sharp and hot, but it doesn't stop me.

It's my ward. It knows me.

"Silas," I say.

He doesn't move.

"I'm not asking this time," I tell him. "I'm not grabbing your hand and putting it on me. I'm standing here. I want you. I've wanted you for a whole year of nights. But if you want me, you're

going to have to take me yourself."

For a long moment he just looks at me.

Then his scarred palm comes up and cups my jaw, and he tips my face up, and he kisses me.

It's nothing like the kitchen. In the kitchen he kissed me as if he was surprised to be doing it. This is a man who's decided. His mouth is hard and deep and slow, and he kisses me as he reads ground, taking everything in, missing nothing, and when he finally lifts his head I'm hanging onto his coat with both fists.

"Yes?" he says, low.

"Yes."

"Tell me again."

"Yes. God, yes. Please."



He doesn't cross the line. He can't. So he pulls me to it.

His palms go to my hips and he draws me forward until my back hits the doorframe, and I'm standing on the threshold with a foot on each side of the salt, and he's pressed against me from the pantry side, and the ward is humming against his spine where it meets the edge of the frame. I can feel it through him. Every time he moves, it buzzes harder, a low warning buzz against the back of his coat.

He doesn't care. He's got his mouth on my throat.

He unbuttons my cardigan with his good fingers, slowly, one button at a time, and pushes it off my shoulders. Then the thin cotton camisole under it, up and over my head, and he drops it on the pantry floor. My tits spill out into the cool air, nipples already tight, and he looks at them in the light from the workroom lamp, and his breath catches.

"Silas—"

He bends his head and takes my nipple in his mouth.

I cry out. His tongue is cool and his mouth is hot and he sucks hard, dragging at me, and every pull goes straight down into my pussy. I grip his hair and arch off the doorframe into him. He moves to the other one and does it again, harder, until I'm writhing against

the wood.

His good palm slides down my belly, into my skirt, and finds me soaking.

"Fuck," he breathes against my breast. "Ondine."

"Don't stop. Don't you dare stop."

He pushes two fingers into me, and I'm so wet there's no resistance at all, and he fucks me with them, slow, while he sucks on my nipple, until my knees are shaking and I'm whimpering into his hair.

Then he stops, and pulls his fingers out, and straightens up, and I watch him, dazed, as he opens his belt and his trousers. He takes his cock out, and I look down, and my breath goes out of me all at once.

Oh.

Oh, fuck.

I felt him through his trousers in the kitchen. I've been imagining him for a year. Holy shit, I did not imagine this.

He's thick. He's so thick my fingers won't go around him when I reach down and touch, heavy and hard and hot against my palm, flushed dark at the head, and long, and he groans when I stroke him and pushes into my fist.

"Silas," I whisper. "That's not— I don't—"

"Tell me to stop."

"I don't want you to stop. I just— Jesus. You're going to split me in half."

"I'll go slow."

"Promise?"

He looks at me. His face is very serious.

"Yes," he says.



He lifts me. He gets his palms under my thighs and hauls me up the doorframe, and I wrap my legs around his waist and lock my ankles, and my skirt falls back around my hips.

The wood of the frame digs into my shoulder blades. The ward hums against his back, so loud now I can hear it, a thick angry

drone.

He fits the head of his cock against me.

I'm so wet I'm dripping. I can feel it running down onto him. And still, when he pushes, it's too much.

The first inch is a stretch. The second hurts.

I gasp. My whole body goes tight around him. I grip his shoulders so hard my nails go through his shirt.

He stops instantly.

"Breathe," he says.

"I'm breathing."

"You're not. Breathe for me."

I breathe, and it comes out shaking, a long ragged gasp against his collar.

He waits. He holds me up against the doorframe with his arms trembling, not moving, not pushing, and he kisses my jaw, my cheek, the corner of my mouth, slow and soft, until I feel my body start to loosen around the head of his cock.

"More," I tell him.

He gives me more. He pushes in slow, so slow, an inch and then another, and it hurts.

God, it hurts. It's a deep stretching burn, my pussy straining around the thickness of him, and my eyes are watering and my thighs are shaking, and I don't want him to stop.

"Ondine."

"Don't stop."

"You're crying."

"I know I'm crying. Don't *stop*."

He doesn't stop. He keeps pushing, a little at a time, pausing every time I tense, kissing the tears off my face, until finally, finally, his hips are flush against my thighs and he's fully inside me.

We both stop breathing, and the whole house seems to stop with us. I've never been this full. I didn't know you could be. He's so deep I feel him in my stomach, stretching me open around him, aching and burning, and it hurts, and under the hurt something else is starting, something slow and hot and enormous that makes me

clench around him without meaning to.

He groans. His forehead drops to my shoulder.

"Fuck," he says, into my skin. "Fuck, you're tight."

"You're big."

A breath that might be a laugh.

"Stay on your side, witch," he whispers.

I laugh too, helplessly, with tears running down my face and his cock buried in me in the doorway of my grandmother's workroom, half inside the ward and half out, and the laugh makes me tighten around him, and we both gasp.

"Move," I tell him. "Slow. Please."



He moves. He draws back until he's nearly out, slow, and pushes back in, slow, and the hurt starts to change.

It doesn't go away. It sits there under everything, a deep sore ache, but on top of it the pleasure starts to build, thick and heavy, every stroke dragging his cock along something inside me that makes my toes curl.

He's careful. He's so careful. He watches my face the whole time, reading it, and every time I wince he stops, and every time I moan he gives me a little more.

"There," I gasp. "Like that. Just like that."

He does it just like that, over and over, slow and deep, until I'm panting against his mouth and grinding down on him as much as I can with my back pinned to the wood.

"Harder," I tell him. "Fuck me harder, Silas. Fuck my pussy harder. I can take your cock. I want to take all of it."

"You're sure?"

"I'm sure. Silas. I'm sure."

He fucks me harder, and the doorframe creaks. The ward roars against his back, and I can see it in his face when it bites him, a tightening around his eyes, but he doesn't stop. He fucks up into me with long hard strokes that knock me back against the frame, his cock splitting me open every time, and the burn and the pleasure are

all mixed up together now, and I can't tell where one ends and the other starts.

I'm going to come. I can feel it building, low in my belly, tight and huge.

"Touch me," I beg. "My clit. Please. I need—"

He shifts his grip, holds me up with one arm, and gets his other thumb between us, right on my clit, and rubs.

That's all it takes. I come on his cock with a scream I don't even recognize as mine.

My whole body bucks against him. My pussy clamps down around him so hard it hurts all over again, in hard rhythmic pulses, and I'm sobbing and shaking and clinging to him while the orgasm tears through me.

He holds me through it. He doesn't move. He just holds me pinned against my grandmother's doorframe with his cock buried in me and his face in my neck, and I feel him shaking.

He hasn't come.

"Silas," I pant. "You didn't—"

"I know."

"Come in me. Please. I want you to."

He lifts his head. His eyes are black and wet.

"Next time," he says.

"Silas—"

"Next time, witch." His voice cracks. "Not tonight. You're hurt. I'm not going to fuck you harder when you're hurt."



He pulls out of me slowly. It hurts coming out, too. I wince, and he sees it, and his face twists into an expression I've never seen on him.

He carries me to bed, and he doesn't put me down once. He picks me up off the threshold, and my legs are still around his waist, and he carries me through the pantry and down the hall to my bedroom and lays me down on my own sheets. He brings a warm cloth from the bathroom and cleans me, carefully, between my legs, and there's

a little blood on the cloth, and he looks at it for a long moment.

"It's fine," I tell him. "It's nothing. It's what happens."

"It's my fault."

"It's your cock's fault. Your cock and I will work it out." I reach for his wrist. "Stay."

He doesn't move.

"Silas. Stay. Get in. Hold me. I don't care if you don't sleep. Just lie here."

He looks at my bed. He looks at me, naked and sore and wrecked on the sheets. He looks at my fingers on his wrist.

Then he takes my fingers off his wrist and lays them on the sheet and holds them there for a second, gently.

"Sleep," he says.

And he goes.

He goes to the guest room, the one with the lock on the inside, and I hear the door close and the lock turn, and I lie in my bed in the dark with my pussy aching and my face wet and the smell of him all over my skin, and it's the loneliest I've been in a year.

Why won't he stay? What does he think will happen to him if he sleeps beside me?



I don't sleep. Around three, I hear his voice through the wall.

Low. He's on the phone.

"No," he's saying. "Not yet."

A pause.

"I know, sire. I know I did."

Another pause. Longer.

"Still confirming," he says.

I roll onto my side and press my face into the pillow.

What is he confirming? And who is he protecting, his king or me?

I bite the pillow so I won't make a sound.

CHAPTER TEN



The Bywater firm keeps its files in a room with a window that doesn't open, and that tells me somebody here expected to need one.



I go in after midnight, through the back.

Tobias gave me the building's registry card this afternoon, stamped and dated and signed in his tiny immaculate hand. Floor plans for every story, a line of text about a fire escape that was never built, and one detail he'd underlined twice: the rear door was replaced within the season, and the lock on it is new.

"Somebody's frightened," Tobias said, and pushed his useless spectacles up his nose. "New locks are the first thing frightened people buy."

The lock is good. It isn't good enough. I've been opening doors that other men paid to keep shut since before the building was built.

Before I leave, I call the Roche brothers. Two of them take the street outside Ondine's gate, and one takes the canal.

She doesn't know. She'd be furious if she did, and after tonight I don't think I have the right to make her anything else.

I don't think about tonight. I think about the lock.



Inside, the firm smells of toner and lemon floor polish and the clerk's burnt coffee from the afternoon. Beneath all of it there's a colder smell, old paper, the kind that's been sitting in the dark for a very long time.

I follow it upstairs.

The file room is at the back of the second floor. It's small and square, lined floor to ceiling with steel cabinets painted the color of oatmeal, and there's a single window high up on the far wall.

The window's painted shut. Painted over, in fact, thick, layer on layer, the frame gone soft and rounded with it.

But the sash has been scraped. There's a line of fresh bare wood around all four edges, where somebody took a blade to the paint in the last few months.

They didn't finish. They got it loose and then stopped, and left it there, ready.

I stand under that window and read it.

Somebody who works here, or owns this place, sat in this room recently and thought about how they'd get out of it if they had to leave in a hurry. Then they decided the day hadn't come yet.

Who, and from what?



The cabinets are alphabetical, and the Marchand file is low down, near the floor.

It's thin. That surprises me. I expected a debt that old and that heavy to come with a stack of paper as thick as my fist, and instead there's a single cardboard folder, soft with handling, holding a handful of sheets.

I take it to the desk and put my penlight in my teeth and read.

The first sheet is a copy of the obligation. The same terms Ondine read to me off Cray's letter, in the same patient hand: the Marchand line, the collateral of weight, the new moon. At the foot, Honorine's

signature, careful and upright, surname only.

The second sheet is a receipt of sorts. *Consideration: delivered.* No date I can convert. No description of what was delivered, or to whom. Just the two words and a mark beside them I've seen before, on the seal of an envelope under a mat.

The third sheet is where I stop.

It's a draft. An earlier version of the collateral line, from before the copy was made clean. It's written out in full, and then one line has been struck through, heavily, with three bars of ink so black they've nearly cut the paper.

Under the ink there was a name.

I tilt the sheet in the penlight. I turn it over and look at the back, where the pen pressed hard enough to leave a ghost in the fibers. I can make out the length of it.

Two words, maybe. A capital at the start that could be an H, or an M.

It isn't Ondine's. Her name is short, and this one is long.

Somebody wrote a different name on this line first, and then somebody struck it out and wrote hers instead.

Whose name was it, and who decided it wasn't good enough?

I hold that sheet a long time. Then I put it back exactly where it was, and I take nothing.



The account's register is in the bottom drawer of a different cabinet, under a stack of annual filings signed by a partner who's been dead since before the war.

It's a ledger, heavy, bound in leather gone black and cracked at the spine. I open it on the desk.

Columns. Dates in calendars I can't all read. Transfers in and out: a shipping company, a holding firm, a dead woman's estate. And along the left side of every page, a name.

A different name, every generation. One name runs for decades, and then the handwriting changes and the name changes with it, and a new one runs for a while, and then another.

Some of them are in French. Some are in a script I don't recognize at all. They go back to the very front of the book, to pages so brown and brittle I'm afraid to turn them.

Every hand is different. The patience in them isn't.

I read people for a living. I read what they leave on the ground: how fast they were going, what they were carrying, whether they were afraid.

I read these names the same way, and every one of them was written by somebody who had never been in a hurry in their life. Every one of them sat down and signed the account as if they had all the time there was.

It's the same buyer. The name changes. The buyer doesn't.

What the fuck lives that long and keeps its books this neatly? And why the hell does it need a broker?

◆ ◆ ◆

The index card is in the last drawer I open, and I almost miss it.

It's tucked in the back of a file of old correspondence, in a little paper sleeve gone yellow and soft. A three-by-five card, the old kind, with a blue rule across the top. There's writing on it in faded ink.

I take it out.

My old designation is on the first line. The one from the yard. The one I haven't heard spoken aloud since a man with kennel keys used it to call me to the chain in the mornings.

Under it, a line of ink.

The Roche boy — introduced.

I stand very still in the dark and think, *fuck*.

My penlight shakes. I take it out of my teeth, and I realize I've bitten nearly through the rubber grip.

Introduced to whom, and by whom? Why is a card from the dog years, from before Aurelian, from the worst decade of my life, sitting in the back of a drawer in a holding firm in Bywater that pays for the account I'm supposed to be tracing?

I don't know.

I put the card in my coat.

I don't decide to. My fingers do it, and it goes into the inside pocket, the one where the writ lived, and it sits there against my chest, and it's lighter than the writ was, and somehow it weighs more.



I lock the back door behind me and walk toward the river before my phone buzzes.

Are you awake.

Of course I'm awake. I'm always awake. She knows that.

I call her instead of answering.

She picks up on the first ring. For a second neither of us says anything. I can hear her breathing, slow and a little uneven, and the rustle of her sheets.

"You're in bed," I say.

"Where else would I be at this hour?" Her voice is low and rough, sleep-thick. "Where are you? You sound like you're outside."

"Walking home."

A pause. I hear her shift.

"You said *home*," she says softly.

I don't answer that. I stop at the corner under a streetlamp with a dead moth caught in the glass, and I close my eyes.

"How do you feel?" I ask.

It comes out rough. I sound like a man who hasn't used his voice in a week.

"Sore."

"How sore, witch."

"Very sore." Something shifts in her voice. "I can still feel exactly where you were. Every time I move, I feel it. It's like you're still in me."

My cock is hard before she's finished the sentence. I lean my shoulder against the lamppost and shut my eyes, and I see her exactly: on her back in the dark, knees up, her palm cupped between her thighs where I split her open a few hours ago.

"Ondine."

"You asked," she says. "Don't fucking ask if you don't want to know."

"I want to know," I say. "Everything."

"All right, then." A breath. "I'm lying here in the dark with my knees up, because it hurts too much to put them down flat, and I'm naked, because I couldn't stand anything touching me. I've got my palm between my legs, not doing anything, just holding it, because it's warm there and it aches and it feels like you." A small, shaky breath. "I keep pressing on it. Just to feel it hurt. God, Silas, I keep pressing on it and getting wet again and it hurts and I don't want it to stop. And I'm furious with you."

"I know."

"You left."

"I know."

"You stood in my bedroom and looked at me in my sheets with your come still—" She stops. "No. You didn't even come. You made sure I came and you didn't, and then you picked me up and carried me to bed like I was something you were returning to a shelf, and then you left."

I don't say anything. There isn't anything true I can say that I can finish.

"Why?" she asks. Her voice breaks on it. "Why won't you stay?"

Because I've never stayed anywhere I wasn't told to. Because the last time a door closed behind me and I slept, I woke up in a yard with a chain on my neck. Because there's a card against my chest right now with that yard's name on it.

"Because I—"

It stops. It always stops.

On the other end of the line she lets out a long breath.

"You don't have to finish it," she says, softer. "Not tonight, anyway. I'm just telling you. I wanted you in my bed. I still want you in my bed. And next time you're inside me, Silas Roche, you're going to come, and you're going to stay, or I'm going to salt your door shut from the outside and keep you in there till you learn."

Something in my chest pulls tight, hard, painful.

"Next time," I say. "Next time I come in you. Next time I stay."

She makes a soft sound, half a laugh, half a sob.

"You promise?"

"I promise."

"Next time." A pause. Softer. "Where were you tonight? Really?"

My palm goes to my coat. To the inside pocket. To the card.

I stand under the streetlamp with the moth in the glass, and I look across the street at the dark window of a closed bakery, and I don't say anything for a long while.

"Tracing the account," I tell her.

It's true. It isn't all of it.

"Find anything good?"

The card is warm from my chest. *The Roche boy — introduced.*

"A window," I say. "Painted shut. Somebody's been scraping it loose."

"That's creepy as shit."

"Yes."

"Come home," she says. "Please. I don't care if you don't come to bed. Just come home and stand at the end of my table and let me hear you not sleeping through the wall."

"I'm coming."

"Walk faster, Silas Roche."

She hangs up before I can answer, and I stand there on the corner with my cock aching and my phone warm in my fist, a fucking fool under a streetlamp.



I walk the rest of the way along the river with my fingers inside my coat, on the card, the whole time.

The Roche brothers are where I left them, a pair at her gate and one at the canal. They nod when they see me.

Nothing moved tonight. Nobody came.

Her kitchen light is on.

She's sitting at the table in her cardigan with her knees drawn up on the chair, and there's a cup of coffee at my place, still steaming, poured when she heard my step on the walk. She looks up at me when I come in, and her face is tired and sore and furious and glad.

"You're home," she says.

I stand at the end of her table and drink the coffee she poured me, and I don't tell her about the card.

CHAPTER ELEVEN



“

He drinks it black,” Selene says. “Obviously. Look at him.”

She’s leaning in my kitchen doorway with her arms crossed and her head tilted, looking at Silas, who is standing at the end of my table with the cup I just poured him, watching her with the expression of a man being assessed by customs.

“I didn’t ask how he drinks it,” I say.

“You were about to. I could see it on your face.” Selene comes in and drops her bag on a chair. “Nobody who’s lived that long puts sugar in anything. It’s a rule. They all drink it black and bitter, as if they’re punishing it for something.”

“Lucian takes cream,” Silas says.

Selene stops. She turns and stares at him.

“He does *not*.”

“Every morning.”

“That lying son of a bitch. That cream-drinking son of a bitch.” She sits down at my table, delighted. “He told me he drinks it black. He made a whole speech about it. I’m going to ruin his entire day.”

Silas finishes his coffee in one swallow and sets the cup down.

“I’ll leave you to it,” he says.

“Coward,” Selene says fondly.

He doesn’t answer. He looks at me, once, a long look that goes down to my toes and back up, and then he goes out the kitchen door.

On the step he stops and says, without turning around, "Lock the door, witch."

"No," I tell his back.

He goes anyway. I hear his step on the walk and the gate, and then he's gone.

Selene watches the door swing shut behind him. Then she turns and looks at me, and her eyebrows climb into her hairline.

"Witch," she repeats.

"Don't."

"Lock the door, witch."

"Selene, I swear to God."

"Oh, honey." She props her chin on her fist. "Oh, holy shit. You fucked him."



I make the tea because I need something to do with my hands.

Selene takes hers as she takes everything, fast and hot with too much honey, and she drinks it while I bang around the kitchen pretending I'm not blushing. She's been coming over since spring. She started the week Lucian brought her here to hide, and she kept coming after, and somewhere along the line we became the kind of friends who split tea orders and trade gossip about vampires.

I've never had a friend like her. I don't think she's had one like me.

"So," she says.

"So nothing."

"So you let him in the warded room."

I drop the kettle lid. It clangs on the stove.

"How the hell do you know that?"

"Because you're walking like you got hit by a streetcar, and the only door in this house with a threshold that bites is back there." She points with her spoon. "You're limping, Ondine. That man split you open, and you let him do it in your grandmother's doorway."

I put both palms flat on the counter and breathe.

"It was the doorway," I admit. "He couldn't cross the salt. So I stood on the line."

"Of course you did."

"And he picked me up against the frame."

"Of *course* he did."

"And it hurt." I turn around. "Selene, it hurt like I was being split with an axe. He's so— I'm not even going to tell you. I'm not going to describe it."

"Please describe it."

"He's *enormous*."

She laughs so hard she has to put her cup down.

"How enormous?"

"I couldn't get my fingers around his cock, Selene. My *fingers*. I had my fist on it in that doorway and I thought, oh, this is how I die. This is how they find me. Flattened in my grandmother's pantry with a smile on my face."

"Oh my God."

"It took him forever just to get it in. He kept stopping. He kept making me breathe. I was crying and telling him not to stop and he was kissing the tears off my face with his cock halfway up inside me, and I've never been so full in my life. I can still feel it. I can feel it right now, sitting in this chair."

"I knew it," she says. "The silent ones. It's always the silent ones. They stand in doorways looking like furniture for a year and then they take their trousers off and it's a fucking crime scene."

"It's not funny."

"It's extremely fucking funny." She wipes her eyes. "Did you come?"

"Selene."

"Did you?"

"Yes." I sit down across from her. "Hard. On his cock, against the wall, with his thumb on my clit, screaming like the house was on fire. I think the cat moved out for an hour. And then he wouldn't. He made sure I did and then he wouldn't, because I was hurt, and then he carried me to bed and cleaned me up and wouldn't stay."

The laughing goes out of her face.

"He left?"

"He went to the guest room and locked the door on the inside."

She goes still for a moment. Then she reaches across the table and puts her fingers on my wrist.

"Lucian did that," she says. "In the beginning. Different reasons. Same door." She squeezes. "They think if they stay, they'll break something. They don't understand yet that they already did."



She finds Cray's letter while I'm making a second pot.

I left it on the table under the account page, where Silas put it the first night. Selene doesn't touch it. She leans over it with her cup in both palms and reads it without moving it, as she reads everything: slowly, twice, with her lips very slightly moving.

"This is him," she says. "The broker."

"Absalom Cray."

"He bought Lucian a brandy once. At a bar, before he was king. The condolences of a grateful city, he said." She frowns. "It was wrong. The words were right and the tone was one step off, as if he'd learned how people talk out of a book and never actually heard them do it."

She reads the letter a third time.

"This is the same," she says. "It's perfect. Every word is exactly correct. *The Marchand obligation falls due at the new moon. A. Cray, broker, will accept the stated collateral.* And it's one register off."

"What does that mean?"

"It means he's written this sentence so many times the grammar's worn smooth. Like a step." She taps the air above the page, careful not to touch it. "Nobody writes *will accept the stated collateral* the first time. You write it the fiftieth time. The hundredth. It's a form letter, Ondine. He's sent this letter to a lot of people."

Cold goes down my back. Jesus Christ.

"And look." She slides the account page out from under the letter and sets it beside Cray's copy of my grandmother's debt, the old

terms he included with the envelope. "Look at the capitals on the debt. The slope on the M. The little hook at the bottom of the D."

I look.

Then I look at Cray's signature on the letter.

"Same hand," Selene says softly. "Different century."

"He wrote the terms," I whisper. "The original terms. He wrote them himself."

"Whoever wrote that debt and whoever wrote this letter is the same person." She looks up at me. "How old is he supposed to be?"

"He says three hundred."

"Well," Selene says, "for once in his miserable life, the bastard's not exaggerating."

◆ ◆ ◆

We sit with it for a while. The tea goes cold. The cat comes and sits in the window and judges us.

"Does he know?" Selene asks at last.

"Does who know what?"

"Silas. Does he know how you feel about him?"

I pick up my cup and put it down again.

"That'll cost," I say.

"Everything costs, with you."

"Everything costs with *everyone*. I'm just the one who says so out loud." I push my hair out of my face. "He knows I want him. He knows I've wanted him for a year. The rest of it—" I shake my head. "The rest of it's a lot to put on a man who can't finish a sentence."

"He finished a few in the doorway, I'd bet."

"He said *breathe*," I tell her. "He said *stay on your side*. He said *next time*." I stare into my tea. "That's it. That's all I got. And I've been lying awake since, taking those sentences apart like they're a clock."

Selene says nothing for a moment.

"Tell me about the ledger," she says.

◆ ◆ ◆

So I tell her.

The brick. The black leather. The brass clasp that bites. The ward that tastes Marchand blood and says no. The hair I tried, and the bone, and the salt, and the prayer to Saint Anthony.

"It wants blood that isn't mine," I say. "And Silas offered his. The first day. He didn't even hesitate."

"So why haven't you let him?"

"Because vampire blood in a witch's lock is a promise." I spread my palms on the table. "A lock like that doesn't just open for anybody's blood. It takes the blood and makes a contract out of it. A binding. Between the one who bleeds and the one who holds the lock. And neither of them gets to read the terms until they come due."

"What kind of terms?"

"That's the whole problem. I don't know. It could be nothing. It could be that he has to come when I call him. It could be that I can't lie to him ever again. It could be that one of us owns a piece of the other one until we die." My voice is shaking now. "I've watched my grandmother's clients sign things they didn't read, Selene. My whole life. I've watched what it costs them when the bill comes."

"So you won't do it to him."

"I won't do it to him."

Selene looks at me for a good while. Then she sets her cup down, and she leans back in her chair.

"When I met Lucian," she says, "I fed him."

I know this. Everybody knows this. The whole court knows Selene let the King drink from her the first week, as easily as pouring him a glass.

"I didn't know what it would do," she says. "Nobody told me. It turns out when you feed a vampire and you're awake for it, he gets everything. Every single thing you're feeling, right down to the stuff you don't want him to know." She laughs, short. "Worst bad decision I ever made. Best bad decision I ever made. You don't get to

find out which until after."

"That's not reassuring."

"It's not supposed to be." She leans forward. "But listen to me, Ondine. You keep saying you won't do it to him. You've already done it to him. You did it the first night he stood at the end of your table. He's already bound. He's just not bound to anything in writing."

I open my mouth. Nothing comes out.

"He offered," she says. "The first day. You said he didn't hesitate. That's not a man who doesn't know what he's signing. That's a man who's already decided what he's signing and is waiting for you to catch up."



She leaves at three with a jar of my lavender salve and a promise to tell Lucian nothing, which means he'll know everything by dinner.

"Cream," she says at the door, grinning. "Every morning. I'm going to destroy him."

"Be gentle."

"I'm never gentle." She kisses my cheek. "Call me after. I want details. I want *measurements*."

"Get the hell out of my house."

She goes, laughing, and I close the door behind her and lean my back against it.

The kitchen's very still. The letter is still on the table next to the account page, with Cray's worn-smooth grammar and his three centuries of patience. The ledger is behind its brick in the stove, waiting.

He's already decided what he's signing and is waiting for you to catch up.

I stand there for a long moment.

Then I get down on my knees in front of the stove, and I work the brick loose, and I take out my grandmother's ledger and set it on the table. I sit down in front of it with my palms flat on either side of it

and look at the clasp.

It'll bind him to me. I don't know how. I don't know what it'll cost him, or me, or when the bill will come.

What if it's too much? What if I open this book and find out what she bought, and I can't close it again?

And what if he walks through my door with his blood, and I find I'd have paid anything to let him?

I pick up my phone.

I don't let myself think. I just type it, and send it, before I can take it back.

Come home. Bring your blood.

INTERSTITIAL

Cray



She threw the jar at my feet before I had taken off my hat.

Green glass, small. It broke on her kitchen boards and let out a smell of scorched honey and river clay. A name had been held in it. She did not care whose. She wanted something to break, and my shoes were nearest.

I stood in the wet and waited for her to finish.

It was the wet years, as she called them afterward. The gutters were full and the river was high against the levee, and Honorine Marchand had a chest that rattled. She was not yet old. She looked old that night. Her husband had been dead since the Sunday before.

“Get out of my house,” she said.

“Of course,” I said, and did not move.



He had died on the Tchoupitoulas levee, under a wolf.

Everyone knew which wolf. Nobody said so. The truce between the canal and the bayou was new, and thin, and it held on the understanding that what happened on the water stayed there. The court would not ask. The King would not ask. The pack had buried the matter and would bury anyone who dug.

So the widow sat in her kitchen with her husband's boots by the door, and she had nobody left to ask.

That is when a broker is useful.

"I can introduce you," I said, "to someone who will see to the wolf."

She laughed. It was a wet and hollow sound.

"And what does your someone want?"

"A name of weight."

"Take mine." She pressed her palm to her chest as though holding the rattle in. "It's all I have worth anything. Take it and bring me his heart in a jar."



She wrote it herself. I let her.

She put her own name on the collateral line in that careful upright hand, pressing so hard the nib nearly went through, and she pushed the paper across the table at me with her jaw set.

I looked at it for a long time.

It was a heavy name. It held every jar on her shelves. It would have served.

But her chest was bad, and she would never live to be old, and a name is only worth what it holds when the paper comes due. Would a dead woman's name hold anything at all by then?

I chose.

I drew bars through her name, neatly, and turned the paper so she could watch me do it.

"Not yours," I said. "Your daughter will have a child someday. That child will be a Marchand."

"So?"

"So she'll hold this house and every name in it. For far longer than you."

"She isn't born."

"Not yet."

"My daughter won't let a man near her."

"Then there's no weight on the line. You've lost nothing."

She said nothing.

"And if there is a child," I said, "you'll have bought your wolf with a name that comes due long after you. You'll never watch it paid."



She went to the door and took the salt from the shelf beside it.

She poured a line across the boards between us, over my feet, fine and even. She did not look at me while she did it. When she straightened, I found I could not step past that line toward her.

That was all it was for. So I would not come closer while she decided.

It took her a long time. I am very good at waiting.

Then she came back to the table and took up my pen, and could not make her hand write.

"You write it," she said. "Ondine. Write *Ondine*. It's what I'd name her, if anyone let me."

I wrote it for her, short and bright, in the space under the bars.

I have always thought that was the cleverest thing Honorine Marchand ever did, and the saddest, and I doubt she knew it was either.



The wolf was dead within the month.

I made the introduction the next evening, and the principal saw to it, and the wolf's name went into the widow's ledger in darker ink than the rest. She came around, afterward. She wrote me a note of thanks on good paper, and asked me never to come to her kitchen again, and I honored that until very recently.

The child has her mouth. I noticed it on the step.

I chose that name for a longer asset. A house of names, in a young woman's keeping, coming due long after anyone who might object was in the ground.

It seemed a very good choice at the time.

It still does.

CHAPTER TWELVE



Silas cuts his own palm open over my grandmother's ledger like a man signing something he hasn't read.

He does it with his own knife, the plain one with the bone grip, and he does it before I've finished telling him how. One clean stroke across the heel of his scarred hand, right through the worst of the old burns.

The blood comes up dark and slow and thick. It smells of iron and cold and something older, like the inside of a church.

"Silas, wait—"

He turns his palm over and presses it flat on the clasp.



The ledger drinks.

I see it happen. The blood doesn't run off the brass or pool on the leather. It sinks in. It goes into the metal as if the metal were thirsty, and the clasp warms under his palm until I can see the heat shimmer off it in the lamplight.

Then the lock takes hold of him.

I feel it before I understand it. A thread, pulled tight between his palm and my chest, right under my breastbone. It doesn't hurt. It's warm. It tugs, once, like somebody pulling a stitch through cloth, and then it knots, and settles, and stays.

He feels it too. I watch it land in him. His whole body goes still, and his eyes come up to mine across the table, black and wide.

"What was that?" he says.

"The promise."

"What does it say?"

"I don't know." My voice is shaking. "Nobody knows until it comes due. I told you. I told you, you stubborn bastard, I *told* you—"

The clasp springs open with a soft click.



The ledger falls open on the table between us.

I see my grandmother's handwriting on the first page. Careful and upright. A date in the old Marchand calendar. A name, and beside it in the margin—

I slam it shut.

I do it before I've read a word. I slam it shut with both palms flat on the cover so hard the lamp jumps, and I hold it closed, and I'm shaking so badly my teeth are chattering.

"Ondine."

"Tomorrow."

"You wanted to read it."

"*Tomorrow*." I don't look at him. "I can't, not tonight. I've wanted to know what's in this book for my whole life, and now it's open, and I can't. I can't read her hand tonight, Silas. I just can't."

He doesn't argue.

He sits there with his palm bleeding into a dish towel, and he watches me hold a book shut with all my strength, and he doesn't say anything at all. Behind me the roux I started an hour ago is getting too dark on the stove. I can smell it going from hazelnut to coffee to burnt. I don't move to save it.

I'm going to cry. I'm going to sit in my grandmother's kitchen and cry over a book I've been locked out of since I was born, and I'm going to do it in front of him.

What's in there that she couldn't let me see? And what did I just let him sign, to see it?

Then he stands up.



He comes around the table.

He does it slowly, one step at a time, as if I'm a horse that might bolt. He takes the pencil out of my hair. It's holding up my whole knot, and he slides it out, and my hair falls down around my shoulders, and he sets the pencil on the table beside the ledger with great care.

Then he goes down on his knees in front of my chair.

I stare down at him. What the hell is he doing?

He's kneeling on my kitchen floor with his bleeding palm wrapped in my dish towel and his coat pooled on the boards around him. His face is turned up to mine. There's nothing in it I've ever seen before. Not the jaw set, not the watchfulness. Something wide open.

"What are you doing?" I whisper.

"You can't read it tonight."

"No."

"Then don't." He puts his good palm on my knee. "Let me worship something, witch."



I don't answer him. I can't.

I put my fingers in his hair instead, and I grip it hard, and I pull him in.

He goes where I pull. He goes gladly, a man who's been kneeling in his head at the end of my table for a year and finally been told he can.

He pushes my skirt up my thighs with both palms, bunching it at my hips, and I lift off the chair to help him. Then he hooks his fingers in my underwear and drags it down my legs and throws it somewhere behind him.

I'm sitting in my grandmother's chair with my skirt around my waist and my pussy bare to the lamplight, and a vampire is kneeling between my thighs.

He looks.

He always looks. He puts his palms flat on the insides of my thighs and spreads me open, wide, wider, until I can feel the cool kitchen air on my wet, and he looks at me for so long I start to squirm.

"Silas."

"I've wanted you like this for a year." His voice is very low. "Every night at the end of this table. I'd drink your coffee and think about getting on my knees and spreading you open and eating you until you cried."

"You never said."

"I'm saying." His thumbs slide up the inside of my thighs, closer, not touching. "You're soaked, Ondine. Look at you. You're dripping onto the chair."

"It's your fault."

"Good. Spread wider."

I spread wider.

"Wider, witch."

I hook my knees over the arms of the chair. I've never been so open in my life. My pussy is flushed and swollen and glistening in the light, and he's staring at it as if he's memorizing the grain of a floorboard.

"Fuck," he breathes. "Look at your clit. It's so swollen. You want my mouth on it that badly?"

"Yes."

"Ask."

"Please. Please put your mouth on me."

"Where?"

"On my pussy, you bastard, on my clit, please—"

He leans in and licks me.



It's one long, slow, deliberate stroke of his tongue, from my hole up to my clit, flat and heavy and wet, and my whole body jerks in the chair.

"Oh, *fuck*—"

He does it again, slower. He licks me as he does everything, completely, missing nothing. When he reaches my clit he circles it once with the tip of his tongue and then sucks it into his mouth, gently, and holds it there.

I grip his hair with both fists. My thighs clamp on his head. My back arches off the chair.

"God. God, Silas, don't stop, don't you dare stop—"

He pulls off just long enough to talk.

"You taste better than I imagined. I imagined it every night." He licks me again, long and slow. "Every night, witch. Every fucking night."

"Tell me," he says between licks. "Tell me how it feels."

"Like— God— like you're starving—"

"I am. I've been starving at the end of this table for a year." He sucks my clit into his mouth and lets it go with a wet, obscene sound. "Spread your pussy for me. Use your fingers. Show me everything."

I do. I reach down and spread myself open for him, and my fingers are shaking, and he groans at the sight like a man in pain.

"Just like that. Hold it open. Don't you dare let go."

I hold it open, and he buries his tongue in me.

He licks and sucks and drags his tongue through my pussy over and over, deep and slow and then fast, and he makes sounds while he does it, low hungry groans that vibrate right into my clit. His good palm slides up under my blouse and finds my tit and squeezes, and his thumb rolls my nipple.

I'm grinding on his face. I'm holding his head down between my thighs with both fists in his hair and grinding my pussy against his mouth, and he groans and lets me.

He pushes his tongue inside me.

I cry out. It's thick and wet and it moves, and he fucks me with it, in and out, his nose pressing into my clit, and I'm going to come, I'm going to come already—

He pulls back.

"No," I sob. "No, no, no, come *back*—"

"Not yet."

"*Silas*—"

"You wanted control." He looks up at me from between my legs. His mouth and chin are shining with me, and his eyes have gone black. "So take it. Tell me what you want. Tell me exactly how you want me to eat your pussy, and I'll do it."

I stare down at him.

This man, who can't finish a sentence about himself. Who stands at the foot of my table as still as a fence post. He's on his knees with my wet all over his face, asking me how I want his tongue.

"Your mouth on my clit," I tell him, and my voice shakes. "Suck it. Hard. And put your fingers in me. Two. Curl them."

"Like this?"

He does exactly that. His lips close on my clit and he sucks hard, harder than before, and two thick fingers push into me and curl up and find the spot.

"Yes— like that, just like that, oh God, oh fuck, don't stop—"

"Tell me more."

"Faster. Faster, Silas. Suck it faster. Fuck me harder with your fingers."

He sucks faster.

"Talk to me," I gasp. "Don't stop talking."

"You're so wet it's running down my chin," he says against my pussy. "You taste like salt and rosemary and cunt. I could eat you every morning from now on."

"Then do it."

"I will. Every morning. Before your coffee." He flicks my clit with his tongue. "On your knees on the kitchen floor. In your grandmother's chair. On the table where I stood for a year wanting this."

"Yes. God, yes. Every morning, you filthy bastard—"

His fingers fuck me hard and deep, dragging over that swollen place inside me with every stroke, and his tongue flicks my clit between every pull of his lips. The chair creaks.

My heels drum his back. The wet sound of him fucking me with his fingers is so loud in the kitchen that I'd be ashamed, if I had any shame left.

"Look at you," he says against my pussy, between licks. "Grinding on my face in her chair. Dripping down my wrist. You're going to come on my tongue, aren't you?"

"Yes—"

"Say it."

"I'm going to come on your tongue—"

"Then come in my mouth, witch. Give it to me. I want every fucking drop."

That's what does it.

I come so hard I scream.

My whole body buckles in the chair. My thighs lock around his head and my pussy clenches on his fingers in hard helpless pulses, and I'm grinding against his mouth and sobbing and swearing, and he doesn't stop. He licks me through it, his tongue working my clit, drawing it out pulse after pulse, swallowing, until I'm writhing and shoving at his head because it's too much.

He doesn't let me push him away.

He pins my hips to the chair with his forearm and keeps licking, slow now, gentle, and it's too much and not enough, and it starts to build again.

"Silas, I can't, I can't again—"

"You can."

"I *can't*—"

"You can. I've got you. One more. Give me one more."

"You bastard—"

"Yes."

He curls his fingers and sucks my clit, soft and steady, and I come again, a slow rolling one that goes through me like a swell

through deep water. I'm crying. I don't even know when I started.



He still doesn't stop.

He pulls his fingers out of me, slow, and I whimper at the loss, and he pushes my thighs even wider with his palms and licks up everything I just gave him. Long flat strokes. My thighs, my hole, my clit. He licks me clean as if it's a sacrament.

"You're going to kill me," I pant.

"No." He presses a kiss to the inside of my knee, then my thigh, then right on my clit, soft, and I jerk. "I'm going to worship you. I told you."

"You've worshipped. I'm worshipped. I'm very fucking worshipped, Silas."

"Once more."

"I'll die."

"Then die on my tongue."

He slides his palms under my ass and lifts my hips right off the seat of the chair, and he buries his face in my pussy, and he eats me like there's no ledger and no broker and no moon, like there's nothing in the world but my cunt and his mouth.

I grab the edge of the table behind me to keep from falling. The lamp rattles. My grandmother's ledger slides an inch across the wood.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God—"

"Tell me," he growls into me.

"Don't stop—"

He doesn't. He fucks me with his tongue and sucks my clit and holds my hips up to his mouth, and I come a third time with my thighs shaking around his ears and a sound coming out of me I've never made in my life, long and high and broken, and I feel it all the way down to my toes.



When he finally lifts his head, I'm boneless in the chair.

My skirt is up around my ribs, my legs hanging over his shoulders, little aftershocks still running through my thighs. There are tears on my face. There's a mark under my ear where he put his mouth at some point, and I don't even remember when.

He's still on his knees.

He wipes his mouth slowly with the back of his good hand and looks up at me, and he's wrecked. His hair is a mess from my fists. His lips are swollen. There's a flush on his face I didn't know vampires could get, and his eyes are wet.

He's so hard I can see his cock straining against his trousers. It must hurt.

"Come here," I whisper.

"I'm here."

"No. *Here*." I put my palm on his jaw and pull him up. "You said next time you'd come. You promised me on the phone."

"I said next time I'm inside you."

"You're a fucking lawyer now?"

The corner of his mouth moves.

I reach down and open his belt. My fingers are clumsy and shaking, and it takes me a few tries, and he kneels there and lets me do it with his forehead dropped onto my knee. I open his trousers and take his cock out.

He's so hard he's leaking. The head is flushed dark and slick, there's a vein along the underside I can feel pulsing in my palm, and he's so thick my fingers won't close. I stroke him, once, slow, root to tip.

He makes a sound as if I've stabbed him.

"Look at me," I say.

He looks at me.

"You made me come three times," I tell him, stroking him slow. "On your tongue. In my grandmother's chair. Now you're going to come for me."

"Ondine—"

"Tell me how you want it. It's your turn to ask."

He stares up at me with his mouth open, shaking.

"Faster," he whispers. "Tighter. Please."

"Say it dirtier," I tell him.

He stares at me. Then his jaw clenches, and he says it.

"Jerk my cock, Ondine. Hard. Squeeze it. Your fist's wet with your come from my face and I want to feel it on me. Make me come all over your thigh. Please. Fuck. *Please.*"

I give him faster. I give him tighter, sliding over the thick head of him, and he's gasping.

His palms are fisted in my skirt on either side of my hips. He turns his face into my thigh and bites down, just his teeth through the skin, and groans into me.

"Ondine. Ondine, I'm going to—"

"I know. Let go."

"I've never—"

"I know. Let go, Silas. I've got you."

He comes in my fist.

His whole body locks up. He groans into my thigh, low and broken, and his cock jerks and pulses in my palm, and I feel him spill hot over my fingers, over and over, onto my thigh and the seat of the chair. He's gripping my skirt so hard I hear the fabric tear.

I hold him through it. I keep stroking until he twitches and pushes my wrist away, and then I just hold him, my sticky palm around his cock and my other hand in his hair.

He doesn't lift his head for a long while.

Has anyone ever held him like this? Has anyone, in two hundred years of yards and kings and other people's kitchens, ever once held this man while he came apart?

I don't think so. Jesus Christ. I don't think anybody ever has.



The roux is ruined.

I can smell it, black and bitter, filling up the kitchen. I don't care. I sit in my grandmother's chair with a vampire's head in my lap, his cheek on my knee, and I stroke his hair while he breathes when he

doesn't need to.

His bleeding palm is lying open on my thigh. The dish towel has fallen away. The cut's already closing, as vampire skin does, but the old burns around it are raw and angry, and I put my thumb on them.

I stroke the scars, slow. Back and forth, over the worst of them.

He shivers.

"Stay tonight," I say.

He doesn't answer for a good while.

"Yes," he says finally, into my knee.

I close my eyes.

Behind him, on the table, my grandmother's ledger is lying shut with his blood dried in the crack of the clasp, and somewhere under my breastbone the thread he pulled through me is still there, warm and tight, tying me to him in words neither of us can read yet.

Tomorrow I'll open it.

Tomorrow I'll read what she bought with my name.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN



She asks me to read it to her, and I do, and I would give the rest of my years to unread it.



The ledger is open on the table where my blood cracked the binding last night. She slammed it shut before either of us read a word, then put her fingers in my hair and pulled me down, and I knelt on her kitchen floor and put my mouth on her, and the ledger stayed closed until morning.

The kitchen smells like both of us. Her skin and rosemary burned at dawn and old paper and the roux that caught on the stove while I was on my knees and she forgot it existed.

She's at the sink. Hair still down from where I pulled the pencil out of it. Below her ear, the mark from my mouth she hasn't touched yet.

She won't sit.

I know what standing means. I have read a thousand rooms by how the people in them hold their weight, and standing means a person who wants the option of leaving.

Ondine Marchand doesn't leave her own kitchen. So why is she standing as if she might? What has she already guessed?

"Read it out loud," she says. "I can't look at her writing right now."

I sit. I open the ledger.



Honorine Marchand kept her records like every witch does. Her own pen, her own script, every term of a working set down plainly. A witch who hides the terms from herself is a witch who pays what she didn't intend.

One page, and the ink changes from the first entry to the last. Good iron gall at the top. Brown and thin at the bottom, where the grip weakened and the nib wandered.

The paper went brittle where it folded against itself inside a brick wall, for longer than Ondine has been alive.

The first entry is a date in old Marchand calendar. I know the letters but I can't convert the year. Under the date, a name.

"Jean-Pierre Marchand."

Her hands go flat on the counter.

"And beside the name," I say, "in the margin. A cause."

"By a wolf." Her voice is worn smooth from a lifetime of telling it. "On the Tchoupitoulas levee. She told me that part. The truce held. Nobody was punished. The Code doesn't reach the water."

"The wolf's name is here."

Silence.

I read it as I'd read a print in soft ground, for what it tells me about the person who put it there.

The handwriting around the name is Honorine's, steady and upright, a careful woman's script in a clean house. The wolf's name went in later. Darker ink, pressed harder into the fibers.

She found out who did it and she went back and wrote it in.

Had she already decided what she was going to buy? Or did the name come first and the decision after, as the blade comes before the cut?

"Hippolyte Arceneaux."

"She never told me that." Very low. "She knew who killed her husband and she never told me his name."

//



Second entry."

I keep my voice level. Level is the least I can give her.

"Consideration: delivered. The Arceneaux wolf. Dead within the month by the arrangement. The broker introduced the instrument. The principal accepts the obligation is discharged."

The faucet drips. The cat shifts on the sill and finds a different patch of sun.

"She bought a killing," Ondine says.

"Yes."

"Through a broker."

"The ledger doesn't name him. But the notations in the margin—"

"Match Cray's letter." She wraps her arms around herself, fingers digging into her own elbows. "Same serifs. Same patience. Same slope on every capital letter. I've been staring at Cray's writing since the envelope came, Silas. I know it better than I know my own."

Cray. The polite bastard has been in this kitchen longer than she has.

She turns her head enough that I can see the line of her jaw, the flour from last night gone, the bruise from my mouth still there.

Her weight is forward, on the balls of her feet, a woman getting ready to move with nowhere to move to in her own kitchen.

"The neutral house," she says. "The witch who never picks a side. Who holds names for both courts. Who doesn't ask who the working's for." Her arms tighten against her own ribs. "She taught me that. She sat at this table and taught me substitution and impartiality and the sanctity of a held name, and she'd already bought a killing with my name on the receipt."

"Witch. Stay in the room."

She exhales. Her shoulders drop a degree.

"I'm in the room."

"Stay in it."

"Read me the third entry."



I don't want to read the third entry.

I have read a manifest with my own designation on it, in a room that smelled like pine tar and sweat and the bastard who owned me. I have read orders that ended with bodies I had to move. I have read a king's ledger where names stopped appearing on dates I can trace to graves I dug.

Two hundred years behind men at desks, reading everything upside down and sideways and between the lines where the real terms live.

This is the worst fucking thing I have ever read right side up.

"Collateral." I hold my voice still, as I'd hold a blade. *"Pledged against the obligation of the Marchand line. One name, of weight, to be delivered upon demand."*

Her breathing stops. In the silence I can hear the canal outside, a bicycle bell, someone calling a name that isn't hers.

"What name?"

She already knows. I can read it in the set of her spine: a woman who heard the answer before the question finished.

"Ondine."

The kitchen holds her name like one of her jars holds a working.

"Written in the broker's hand," I tell her. "Not Honorine's."

Did Cray write it because she asked him to, or because he wanted his handwriting on what he was buying?

She turns around.

Her eyes are dry and her fingers are steady. I know the difference between a man running and a man falling, and this is a woman standing perfectly still while the fucking ground moves under her.

"She signed my name," Ondine says. "As surety. Before my mother was married. Before my mother was pregnant. Before anyone in this house knew there would be—"

"There's a note. Below the collateral line."

She closes her eyes. Breathes. Opens them.
"Read it."



The last entry is in a dying woman's hand.

The letters list to the right, heavy, losing the careful upright of the earlier work. The ink is thin, and two words are smudged under a drop thicker than tears.

I can smell it in the paper under the dust and the roux grease: camphor, blood, the medicine for the chest. She wrote this drowning from the inside.

How long did she sit with the pen before she started? How many times did she put it down?

"The wolf took my husband on the levee on a Sunday. The truce said I couldn't ask the court. The Code said I couldn't ask the King."

Ondine reaches behind her. Finds the counter. Holds on.

"The broker said I could ask him."

"I have nothing of weight but the line. The broker suggested the child my daughter will have. I don't know yet if my daughter will have a child. I am putting the name I would give her."

"Stop."

"If there is no child, the name has no weight, and the collateral is void. If there is a child, she will be a Marchand, and her name will hold every name this house holds, and that is the weight they want."

"I said stop."

"I am sorry for it. I am sorry for all of it. But Jean-Pierre is dead on the levee and the wolf is still breathing and I cannot die knowing he is."

I close the ledger. The binding shuts with a sound like a fist closing.



She doesn't cry.

I have seen men cry and I have made hard bastards cry, and crying has a direction to it. It goes somewhere, burns through what

it has to, reaches a bottom. What Ondine does is stand in her grandmother's kitchen in her grandmother's cardigan and go so still that the faucet drip sounds like a bell.

"She loved me."

Flat. Clear. The voice of a woman reading back the terms of a contract she didn't sign.

"She named me. She held me when I was born. She taught me salt-for-bone on this table when I was eight, and she'd pick me up afterward and there's still a salt stain on the wood grain from where I sat, and she loved me." Her fingers move along the counter, tracing the knife scars. "She loved me and she wrote my name on a piece of paper and gave it to a man in good shoes, and she died in her bed with a dead wolf and a clean conscience."

"Ondine—"

"She sold me before I breathed."

The sentence comes out of her as if she's been carrying it since the wax seal. Since *collateral* and the one name under it.

I stand. I know every board between the table and the sink by the sound it makes, and I cross them without making any.

I take her hands.

She lets me. Her fingers in my scarred palm, my thumb on her wrist where the pulse is fast and hard and honest.

I can feel the beat of it against the old burn tissue, the one part of my body that still registers heat as more than information.

Then she pulls free. Gently. The way you set down a jar you've decided not to break.

"Don't." Her eyes come up. "Don't try to finish a sentence about this. I can hear when you're about to force one, and whatever you build will be a lie, and you don't lie to me."

She's right.

"What do you need?" I ask. Because that much I can finish.

"I need this house to not be built on a murder." She pushes her hair off her face with both palms. "I need the neutral ground to be neutral. I need a whole working life of clients and held names and court obligations to not be resting on a grandmother who bought a

dead wolf with her granddaughter's name."

She looks at the shelves, at all the jars of names in this kitchen. Clients. Debts. Obligations from both sides of the canal, every one of them resting on the authority of the Marchand name.

All of them resting on her.

What does a woman look like when she finds out the ground under the house was salted before she was born?

She looks like Ondine. Standing in her own kitchen, arms at her sides, surveying the architecture of a life that was collateral before it started.

"I was paid for before I had a name."

She picks up the nearest jar. Green glass, small, a label in script I've never learned to read. She turns it in her fingers. Once. Twice.

She throws it against the far wall.

I read the throw as I read anything that moves. Overhand, from the shoulder, no wind-up. Aimed past the window, past the door, past me, at the one stretch of bare plaster in a kitchen where every other surface holds something she'd grieve.

Even now she's choosing where the damage lands.

Good. Let her break the whole fucking shelf.

The glass hits and the name-working inside it leaves a dark smudge that will never come out of the paint. It smells like burnt sugar and wet stone, and whatever name was in that jar is loose in the room now, and gone.

She reaches for another jar. Stops. Reads the label. Sets it back on the shelf.

"That's a child-naming," she says. "Belongs to a woman on Esplanade who's due in October."

Her fingers have stopped shaking. The steadiness is worse than the tremor.

"One jar," she says. "That's all."

She looks at the dark smudge on the wall, the broken glass on the floor, the ledger closed on the table with my blood dried in its crease.

"I'm not her. I'm not Honorine. I don't spend what isn't mine."

"Witch."

She looks at me.

"I know."

She holds my eyes for a long beat, and I don't know what she reads in them, and then she walks out of the kitchen.

Her bedroom door stays open, because Ondine's doors always stay open, and the bed creaks once, and then nothing.



I don't sweep the glass. The glass is hers to decide about.

I stay at the table with my palm on the closed ledger. Her silence comes through the wall. On the shelves, every other jar is still holding.

In my coat, against my chest, is the index card I took from the Bywater firm. Yellowed at the edges. My old designation, and one word after it.

The Roche boy — introduced.

The same word sits in Honorine's second entry. *The broker introduced the instrument.*

I haven't held the card beside the ledger to compare the writing. I'm not going to. Not tonight, not in her kitchen, not with her glass still on the floor.

What the fuck would I even do with it, if it were mine to give her?

I look at the window.

The rosemary burns down to ash and I let it.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN



Grief makes me clean. By noon every jar in the kitchen is relabeled and the cat has left home.



I start at dawn. Last night I left Silas sitting at the table with his palm on the closed ledger, and he's still there when I come out with my hair tied up and my sleeves pushed to my elbows. I'm still tender from his mouth in my grandmother's chair two nights ago. Every step reminds me, and this morning I hate that I like it.

He hasn't moved. I don't think he's moved all night.

"Don't," I tell him, before he can open his mouth.

He doesn't.

I take every jar off every shelf. Every goddamn one of them, and I count them as I go, because counting is better than thinking. I line them up along the long table and the counter and the floor, and I wipe them down one by one with vinegar water, and I read every label, and I write every one of them out again on a fresh card in my own hand.

Mine, this time. Not hers.

My grandmother's script is on half these jars. Upright and careful, the same hand that wrote *Jean-Pierre Marchand* and *Hippolyte*

Arceneaux and consideration: delivered.

I can't stand to look at it this morning. I peel off every one of her labels with my thumbnail and throw them in the stove and write the names out again myself, and the stove eats her handwriting one card at a time.

The cat watches me do a few shelves. Then he gets up off the windowsill, stretches, gives me a look of pure contempt, and walks out the back door. I haven't seen him since.

"He'll come back," Silas says from the table.

"He's a cat. He'll come back when I'm interesting again, the little shit."

"You're interesting now."

"I'm scrubbing jars at dawn because my grandmother bought a murder with my name. I'm not interesting, Silas. I'm fucking unhinged." I slap a new label on a jar of held debt from a wolf in Chalmette. "There's a difference."



By nine I've stopped crying and started thinking, and that's worse. Much fucking worse.

I'm holding a jar that belongs to the Aldric house. Green glass, heavy, one of a row on the bottom shelf with the Aldric mark scratched into the lid. Inside it, on a twist of paper, is a name, and with the name, a debt: a debt a vampire owed a wolf before I was born, held here, on neutral ground, so neither of them had to trust the other.

That's what this house is. That's what I am.

"Silas."

He looks up.

"Do you know what's on these shelves?"

"Debts."

"Names. Every one of these jars is a name somebody gave up to hold a promise. Wolf debts. Vampire debts. Court favors, pack favors, blood-oaths from before the truce." I set the Aldric jar down very carefully. "Half the obligations in New Orleans are sitting in

my kitchen, and the only reason they stay put is that the Marchand name holds them. My name. I'm the keeper. Every one of these jars is tied to me."

He's very still.

"If my name goes," I say, "all of them go with it. Every jar on these shelves passes with the collateral. Whoever holds my name holds every debt in this room. Half of both courts, owing *them*."

I look at the shelves. At every name in my own handwriting, drying.

"That's what the account wants," I whisper. "Not me. It never wanted me. It wants the house. It wants the whole city's debts in its pocket, and I'm the jar they come in."

"And me," Silas says, low.

I turn.

"Cray wants me too," he says. "He looked at me the whole time. *Any name of equal weight.*" His jaw works. "The King's enforcer. A man who stands at the King's door and reads his rooms. If my name's on that paper, the account gets its hand inside the crown."

"So he wants both."

"He wants whichever one he can get."

Every name is somebody's grave. My grandmother used to say that. I never knew what she meant until this morning.

How many graves am I keeping on these shelves? And whose name is going to go in the ground if I lose?



I work the problem the only way I know how.

Substitution. What stands in for what.

Salt for bone. Bone for hair. Honey for sugar, lard for butter.

There's nothing on this earth you can use for a name, except another name. That's the rule. That's the first rule.

So: a name, for a name.

I sit down at the table across from him and pull the copy of the obligation toward me, the one Cray left under my mat, and I read it as my grandmother taught me to read a contract: for who's in it,

never for what it says.

There are three names on this paper.

Honorine Marchand, at the foot, signing.

Ondine, in the collateral line.

And the broker's mark in the margin. *A. Cray*. Witnessing. Introducing. Holding.

Three names. That's all the paper knows.

I stare at them. There's a thought there, at the edge of my mind, a smell from a pot on the back burner.

I can't quite get to it, and it's driving me up the goddamn wall. Something about the three of them, and which ones are already bound, and which one—

"What?" Silas says.

"Nothing. Shit. Nothing." I shake my head. "I don't know. It'll come."

It doesn't come. I put the paper down and let it sit.

//



Tell me the part about killing him," Silas says.

"You already know. You heard him say it."

"I heard him say it. I want to hear you say it."

So I show him.

I get up and take a jar down from the top shelf. One of mine, a small one. A debt a client from Algiers owes her sister. I hold it up to the light.

"When my grandmother died," I tell him, "every jar in this kitchen was hers. Every debt was tied to her name. And the night she went, I felt every single one of them come to me. It was like being handed a whole sack of stones in the dark. I couldn't breathe right for days."

"They passed to you."

"They passed to me. Because I was the keeper under her. That's how a held debt works. It doesn't die with the holder. It goes up. Or down. To whoever's next in the chain." I set the jar back on its shelf. "Cray's holding my paper. If you kill him, it doesn't burn. It goes to

whoever he's holding it for. The principal. The account. Whatever the hell that is."

"And that's worse."

"That's much worse. Cray's a man. He's got a name and a house and a pair of stupid shoes. You can find him. You can talk to him." I look at the shelves. "The account's got a column of names on a page and no face at all."

Silas is quiet.

"So he stays alive," he says.

"He stays alive until we find another way."

"I don't like it."

"You don't have to like it. It's the rule. Rules don't care what you like." I sit back down. "That's what I love about rules, Silas. They're the only part of this house that's never lied to me."



At noon he stands up from the table.

"Come here," he says.

"Why?"

"Bring the knife."

I look at him. He's looking at the knife block by the stove. The long one, the carving knife my grandmother used on holiday hams.

"You want to teach me to stab somebody. Jesus Christ."

"I want to teach you to hold a knife so it doesn't get taken off you and put in your own throat." He holds out his good palm. "You picked one up the night on the step. You held it wrong."

"I held it fine."

"You held it like a spoon, witch."

I get up and get the knife.

He takes it from me and turns it over and gives it back to me, handle first. Then he steps behind me.

He's close. He's so close I can feel the cool of him all down my back, from my shoulders to my thighs. He reaches around me and takes my wrist in his fingers and turns it, slowly, until the blade's pointing down along my forearm instead of out.

"Like this," he says, low, right by my ear.

"That feels backward."

"It isn't. Point out, anybody can grab your wrist and turn it. Point down, along the arm, it's yours." His thumb presses into the inside of my wrist. "Grip with the last two fingers. Leave the first two free. They're for steering."

"Steering," I repeat.

"Yes."

I adjust my grip. His thumb stays on my wrist.

His chest is against my back now, flush, and I can feel the whole solid length of him. And lower down, against my ass, I can feel something else, and it isn't his knife.

I don't say anything. Neither does he. Holy shit, neither does he.

"Now step," he says, and his other palm comes down on my hip. "When they come at you, you don't go back. You go in. Step into them, inside their reach, and bring the blade up."

He moves my hip. I step. He steps with me, and his thigh slides against the back of mine, and his cock presses harder into me, and I lose my breath.

"Again," he says. His voice has gone rough.

"Silas."

"Again."

I step again. He moves with me, slow, all of him pressed against all of me, and his palm on my hip slides forward onto my belly, and his fingers spread there, and hold me back against him.

We stand like that in the middle of my kitchen, surrounded by every jar I own and my grandmother's handwriting burning in the stove. His thumb is on my wrist. His fingers are on my belly. His cock is hard against my ass, and I'm so wet I can feel it on my thighs, and my knees are shaking, and neither of us moves.

"You're not paying attention," he says into my hair.

Of course I'm not paying attention. How the hell is a woman supposed to learn knife-work with a vampire's cock pressed into her ass? Who teaches like this?

"Neither are you."

"No."

I tip my head back onto his shoulder. His mouth is right at my temple. I can feel his breath there, cool and uneven.

"The other night," I whisper. "You stayed."

"You asked."

"I asked the night before that, too."

"You asked better."

I laugh, and it comes out shaky, and his fingers tighten on my belly.

Then he lets go.

He steps back. The cool air rushes in where he was, all down my back, and I nearly stagger. He takes the knife out of my fingers and lays it on the table, very carefully, and looks at me with his eyes gone dark.

"Tonight," he says.

It's nearly a promise.

"Tonight," I agree, and I'm so turned on I could fucking scream.



I'm at the front window at dusk, folding clean dish towels because my hands won't be still, when I see them.

Three men. They come down the street from the canal end, not hurrying, not together, and they stop.

One takes the lamppost at the corner. One takes the fence across the street, leaning on it, as if he's waiting for a bus that doesn't run here. The third stands in the middle of the sidewalk, right in front of my gate, with his arms folded.

They aren't the hired men. These are different.

Their shoes are good. They stand very still, and they don't talk, and they don't blink.

They stop exactly where the salt line of my ward ends.

An inch past would put them inside. An inch short, and they'd be nowhere. They're right on the edge, where my grandmother's protection gives out and the city starts.

I stand behind my curtain with a dish towel in my fists and watch them watch my house.

"Silas," I say.

He's already beside me. I didn't hear him come.

"I see them," he says.

"Who are they?"

"Cray's."

"What do they want?"

He looks at them for a long while. At the lamppost. At the fence. At the man in front of my gate with his arms folded and his feet exactly on the edge of my salt.

"They want us to know," he says, "that they can count."

"Count what?"

"Nights."

The sun goes down, and they don't move.

The streetlamp comes on over their heads. They stand in it without blinking, shadows on the edge of my ward, waiting for the moon to get thinner.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN



They stand at the edge of the ward line all night, three of them, and they don't blink.



I check at ten. I check at eleven. I check at midnight with a cup of chamomile in my fist that I'm not drinking, standing behind the front curtain in my nightgown, and they're still there.

The one at the lamppost. The one on the fence across the street. The one at my gate with his arms folded and his good shoes planted exactly on the edge of my grandmother's salt.

They haven't moved. They haven't smoked, or checked a phone, or shifted their weight, or scratched their noses. They stand in the orange light of the streetlamp as if they've been painted there, and every so often the one at my gate tilts his head a fraction, a dog cocking its head at a sound in the walls, and my whole body goes cold.

"They can hear," I whisper.

"Yes."

Silas is behind me. He's been behind me all night, a cool weight at my back, never touching, never leaving.

"The ward doesn't stop sound?"

"Wards stop bodies. You know that better than me." His voice is very low, right at my ear. "They can't come through your gate. They can hear every word you say in this house."

"Every word."

"Every sound."

I think about that. I think about my kitchen table, and the chair, and the doorway of the workroom, and every noise I've made in this house in the last week with this man's mouth or fingers or cock in me.

My face goes hot.

"Oh, God," I whisper. "Silas. The other night."

"The other night they weren't here."

"You're sure?"

"I walked the fence at dawn. There were no prints." A pause. "Tonight there are."



I'm not afraid of him. I want to be clear about that, to myself if nobody else.

I'm afraid of the men at my gate. I'm afraid of their good shoes and their unblinking eyes and the way the one in the middle keeps tilting his head. I'm afraid of Cray, sitting somewhere in Bywater with his tea, being told what I sound like when I come.

But I've been afraid all week. I've been afraid since the envelope. I'm sick to death of being afraid in my own house.

How long am I supposed to stand behind a curtain in my nightgown, until the moon's gone and they've taken my name and every jar on my shelves?

And Silas said *tonight*.

I put the chamomile down on the windowsill. I turn around. He's right there, close enough that my breasts brush his shirt when I breathe, and he looks down at me with his eyes gone dark.

"You said tonight," I say.

"Ondine."

"You said it in the kitchen with your cock against my ass and your palm on my belly. You said *tonight*. It's tonight."

"They'll hear."

"Then make sure they don't."

He goes very still.

I watch him understand what I'm asking. I watch it move through him, and I watch the hunger come up in his face behind it, dark and slow and enormous, like water rising in a well.

"Ask me properly," he says, very low.

"Make sure they don't hear me." I lay my palm on his chest. "Put your hand over my mouth and fuck me. Right here. Against my grandmother's wall. With those men standing outside it."

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He doesn't move for a long moment.

Then he takes my wrist, the one on his chest, and turns me around. He does it slowly. He puts my palms flat on the wall beside the window, the front wall of the house, the one with the ward laid into its bones, and I feel the salt humming under the plaster against my skin.

He steps up behind me.

"Listen to me," he says in my ear. "Are you listening?"

"Yes."

"My hand over your mouth. You can't talk. You can't tell me to stop." His palm settles flat on my hip, heavy. "So if you want me to stop, you knock twice on this wall. Twice. Anytime. I stop. No matter what. No matter how close I am. Knock twice, and it's over. Say it back to me."

"If I want you to stop, I knock twice on the wall."

"And?"

"And you stop. No matter what."

"Again."

"If I knock twice, you stop. Anytime. No matter how close you are." My voice shakes. "Silas, I've got it."

"You're sure."

"I'm sure."

He says nothing for a heartbeat. Then his mouth comes down against the side of my throat, just below my ear, and he breathes me in.

"Knock twice," he says, "if I'm wrong."



He pulls my nightgown up.

He does it slowly, dragging the thin cotton up the backs of my thighs, over my ass, up to my waist, and he bunches it there in his fist. I'm naked under it. The cool night air from the window seam touches my bare skin and I shiver all over.

He puts his palm between my shoulder blades and pushes, gently, until my cheek is against the plaster and my back is bowed and my ass is pushed out toward him.

"Spread your feet."

I spread them.

"Wider."

I spread them wider. I can feel how wet I am. It's slick on the insides of my thighs.

He can see it. I know he can see it, because I hear his breath catch.

His fingers slide down the crease of my ass and between my legs and find me soaking.

"Fuck, witch," he whispers. "You're dripping. You're dripping down your legs. With them standing right there."

"Because of you."

"Because they can hear you?"

"Because you're going to stop them hearing me."

He makes a sound low in his chest, almost a growl.

He pushes two fingers into me from behind, hard and deep, no warning, and I gasp, loud, and his other palm comes around and clamps over my mouth.



It's his scarred palm. The right one.

It covers my mouth and half my face, rough and cool, the old burns pressing ropes into my lips. I can smell my own wet on his fingers and the salt from the wall and the faint cold iron smell of him.

I can breathe through my nose. I can't make a sound past his palm.

He fucks me with his fingers, slow and deep, while he holds my mouth shut.

I moan into his palm. It comes out muffled, a small trapped hum against his skin, and nobody outside could hear it, and knowing that makes me moan louder.

"Good," he says into my ear. "Good. Be as loud as you want. Nobody hears you but me."

His fingers curl. They find the place inside me and drag over it, over and over, and my knees buckle and he holds me up with his palm on my face and his fingers inside me.

I'm grinding back onto his hand. I'm fucking myself on his fingers against my grandmother's wall with a vampire's scarred palm over my mouth, and the men at my gate are a few yards away beyond the plaster, and they can't hear a thing.

The ward crackles.

I feel it under my palms. A sharp hot fizz, like fat hitting a skillet, running along the salt in the wall.

The ward knows him. It knows he's not Marchand, and he's pressed up against it, inside the house it guards, and it doesn't like it.

He doesn't care. He pushes a third finger into me.

I cry out into his palm. It stretches. It burns a little, the good burn, and I'm so wet it's running down my thighs, and I'm going to come on his fingers if he doesn't stop, and he doesn't stop.

"Not yet," he says.

He pulls his fingers out.

I whimper against his palm. He doesn't take it off my mouth. I hear his belt. I hear his zipper, a long rasp in the dark. Then I feel the

head of his cock, hot and blunt and thick, pressing against me from behind.

"Knock twice," he breathes, "if you want me to stop."

I don't knock.

He drives into me in one long hard stroke.



He's too big. He's always going to be too big. It splits me open and I scream into his palm, a full scream, my whole body arching off the wall, and all that comes out past his fingers is a muffled hum.

He holds still inside me. Buried to the hilt. His hips pressed flush against my ass, his cock stretching me so full I can feel him in my belly, and he's shaking.

"Breathe," he says. "Through your nose. Breathe for me."

I breathe. Through my nose, in shaky gulps.

His palm stays over my mouth. His other hand spreads on my belly, holding me back against him.

"Good girl," he whispers. "That's it."

I feel myself loosen around him, a fraction. He feels it too. He pulls back, slow, dragging his cock out of me almost to the head, and then he thrusts back in, hard.

Then he doesn't stop.

He fucks me rough. It's nothing like the doorway. In the doorway he was careful, so careful, stopping every time I winced. Tonight he holds my mouth shut and fucks me against the wall with long brutal strokes that knock me up onto my toes.

His hips slam into my ass. The slap of it is loud in the dark room. My palms are sliding on the plaster. The ward crackles and spits under them.

I'm moaning constantly now. I can't stop. Every thrust knocks a muffled cry out of me into his palm, and he just holds on tighter.

"You feel that?" he growls in my ear. "That's mine. You're mine. You stand in your own house and let me fuck you with those bastards at your gate, because you're mine."

I moan into his palm.

"Say it."

I can't say it. His palm is over my mouth. I nod, frantic, my cheek scraping the wall.

"I know," he says. "I know you are. Feel how deep I am. Feel it. You're dripping down my balls. Your cunt's squeezing me every time you try to scream. Bite my palm and come on my cock. Let them stand out there and hear nothing."



I bite him.

I don't plan to. It just happens. He drives into me so hard my teeth close on the edge of his palm, the scarred heel of it, and I bite down.

He goes still inside me.

I feel it hit him. Not pain. The burns don't feel much. Something else. His whole body locks up against my back, and his cock jerks inside me, and he makes a sound I've never heard from him, low and rough and broken.

And he lets go.

His fingers tighten on my face. His other palm leaves my belly and grabs my hip, hard enough to bruise. And he fucks me like a man who's stopped holding anything back at all.

It's brutal. It's so much. He's pounding into me from behind, his thighs slapping mine, his cock hitting so deep every stroke that I see white.

My knees are giving out and he doesn't let them. He holds me up with his palm on my mouth and his grip on my hip and his cock driving into me, and I'm pinned between him and the wall and the humming ward, with no way to move and no way to scream.

I could knock. My palm is right there on the plaster.

Two knocks and he'd stop. I know he would.

I don't knock.

I'm not going to be the Marchand who knocked. I'm not going to let those men at my gate be the reason I stopped the best fuck of my

life. I'm not going to give that bastard Cray the satisfaction.

I grind back onto him instead.

"Fuck," he snarls. "*Fuck, Ondine.*"

His palm slides down from my hip, around, between my legs, and his fingers find my clit and rub it, hard and fast, while he fucks me.

I come screaming into his palm.

It tears through me. My pussy clamps down on his cock so hard it hurts, in hard rhythmic pulses, and I'm shaking and sobbing and biting down on his scarred palm again, and he's still fucking me through it.

"Again," he says, rough. "Again, witch. Give me another one."

He doesn't stop rubbing my clit. He doesn't stop fucking me. The second one hits before the first one's finished, and I buck against him so hard my forehead knocks the wall.

And then he comes.

He slams into me one last time and holds there, buried deep, and groans into the back of my neck. I feel his cock pulse inside me. Over and over. Filling me. Hot and thick and so much of it, spilling into me, and he's shaking against my back and groaning my name into my hair, muffled, just as I'm muffled.

He came in me.

He promised on the phone, and he did.

◆ ◆ ◆

We stay like that for a good while.

His palm is still over my mouth. His cock is still inside me, softening. His forehead is on the back of my neck. My palms are flat on the plaster, and the ward has stopped crackling, and all I can hear is his breathing and mine.

Slowly, he takes his palm off my mouth.

There are teeth marks in it. My teeth. Two neat curved rows across the heel of his scarred palm, and one of them has drawn a thin bead of dark blood.

He looks at it for a long moment.

Then he eases out of me, slow, and I feel his come start to slide down the inside of my thigh. He turns me around by the shoulders, very gently, and looks at my face.

"Was that right?" he asks.

I stare at him.

He's asking. After all that. Who taught him to ask? Who in his whole life ever asked *him*? After holding my mouth shut and fucking me against the wall till I saw stars, he's standing there with his cock still out and my teeth marks in his palm, asking me like a man checking whether he locked the door.

"Was it too much?" he says. "I was rough. I held you. You didn't knock. I need to know if you didn't knock because you didn't want to, or because you couldn't."

"I didn't want to."

"You're sure."

"Silas." I put my palms on his face. "I'm sure. I thought about it. My palm was right there on the wall. I could have knocked any time I wanted. I didn't knock because I didn't want you to stop. Not once."

He closes his eyes.

"Okay," he says. "Yes. It was right."

"Okay."

He puts his forehead against mine, and we stand there in the dark with the ward humming low in the wall behind me, and the men still standing outside my gate, hearing nothing.



He carries me to bed afterward. He stays.

He lies on his back in my sheets and I lie on his chest, and he holds me there with his good arm and doesn't sleep, and I don't either. I trace the teeth marks on his palm with my fingertip.

"I'm sorry," I say.

"For what?"

"For biting."

"Don't be."

"It bled."

"It stopped." He closes his fingers around mine. "Do it again sometime."

I laugh against his chest. I can feel the laugh go through him too.

After a while, he says, "I have to go to Baratania tomorrow."

I lift my head. "Why?"

"The wolf. Arceneaux. I want to know where he's buried."

"Silas."

"I'll be gone a day. Maybe two." His palm moves on my back.

"You don't open the door for anyone."

"Anyone?"

He looks at me. His eyes are very dark in the dark.

"Anyone but me, witch."

CHAPTER SIXTEEN



“

Yeah, no,” Rémy Thibodeaux says. “Arceneaux doesn’t have a grave.”



He’s sitting at the end of the bar at Fontenot’s with a can of Coke sweating in front of him, the only man in the building not drinking anything with a proof on it. Fontenot’s is a fish camp at the end of a shell road in Barataria, a tin roof on pilings over black water, and the whole place smells of fryer oil and diesel and shrimp heads rotting in a bucket out back.

Rémy’s big. He’s always been big, sunburned across the nose and the backs of his arms, and he sits with his right arm held a little stiff against his side, where Aurelian broke it a long time ago and it never healed right. He doesn’t look at me when I sit down on the stool beside him. He looks at the Coke.

“Silas Roche,” he says. “Long way from the canal.”

“I’m looking for a wolf.”

“Lot of wolves out here.” He takes a pull of his Coke. “Most of them don’t want to be found by you, either. No offense.”

“None taken.”

“How’s Selene?”

It catches me off guard. I look at him, and he's still looking at the can, and his jaw is tight.

"Well," I say. "She's well. She stole the King's cream this morning."

Something moves at the corner of his mouth. It's gone before I can read it.

"Good," he says. "That's good. Tell her Delphine says she owes her a tea order."

"The wolf I'm looking for is dead," I say. "Hippolyte Arceneaux."

That's when he says it. *Yeah, no*. The way he's always said it, the Barataria way, flat and friendly and final, as if he's closing a gate.

"Everybody knows he doesn't have a grave," Rémy says. "The pack burned him. Out on the water, on a pirogue, the old way. Nothing left to bury."

"When?"

"Before my time." He turns the Coke can in a slow circle on the bar. "Before my daddy's time, near enough. You'd have to ask the old people."

I watch him turn the can.

Rémy Thibodeaux killed a man and his wife on their own porch once, because he was lied to. He spent years understanding what he'd done. He got very good at lying once, and very tired of it.

He's lying now. His thumb stops on the can every time he says *burned*.

What would make a man who's spent years learning to stop lying start again for a wolf that's been dead since before his daddy was grown?

"All right," I say.

He looks at me then, finally, sideways, and his face is careful.

"That's it? All right?"

"That's it."

He studies me. Then he picks up his Coke and drinks, and sets it down, and says, very low, without looking at me again:

"Don't go out to the old place after dark, Roche."



Gaspard Thibodeaux finds me in the parking lot.

He's the pack's alpha and has been since before the truce, a heavy gray man with a face as knotted as a cypress knee and a voice that comes up from somewhere under the ground. He comes out of the dark between the parked trucks with two of his sons at his back and stops a respectful distance from me, and nods.

"Silas Roche," he says.

"Gaspard Thibodeaux."

"You were at my son's elbow."

"I was asking him about a dead wolf."

"Hippolyte Arceneaux." He says it the old way, full, every syllable, as he says every name, as if a name were a thing you pay for and he means to get his money's worth. "What does the King's enforcer want with Hippolyte Arceneaux?"

"The King doesn't. I do."

"Why?"

I think about lying to him. I think about Ondine at her kitchen table, and the ledger, and her grandmother's name.

"A debt," I say.

Gaspard's face doesn't move. But his sons shift behind him, and I read that instead.

"Hippolyte Arceneaux was burned on the water," Gaspard says. "The old way. The pack saw to it. There is nothing to find in Barataria, Silas Roche, and nothing to dig up, and nobody out here who would thank you for digging."

"Rémy says the same."

"Rémy Thibodeaux is a good son."

"He is," I agree.

Gaspard looks at me for a long while. Then he nods, once, and turns away between the trucks, and his sons go with him.

The whole pack is lying to me, all of them in unison. What are they covering?



Delphine Thibodeaux brings me a glass of water before I leave.

She comes out of the kitchen door at the back of Fontenot's with it, a tall plastic tumbler full of ice, and hands it to me without being asked. She's Rémy's sister, sharp-faced and dark-eyed, and she smells of fryer oil and the lemon she's been cutting.

"You're driving out to the old Arceneaux place," she says.

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to. Everybody in there watched you ask." She tips her head back and sniffs the air, once, long, her nostrils flaring. "It's going to rain. About an hour. Maybe less."

The sky over the bayou is clear. Stars everywhere.

"It's clear."

"It's going to rain," she says again, patiently, as if I'm a child. "Drink your water, Silas Roche. Go do your stupid thing. Come back to the canal before it floods the road."

I drink the water. She takes the glass back.

"Tell the witch hello," she says, and goes inside.



The old Arceneaux place is at the end of a shell road even worse than Fontenot's.

It's a burned-out house on blocks, black timbers and a collapsed tin roof, cypress knees standing up out of the water all around it like a crowd at a wake. There's a tin shed behind it that didn't burn. There's a stand of old live oaks behind the shed, and behind those, the woods.

I get out of the truck and read the ground.

Somebody comes here.

It isn't often, and it's never many. A single person, alone. The shell drive has a single track down the middle of it that isn't mine, a small tire, a scooter or a light bike, pushed in by hand from the road. The same track comes and goes. It goes up to the shed and stops.

Then boots.

Small boots. A careful stride. Whoever wears them doesn't hurry, and doesn't stop to look around, and knows exactly where they're going.

I follow them around the shed.

There's a bucket behind it, half-buried in the weeds, tipped against the wall. I crouch down and look in.

Bulbs.

Dozens of them, papery and brown, the kind you plant in fall. Wild iris. And beside the bucket, lying in the dirt, a trowel with fresh black mud dried on the blade.

The boots go past the bucket. They go into the trees.

I stand at the edge of the woods and look after them. There's a path in there, narrow, one person wide, worn down to bare earth through the palmettos. It goes back into the dark under the oaks.

Somebody is planting iris in the Arceneaux woods. Somebody comes out here, alone, and puts bulbs in the ground, for a wolf who doesn't have a grave.

For whom, and what the fuck is back there?

I step onto the path.

The first drop of rain hits the back of my neck.

Then the sky opens up, all at once, a warm hard downpour out of a sky that was clear an hour ago, and the path in front of me turns to running mud in seconds, and every print on it washes away.

Fucking Delphine. Fucking weather-sniffing, lemon-cutting Delphine.



I sit in the truck with the rain drumming on the roof and the windshield running with water and call her.

She answers on the second ring.

"Where are you?"

"Barataria."

"I know that. Be specific."

"In a truck. In the rain."

"Delphine texted me," Ondine says. "She said to tell you she told you so."

I close my eyes.

"Are you in bed?" I ask.

"Where else would a prisoner be?" Her voice drops, goes warm and low and lazy. "You told me not to open the door for anyone. So I'm lying here with the door locked and no cat, doing absolutely nothing. It's very boring. I hope you're happy."

"I'm not happy."

"No." A pause. "Tell me."

"I'm in a truck in the rain in Barataria," I tell her, "and every fucking person I talked to tonight lied to me."

She says nothing for a moment.

"Even Rémy?"

"Especially Rémy."

"Shit," she says softly. "That's bad."

"I don't know yet."

"Come home, then."

"The road's flooded."

"Then tell me what you're wearing."

I open my eyes.

"Ondine."

"You're in a truck in the rain with nothing to do, and I'm in bed with nothing to do, and I've been thinking about your mouth all day." Her sheets rustle. "Tell me what you'd be doing, if you were here instead of there."

My cock answers before I do.

I look out at the rain. At the dark shape of the burned house through the water on the glass. At the black woods behind it, and the path I can't see.

"I'd be in your bed," I say. It comes out rough. "I'd pull that sheet off you. I'd put my mouth on your throat, and then your tits, and then I'd spread your legs and eat you until you forgot the cat ever left."

A small sound on the line. A catch in her breathing.

"Keep going."

"I'd make you come on my tongue," I tell her. "Twice. I'd hold your hips down so you couldn't get away from it. Then I'd turn you over and put you on your knees and fuck you slow, all the way in, until you begged me to go faster."

"And would you?"

"No. I'd make you wait. I'd make you cry for it. And when you were crying, I'd give it to you so hard you'd feel me for a week."

"Silas."

"You asked."

"I did." Her voice has gone ragged. "God, I did. Are you— is it—are you hard?"

"Yes."

"Good. Stay that way. Think about me the whole drive home." She lets out a shaky breath. "I've got my fingers between my legs, and I'm not going to do anything about it, because I want you to come home and do it."

I don't say anything. I can't.

"Come home," she whispers. "When the water goes down. Come home and do everything you just said."

"I will."

"Promise me."

"I promise, witch."

She hangs up.

I sit in the truck with the rain coming down and my cock aching and my phone in my fist, a two-hundred-year-old fool in a flooded parking lot, and I stay there until the worst of it passes.

She does this to me. Nobody's done this to me in my whole life. What the hell am I supposed to do with it?



When the rain slows to a drizzle, I get out and walk back around the shed, one more time. I tell myself I'm checking the path. The path is gone, a sheet of black water under the oaks.

But there's something new on the shed.

It's nailed to the door at eye level. A cream envelope, heavy stock, the rain beading on it and running off without soaking in. Nailed through the top edge with two good nails, driven by somebody who wanted it to hold in weather.

It wasn't there before the rain. I walked right past this door. He waited until I was busy.

My name is on the front of it. *Mr. Roche*. In a patient hand, with a familiar slope on every capital.

I stand in the drizzle and look at it.

He was here. While I sat in the truck with my eyes shut and her voice in my ear, telling her what I'd do to her, he walked up this shell drive in his thin shoes and nailed this to a dead wolf's door, and I didn't hear him.

I pull the nails with my fingers. I take it down.

I don't open it.

I put it in my coat, in the inside pocket, against the card from the firm.

Then I drive home to the canal with it riding against my chest the whole way.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN



Cray comes while Silas is gone. It's either rude or tactical, and with Cray those are the same thing.



He comes in the middle of the afternoon, in full daylight, with the sun hot on the street and the cicadas screaming in the oaks. He comes walking up from the canal end in his good coat, which must be miserable in this heat, and his thin clean shoes, carrying a white bakery box tied with string.

His men at the ward line don't move when he passes them. They don't look at him. He doesn't look at them either.

He stops at my gate.

Exactly at my gate. His toes are right on the edge of my grandmother's salt, the same as his men's, not a hair over. He stands there with his bakery box in both palms and looks up at my porch, where I'm sitting in my rocker with a bowl of snap beans in my lap and a paring knife in my fist.

I've been sitting out here since noon. I wanted them to see me.

"Miss Marchand," he says. "Good afternoon."

"Get off my step, broker."

"I'm not on your step." He glances down at his shoes, then back up at me, and smiles. "I'm on the city's sidewalk, and the city's

sidewalk is very generous about who stands on it. I brought pralines. From Loretta's. I'm told they're your favorite."

They are my favorite. The polite son of a bitch.

"How'd you know that?"

"I asked around." He holds the box out, over the line, toward nobody. "I'll leave them on your post, if you'd rather not come down."

"I'd rather you left."

"In a moment." He sets the box on my gatepost, squared to the edge, the same as the wine. "I came to talk to you. Mr. Roche is in Barataria, I believe, and I thought it would be a kindness to speak to you without him standing in your doorway looking at me as if he'd like to take my head off."

"He would like to take your head off. So would I."

"I know." Cray looks genuinely sad about it. "It's one of the things I like best about him."



I don't go down the steps. I don't put down my knife.

But I don't go inside, either, and he sees that, and his pleasant face shifts, very slightly, as a cat shifts when it hears a mouse in the wall.

"You've read your grandmother's ledger," he says.

My fingers tighten on the paring knife.

"How the hell do you know that?"

"Your face." He tilts his head. "You've learned what she bought, and what she paid. It's written all over you, Miss Marchand. You look like a woman who's found out her house was built on a grave."

"It was."

"Most houses are." He says it gently. "That's no reason to lose one."

"Is that what you tell yourself? When you walk away from a kitchen you've ruined?"

"I've never ruined a kitchen, Miss Marchand." He looks almost hurt. "I introduce people to what they already want. What they do in

their kitchens afterward is entirely their own affair."

I don't answer that. A snap bean breaks in my fist, loud in the heat.

"I came to make you an offer," Cray says. "A better one than the one on your paper. I'd hate for you to go into the new moon thinking there was only one way out."

"There's no way out. You told me. My name, or collection."

"Or a name of equal weight, freely given." He looks at me steadily. "I believe I mentioned that, too."

My stomach turns over.

"Say it plainly," I tell him.

"The enforcer's name for yours," Cray says. "Silas Roche. Freely given, at the new moon, and your paper is discharged. You keep your name, and your house, and every jar on your shelves. You never see me again."

"No."

"I haven't finished."

"You're finished. No."

"He'd give it," Cray says softly. "You know he would."

"Shut up."

"He'd give it the moment I asked, if he thought it would keep you. He's been waiting to give it to somebody his whole life." He tilts his head. "You've seen it on him. That look he gets at the end of your table, as if he's already halfway out the door and wants somebody to call him back. That's a man looking for someone to hand himself to."

"Shut up."



The cicadas are so loud. The sun is so hot. I'm sitting on my porch with a bowl of beans and a knife in my fist, and the whole street has gone very far away.

"Get off my step," I say again. My voice cracks on it. "Broker."

"I'm not on your step, Miss Marchand."

"Get off it anyway."

He studies me. Then he inclines his head, very politely.

"Of course," he says. "Enjoy the pralines."

He turns to go. He gets a little way down the sidewalk, past the man at the lamppost, and then he stops, and half turns, and looks back at me over his shoulder, his face bright and fond in the afternoon sun.

"I introduced him to his last owner, too," he says. "Did he never tell you?"

He goes.

I sit on my porch and watch him walk away down the street toward the canal, unhurried in his good coat, until the heat shimmer swallows him.

His last owner.

What does that mean? Silas doesn't have an owner.

Silas has a king. Silas has never had anybody at all.

Has he?



I don't eat the pralines. I don't even touch the box. I leave it sitting on my gatepost in the sun, where the ants find it by five.

I go inside and lock the door. I never lock the door. I lean my back against it and slide down onto the floor of my front hall and sit there.

He'd give it.

That's the part that won't leave. The offer I can stand. The grave under the house I can stand. *His last owner*, whatever the hell that means, I can stand.

He'd give it.

Cray's right. That's the worst of it. Silas would give it.

He'd stand on a step at the new moon and give his name away without blinking, if he thought it would keep my name on my jars. He'd do it without asking me. He'd do it and never finish a sentence about why.

And I'd have to live the rest of my life knowing I let him.

I put my face in my palms and I sit there on the floor until the light in the hall goes orange.



I don't mean to touch myself. I swear to God I don't mean to.

But I'm lying in my bed at dusk with the shutters open and the heat pressing down on me, heavy as a quilt, and I can't stop thinking about him. About his palm over my mouth two nights ago. About his cock driving into me against the wall while the ward spat under my fingers. About *knock twice if I'm wrong*, and the teeth marks I left in his hand.

About the men at my gate, standing there right now, listening.

They can hear everything in this house. Silas said so.

I think about that for a long moment.

Then I pull my nightgown up to my waist and spread my knees on the sheets.

I'm already wet. Of course I'm wet. I've been wet since his voice on the phone last night. I don't think I've been dry for a week. I slide two fingers down through my pussy and they come up slick, and I circle my clit, slow, and my hips come up off the mattress to meet my own hand.

Let them listen.

Let them go back to Bywater and tell that polite bastard exactly what they heard.

I push two fingers inside myself, deep, and I think about Silas on his knees in my grandmother's chair, eating me until I cried. I think about his voice, rough and filthy, *come in my mouth, witch*. I rub my clit with my thumb while I fuck myself with my fingers, and I don't bite the pillow, and I don't keep silent.

"Silas," I say.

Out loud. Clearly. My voice goes out through my open shutters into the hot evening air, toward the gate.

"Silas."

I curl my fingers inside myself and grind my palm against my clit, and I say his name again, louder, and again, and my thighs are

shaking and my back is arching off the bed.

His name. *His*, and nobody else's, and every one of those bastards at my gate can go straight to hell.

"Silas— oh, God, Silas, *yes*—"

I come with his name in my mouth, loud enough for the whole street to hear.

My pussy clenches around my own fingers, hard, over and over. My heels dig into the mattress. I sob his name one last time into the orange dusk, and then I lie there panting with my nightgown around my waist and my fingers still inside me and my heart slamming.

Let them tell Cray that. Let them tell him every filthy word.

Let him know exactly whose name this house is saying.



He calls at ten. The road's open.

"I'm on the way," he says. "Soon."

"Okay."

He hears it. Of course he hears it. There's a long pause on the line.

"What happened?"

"Cray came."

The silence on the other end is so complete I think the call's dropped.

"He didn't cross," I say quickly. "Silas, breathe. He stood at the gate. He brought pralines. From Loretta's. The ants got them."

"What did he want?"

I close my eyes. I'm sitting on the floor of my kitchen with my back against the stove, where the ledger lives behind its brick.

"He offered me a trade," I say.

"What trade?"

"Your name for mine."

Nothing. He isn't even breathing.

"I told him no," I say. "I told him to get off my step. I told him twice." My voice starts to shake. "Silas. Listen to me. I told him no."

"I heard you."

"Did you?"

"Yes." A pause. Then, very low: "Lock your door, witch. I'm coming."

He hangs up.

I sit on my kitchen floor with the phone in my lap, and I think about how he didn't say *good*. He didn't say *I'd never*. He didn't say *of course not*.

He said *I heard you*.

He'd give it.

God help me, that's what frightens me most.

He'd give it, and he'd never tell me until it was done.

INTERSTITIAL

Cray



The catcher kept his dogs in a yard behind a feed store, north of the city, where the road went to mud.

A house on the canal wanted a tracker. A broker is only as good as his knowledge of who keeps what, and I knew the catcher kept something unusual. So I put on a good coat and my thinnest shoes and went up the mud road on a gray morning, and I stood at the edge of his pen.

The catcher smelled of tobacco and wet rope, and he was very proud of his yard.

“That one,” he said, and pointed. “He’ll bite.”



The boy was chained low.

He was newly turned. I could see it in how he held himself, too still, as the new ones are before they learn to pretend to breathe. He crouched in the mud against the post with his arms around his knees, and his fists were wrapped in rags that had once been white.

Under the rags, the burns. I could smell them from the fence. Someone had turned him before the fire finished its work, and the skin would never be given the chance to heal. It would stay as it was,

forever.

His eyes were on the ground.

He never looked at me, or at the catcher. He was reading the mud between his bare feet. I watched his gaze move over my prints where I had come up to the fence, then over the catcher's, then back to mine, and stop there.

He knew my shoes.

He had learned them from the ground in the time it took me to walk up.

"Doesn't talk," the catcher said. "Won't say a word since the fire."

"Does he track?"

"Best I've ever had." He spat. "Bites, though."

I waited. The boy did not bite. He crouched with his wrapped fists in his lap and his eyes on my shoes, so still that the flies walked on him.

I have seldom met stillness like that.



There were river men who would have paid a great deal more.

Smugglers, who would have put the boy in a skiff, pointed him at the dark, and used him until the marsh took him.

I could have introduced him to them. It would have been a very good introduction.

I chose the old King instead.

Why did I? I have asked myself, now and then, over the long years since. I believe it was the stillness. A house with a great many doors needs someone at them who does not fidget. A house with a great many rooms needs someone who reads them without being asked. The boy had already read the whole yard. He would have read a palace inside a week.

Would you send that into a swamp?

I would not.

So I made the introduction. The old King's man came up the mud road the next morning with the money, and the catcher counted it

and unlocked the chain. The boy stood up out of the mud. He followed the King's man down the road with his eyes on the ground.

He never once looked back at the yard.



The catcher's clerk wrote the receipt in brown ink, at a table in the feed store, while the flies circled.

The catcher had a word for what he kept in his yard. He used it, and the clerk put it on the paper without looking up.

I have never cared for that word. I have never once used it.

It was always inaccurate, and inaccuracy offends me. But it was not my receipt to correct.

At the bottom, the clerk wrote my name, as the man who made the introduction. Then he folded it small and handed it to me, because brokers keep the paper.

I have kept it ever since, in a drawer, in a sleeve. I took it out now and then to look at it. A receipt is a key to a room not yet built. One keeps it, and waits to see whether the house goes up.



Tonight I took it out again and read it through in the lamplight.

Turned too soon. Tracks well. Holds what he's told to hold.

Does not speak of it.

He still doesn't. I have stood behind an oak on a canal road and watched him not speak of it every night of a long season. He carries it as though it were part of his neck.

The witch refused me today, on her porch, with a paring knife in her fist. She told me more than once to get off a step I was not standing on. I admired it enormously.

Then she went inside and said his name, with the shutters open, over and over, until my men at the gate did not know where to look.

It was a very clear message.

So I will send him mine.

I put the receipt in an envelope with a brief note, sealed it with my mark, and chose where to leave it. Somewhere he will go looking for something else, and find it, and carry it home unread against his chest, as he carries everything.

He will read it eventually. They always do.

And then he will come to me, because he will want to know who stood at the edge of the pen.

I will tell him.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN



Silas comes back from Barataria smelling like shrimp boats and bad decisions.



He comes in the kitchen door at half past eleven with mud to his knees and his hair still damp from the rain, and he stops in the doorway, and he looks at me.

I'm at the table. I've been sitting at this goddamn table since his phone call, with a cup of coffee going cold at his place and my own untouched in front of me, listening to the cat not come home.

"You locked the door," he says.

"You told me to."

"You never do what I tell you."

"I did tonight."

He crosses the kitchen. He stops at the end of the table, where he always stops, and he picks up the cold coffee and drinks it in one swallow, as a man drinks water after a long walk. Then he puts the cup down and just stands there, looking at me with his jaw set.

And I smell it.

Under the mud and the rain and the diesel and the shrimp, there's another smell on him. Clove. Beeswax. And paper, the good thick cream-colored kind, with a faint sweet smell of sealing wax.

Cray's paper.

It's in his coat. I can smell exactly where. The inside pocket, over his heart, where the writ used to live.

I don't ask.

I look at his face, and I know that if I ask, he'll look at the window. He'll give me an answer that's true and not complete. And I can't stand to watch him do it tonight.

So I don't ask.

"Come to bed," I say instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

He doesn't say anything. He follows me down the hall.

In my bedroom, I light the lamp on the dresser and turn it low. I take off my cardigan.

I'm wearing a thin slip under it and nothing else, and I pull that off too, over my head, and drop it on the floor. Then I turn around and stand in front of him in the lamplight, naked, and let him look.

He looks for a long while.

"Your turn," I tell him.

He takes off his coat. He does it slowly, and he folds it, and he lays it over the chair by the door with the inside pocket turned toward the wall.

I watch him do that. I don't say a word about it.

Then his shirt. His boots. His trousers.

Holy shit. I've had him in the dark, and in the doorway, and against the wall. I've had his cock in my fist in my grandmother's chair. I've never seen him naked in the light.

He's lean and pale and hard all over, scarred in places I didn't know about: a long pale line across his ribs, a knot of old tissue at his shoulder. The burns don't stop at his wrist. They go up his forearm in ropes and whorls, up to the elbow. And his cock is already hard, thick and heavy against his belly, flushed dark at the head.

"Lie down," he says.

His voice has gone low and rough. It isn't a request.

"On your front."



I lie down on my front across my bed with my cheek on the pillow and my arms folded under it.

He kneels on the mattress behind me. I feel it dip. I feel his palms settle on the backs of my thighs, cool and heavy, and slide slowly up, over the curve of my ass, up my spine to my shoulder blades and back down again.

"You're shaking," he says.

"I'm cold."

"You're not cold."

"No," I admit. "I'm fucking terrified and I'm soaking wet, and I don't know what's winning."

His palms spread my thighs apart. Gently. Wider, until my knees are sliding on the sheet and I'm open to him from behind and I can feel the cool air of the room on my pussy.

I'm wet. I've been wet since he walked in the kitchen door smelling of rain. I feel his thumb drag through me, slow, and I shiver all over.

"Soaked," he says softly. "You've been waiting for me."

"All day."

"Cray came to your gate."

"And I told him to get off my step."

"You told me." His thumb circles my hole, slow, not pushing in. "You told me twice. I heard you both times."

He pushes his thumb in.

I gasp into the pillow. He holds it there, just his thumb, deep, and presses down, and I rock back onto it without meaning to.

"He said a thing to me," I tell the pillow. My voice is shaking. "Before he left. He turned around at the corner and said it over his shoulder."

His thumb stops moving.

"What did he say?"

"He said he introduced you to your last owner, too. What the hell does that mean, Silas?"

◆ ◆ ◆

The room goes very still.

His thumb is still inside me. His other palm is flat on the small of my back. And he doesn't move, not at all, for so long I start to think he's stopped breathing, which he doesn't need to do anyway.

"Silas," I whisper. "Who was your last owner?"

Slowly, he eases his thumb out of me.

Is he going to leave? I think he's going to leave. I think he's going to get up off the bed and put his clothes on and go to the guest room and lock the door on the inside, and I'll lie here with my face in the pillow and never know.

He doesn't leave.

He moves up over me instead. He lowers himself down onto my back, all of him, his chest to my spine and his thighs against mine, and I feel the weight of him press me into the mattress. I feel his cock, hard and hot, slide into the crease of my ass, and then lower, between my thighs, and nudge against my pussy.

"Can I?" he says into my hair.

"Yes."

"Ondine."

"Yes. God. Yes, please."

He pushes into me.

Slow. So slow. The head of his cock stretches me open and I bite the pillow and he keeps going, slowly, deeper and deeper, until his hips are flush against my ass and he's buried inside me to the root and I'm so full I can't think.

He stays there. He doesn't move.

And then, with his cock inside me and his mouth against the back of my neck, he starts to talk.

◆ ◆ ◆

//

There was a fire," he says.

I go still under him.

"A house on a river. Somebody set it." He draws back, slow, his cock dragging out of me, and then pushes back in, just as slow. "I was—"

It stops. He thrusts into me again, slow and deep, and I feel it up the length of my spine.

"Whose house?" I ask.

"My mother's." His breath is ragged against my neck. "There was somebody in the back. I went in for—"

It stops again.

"For her," I say. "You went back in for her."

He doesn't answer. He fucks me, slow and steady, long strokes that drag every inch of him out and push every inch back in. His palm slides under me and spreads flat on my belly and holds me there.

"The burns are from that," he says. "After, in the road, I was—"

"Dying."

"Yes."

"And somebody found you."

"A catcher. He caught people for money." His hips roll into me, deep. "He saw a burned boy in a road and thought, that one will never hold a gun, but that one will track."

"Silas."

"He turned me. There, in the road, before the burns could heal. Vampires heal what's done to them after. Never what came before." His voice cracks. "So they stay. Forever."

I'm crying. I can't help it. How long did he carry this without saying one word of it? Who was the last person he told? He's inside me, slow and deep, telling me this into the back of my neck, and I'm crying into my pillow.

"Don't stop," I whisper. "Please. Don't stop. Either one."

He doesn't stop.





He kept a yard," he says. "Behind a feed store, north of the city. A chain. A post." His cock drags out of me and slides back in. "Runaways, debtors, anybody somebody paid him to find. He'd put me on the trail, and I'd—"

"Find them."

"Yes."

His palm presses on my belly, pushing me back onto him, and I moan into the pillow. He's hitting something deep inside me with every stroke, slow and relentless, and it's building even while I cry, a thick heavy ache between my thighs.

"He had a name for it," he says. "For what he kept. He called it out every morning when he came with the keys. Come here, and the name. And I'd—"

I reach back blindly and find his thigh and hold on.

"I was somebody's dog once—" he says.

And stops.

It's the most I've ever heard him say about himself. It hangs there in the dark room, one breath from finished, and I feel him try to say the rest of it, and I feel it not come.

"I know," I whisper. "I know. You don't have to."

"I want to."

"You nearly did. That's enough for tonight."

He presses his face into the back of my neck and makes a sound I've never heard from anyone, low and broken.

"Then the King's man came up the road with money," he says, rough. "And the catcher unlocked the chain. And I stood up and I—"

"Followed him."

"Yes."

"And you never said thank you."

"No." A harsh breath. "Never. Not once."

"Everybody knows that," I tell him. "It's all right."

"It isn't."

"It's all right with me."

He goes still inside me, buried deep.

"I don't want to talk about him anymore," he says.

"Then don't."

"I want to talk about you."



He pulls out of me.

I whimper at the loss. He rolls me over onto my back, gently, and looks down at my face, wet with tears, in the lamplight. Then he pushes my knees up and wide, and settles between them, and slides back inside me in one long stroke, and I cry out.

"There," he says. "I want to watch you."

"Silas—"

"You're so wet." He rocks into me, deep, and holds there. "You're dripping all over my cock. Do you feel how wet you are, witch? Listen to it."

He pulls back and drives in again, and the sound of it is obscene, slick and loud in my quiet bedroom.

"God," I gasp. "You're filthy."

"You made me this way."

"I did not."

"You did. Every night at the end of your table. Every night I walked home hard." He fucks me slow and deep, watching my face. "I used to stand under the streetlamp and think about this. Your knees up. Your pussy stretched around my cock. Your tits bouncing every time I pushed into you."

"Oh, fuck—"

"Tell me it's good."

"It's good."

"Tell me how good."

"So good I can't see. So good I can feel you in my throat. Fuck me harder and I'll tell you in French."

He speeds up.

He fucks me harder now, long hard strokes that shove me up the bed, and his palm slides between us and finds my clit and rubs. My back arches off the mattress. My heels dig into his ass and pull him

in deeper.

"There," he says. "Right there. You're squeezing me so tight I can barely move. You want to come?"

"Yes—"

"Ask me."

"Please. Please let me come. Please, Silas—"

"Not yet."

"You *bastard*—"

"Not yet, witch."

He pulls his thumb off my clit and keeps fucking me, deep and steady, and I'm right on the edge, trembling, clawing at his back. He watches me the whole time. He reads my face as he reads a stretch of road, missing nothing, and every time I get close he slows down and every time I start to fall back he speeds up.

"Look at you," he says. "Look at you, begging for my cock."

"I'm not begging."

"You are."

"I'm *demanding*—"

He laughs. He actually laughs, low and rough, with his cock buried in me, and it goes through me like a jolt.

Then he puts his thumb back on my clit and fucks me hard, and I come screaming.

It rips through me. My pussy clamps down on his cock in hard, helpless pulses, and my thighs lock around his hips, and I'm sobbing and swearing and clutching at his back, and he doesn't stop. He fucks me through it, relentless, his thumb working my clit, dragging it out until I'm shaking all over.

"Again," he says.

"I can't—"

"You can. One more. Come on my cock one more time and then I'll fill you up."

"Oh my God—"

He doesn't let up. He grinds into me and rubs my clit in tight hard circles, and the second one builds on top of the first before the first has even finished, and I come again with my back arched and

my nails in his shoulders and his name tearing out of my throat.

"Silas—"

"Yes," he says. "Yes. Ondine. Ondine, I'm going to—"

"Come in me. Please. I want it. Give it to me—"

He comes.

He doesn't hold anything back. He doesn't pull out. He drives into me as deep as he can go and holds there, and groans my name into my throat, and I feel his cock pulse inside me, over and over, filling me, hot and deep.

His whole body shakes on top of mine. His arms come around me and hold on so tight I can barely breathe.

He's shaking so hard the bed moves.

He's letting go. Has he ever let go like this, with anyone, in all that time?

I lie under him and hold on to his back and let him.



We lie there for a good while.

He stays inside me. He stays on top of me, all his weight pressing me into the mattress, his face buried in my neck, and I don't ask him to move.

I can feel his come slowly leaking out of me onto the sheet. I can feel his heartbeat, which vampires have, it turns out, faint and slow against my breasts.

Eventually he rolls off onto his side, and pulls me back against his chest, and curls around me.

"You almost finished a sentence," I say into the dark.

He's silent for a long moment.

"Don't get used to it," he says.

I laugh. I can't help it. It comes out wet and wrecked, and he laughs too, low and rough against the back of my neck, twice in one night.

On the chair by the door, his coat is folded with the inside pocket to the wall. I can still smell the cream paper from here.

I don't ask.

The cat, who has apparently decided I'm interesting again, comes in through the open window and jumps up on the bed and sits on his hip.

Silas goes rigid.

"There's a cat on me," he says.

"He likes you."

"He's never liked me."

"He likes you tonight." I pat the cat. "Don't get used to it."

CHAPTER NINETEEN



The envelope says what I have never let anyone say to my face. It says it in brown ink on paper gone soft as cloth, and paper never has the decency to look away.



I've carried it since Barataria. Cream stock, nailed to a dead wolf's shed with my name on the front, riding in my coat where the writ used to live.

Ondine smelled it on me the minute I came through her door. She didn't ask about it. She took me to bed instead, and I talked more tonight than I have in my whole life.

Now she's asleep on her front with the sheet at her waist, and I'm out on her back step with her letter knife.

Her garden smells of wet mint and the frog's green water and the last of the jasmine on the fence. The moon over the canal is thinner than it was last night. I don't count what's left of it, because I don't have to.

The envelope tells me things before I open it. There are two nail holes through the top edge, rusted brown, from a nail driven by someone who wanted it to hold in weather. The corners are soft where my coat has rubbed them. The seal hasn't been lifted and pressed back down. Nobody between the shed and my pocket

wanted to know what was in it.

He knew I'd carry it for days before I read it. He wrote it for a man who waits.

I slit the seal.



There are two papers inside.

The top one is new, Cray's stock with Cray's patient slope on every capital. I set it face down on the step, because a man who puts the pleasant paper on top wants you to read it first.

The bottom one was folded in thirds by somebody who expected it to live in a drawer. The creases have gone brown, and it opens along them with a sound like dry leaves.

It's a receipt.

Received of the house of Croix, for the Roche boy, the catcher's dog: consideration in full.

Turned too soon. Hands burned, will not heal. Tracks well. Holds what he's told to hold.

Does not speak of it.

Introduced by A. Cray.

I read it upside down first, from habit, then turn it right side up and read it again. The clerk who wrote *does not speak of it* knew me better than anyone alive does now.

Dog.

Nobody has said that to my face since the yard. The man who kept the kennel said it every morning with his boot on the chain.

I have spent every night since making sure nobody else gets close enough to try. Aurelian never said it, and Lucian never has.

Introduced by A. Cray. Of fucking course.

I always believed Aurelian found me himself, that he came down to that yard big and warm and saw something in the mud worth the money. I never once asked who told him where the yard was.

I remember shoes.

Thin soles in the yard mud, and a man at the edge of the pen who never looked down at what he was standing in. I was chained low

with my eyes on the ground, because the ground was the only thing in that place that didn't lie to me.

I watched those shoes come and go, and I never lifted my head to see the face above them.

I have been following those shoes around this city since the crowning.

I have been following them a hell of a lot longer than that.

He's the man who sold me.

I was—

I fold the receipt back along its creases. It doesn't matter what I was.



The new paper says less. Cray never needs much.

Mr. Roche,

You were introduced once before and did well by it. The Marchand obligation may be discharged by any name of equal weight, freely given. I have considered the weights. Yours would serve.

I'm at home most evenings. Do come by. I'll open something good.

A.C.

I look back at the kitchen window. Her lamp is off, and the rosemary on the sill has gone cold.

I go.



Bywater after midnight smells like river mud and bread proofing in somebody's back room, and the sweet rot of a banana tree dropping fruit nobody bothers to pick up.

The street reads the same as it always does. A man on a porch two doors down sees my coat and finds a reason to go inside. A cat crosses in front of me without hurrying, so nothing on this block has frightened it in a while. The gutters are dry except outside one house, where somebody rinsed the step tonight and swept the water toward the street.

Cray's house is a shotgun double painted the color of weak tea. I've stood across the street from it more fucking nights than I'll admit, in sight, never in custody, and not once has it looked like it was expecting me.

Tonight it does.

The porch light is on. The gate latch has been lifted and left resting on the post instead of in the catch.

The front step is worn into a shallow dip at the center by one stride and one pair of shoes, with no second set of wear anywhere on the wood. Nobody visits this man, and nobody has in years.

Through the front window I can see a table, and on it, two glasses.

He set the second one out before I finished reading.

I don't knock. He'd enjoy a knock.

//



Mr. Roche."

He's in the front room in shirtsleeves and a dark waistcoat, on his feet, as if he rose the moment my weight touched the step. He smells of clove and cold ash and beeswax, and under all of it, paper.

"You came in your working coat," he says. "I'm flattered."

"You were in the yard."

"I was." He pours. The bottle has wax on the neck and an old label I've seen in the Aldric cellar. "Sit, please. You won't, I know. It's polite to offer."

"You stood at the edge of the pen."

"I did. The man who kept it told me you'd bite."

He sets a glass at the near end of the table, exactly where a man who won't sit would stand. He knows where I stand.

"You didn't bite," he says. "You were very still. I remember thinking a stillness like that would suit a house with a great many doors."

"So you sold me."

"I introduced you." He says it gently, as if he's correcting a child's grammar at the dinner table. "I've never sold anyone

anything, Mr. Roche."

"The paper says consideration in full."

"The paper was written by a clerk. There were river men who'd have paid more for a tracker. I chose the old King instead. I thought you'd do well in his house."

He lifts his own glass an inch.

"You did."

My fist is closed in my coat pocket. The burned palm doesn't feel my nails, and it hasn't felt much of anything since before I was turned.

"Why send it?"

"Because you'd have found it. You found the card at the firm." His eyes stay pleasant. "I preferred you hear it from the man who made the introduction. It seemed a courtesy."

The bastard is handing me the end of the leash so I'll know exactly how long it is.

"I bought your king a glass of this once," Cray says, and turns the bottle so the label faces me. "At a bar, before he was king. He didn't touch it. His father never did either."

"Lucian doesn't drink from strangers."

"No. He was raised well. I've always admired that house."



Say it plainly," I tell him.

"Your name for hers."

He sits, since I won't. He crosses one knee over the other, and his thin sole turns up toward the lamp, clean as the day it was cut.

"Freely given, and the Marchand paper is discharged," he says. "She keeps her name. She keeps her shelves and everything on them. She keeps her cat."

"And me?"

"You go on exactly as you are." He opens his palm, generous. "You stand at your king's door. You keep his confidence. You read his rooms for him."

"And?"

"And you'd simply have somewhere else to bring what you notice."

A man inside the crown, reporting to the account. A dog in the King's house again, with a longer chain and a nicer fucking yard.

"The writ," I say.

"Stays, of course. Your king's protection over her house is a lovely piece of paper, and I'd never ask you to withdraw it." He considers a word before he spends it. "That would be unkind."

"You don't do unkind."

"I try not to. It's so rarely necessary." He tips his head toward the river, toward her house on the far side of the city. "Her grandmother refused me too, you know. The first time I came to that kitchen. She threw a jar at my feet."

My chest goes still.

"Ondine threw one at a wall," I say, before I can stop it.

"Then she's very like her," Cray says fondly. "Honorine came around before the kettle boiled."



Who's it for?"

"The account."

"Who's the account?"

He smiles. It's a real smile, warm and a little sorry, as if I've asked a good question at a funeral.

"Older than this house, Mr. Roche. Older than your king's. It has never been in a hurry about anything, and it has never once been refused."

What does it want with a pair of eyes in Lucian's house that it can't already buy? Why does a thing that old need a dog at all? And how thin does the moon get before it stops asking this nicely?

"Cassian was yours," I say.

"Cassian was a client." He sips. "The old man never met the witch. He preferred a broker between."

Lucian gave me Cassian's last words the morning after, standing in the courtyard with the plain blade still on the bench.

These are the same words, near enough. One man said them with blood in his mouth. This one says them over brandy.



I could kill him before he sets the fucking glass down.

I know it in my shoulders. Across the table, one fist in his collar, his head into the corner of the mantel, then the throat. It would take less time than it takes him to swallow.

He watches me know it, and he doesn't move.

"You could," he says. "I'd understand. But the paper goes home when I do, Mr. Roche, and where it goes, nobody reads upside down."

He knows I read upside down. He watched me learn it, from the edge of a pen, and at every desk since.

He stands. He corks the bottle and holds it out to me by the neck, the same as he held the wine on her step.

"Take it, please. It was always meant for your house."

I take it by the neck.

I don't decide to close my fist. It closes. The glass gives with a flat crack, and brandy runs down my wrist into my sleeve and all over the rug the bastard is so proud of.

Shards go into the burned palm deep enough to stay there on their own. The scar tissue barely reports it. What it reports is heat, the old kind, and I stand in the smell of spilled brandy and my own blood and make myself not take the last step.

Cray looks at his rug, and then at me.

He takes a folded handkerchief from his waistcoat and holds it out, pressed and monogrammed.

"You're bleeding on the Aldric vintage," he says. "Keep it. I have others."

I don't take it. He sets it on the table beside my full glass, squared to the edge.

"Think about it," he says. "That's all I've ever asked of anyone."

I look at him for a long while.

"I'll think about it."

His face does nothing at all, and that's how I know I've given him more than he set the second glass out for.

◆ ◆ ◆

Her kitchen light is on when I get back.

A whole bundle of rosemary is smoldering in the saucer on the sill. She's at the table in the holey cardigan and a pair of my socks, the letter knife back on its hook, watching the door as if she's watched it since the moment I went through it.

"You went to him."

It isn't a question and I don't answer it.

She sees my fist. She smells the brandy on me, and the clove, and she puts them together in the time it takes her to stand up.

"Oh, shit. Jesus Christ, Silas. Sit down."

I sit.

She brings the lamp and the tweezers and a bowl, and a brown bottle that smells of witch hazel and thyme. She pulls her chair in until her knees bracket mine, then takes my wrist and turns the palm up to the light.

She doesn't flinch at it. She never has.

"Hold still."

"It'll close by morning, witch."

"The cuts will." She lifts out the first shard and drops it in the bowl with a small bright tick. "This won't. That's why you keep it in your coat."

She works slowly. Every piece she lifts, she presses the heel of her thumb beside the wound until the next one rises.

Her hair is down around her face. Her breath lands warm on my palm, and the burned skin doesn't feel much, but it feels that.

When the last piece is out she washes the palm clean, and then she lifts it and puts her mouth to the center, right on the worst of the scar.

I stop breathing. I don't need to breathe. I stop anyway.

She climbs into my lap. Her thighs settle over mine on the narrow chair, and the cardigan falls open, and she doesn't pull it

closed.

She puts her forehead against mine.

"What did he want?"

"What he offered you on the step."

Her fingers tighten in my collar. "And you said?"

I look at the window.

"Silas Roche," she says, very softly. "Don't you dare."

I don't say anything. I put my good palm flat on her lower back, under the wool, where she's warm and real and entirely her own.

I hold her there until her breathing slows and her weight goes heavy against my chest.

She sleeps like that, in my lap, in her own kitchen, with the rosemary burning down to the stems.

The receipt is in my coat, folded along its brown creases, saying what it says.

I told a man tonight that I'd think about it.

That's the most dangerous sentence I've ever said out loud.

CHAPTER TWENTY



I break a promise to myself at two in the morning, and it takes a spoon, a hair from his coat, and the sound of my mother's voice.



I wake up in my own bed.

I don't remember getting here. The last thing I remember is his lap, in the kitchen, on the narrow chair, with his good palm flat on the small of my back and the rosemary burning down to the stems.

He must have carried me. He must have laid me down and pulled the sheet up, as he always does, as if he's putting a jar back on a shelf.

He's beside me now. He's lying on his back on top of the covers, still in his trousers and his ruined shirt, with his hands folded on his chest and his eyes closed.

He isn't asleep.

He doesn't sleep. This is what he does instead, a stillness so complete it looks like death, and I've learned that if I say his name, he'll open his eyes at once.

I don't say his name.

What would I even say to him? *Tell me what you promised that man?* He'd look at the window.

His right palm is wrapped in the linen I tied around it after I picked the glass out. There's blood on it, dried brown. Brandy and blood and clove. I can still smell Cray on him.

What did he want?

What he offered you on the step.

And you said?

And he looked at the window.

I lie there in the dark with my heart going too fast and look at the side of his face.

He's going to do it. I know he is.

I don't know how I know, but I know it as surely as I know a pot's about to boil over before the lid starts to rattle. *Fuck*. He went to Cray's house tonight, and he came back with his palm full of glass and Cray's smell all over him, and when I asked him what he'd said, he couldn't look at me.

I promised myself I'd never read him.

I promised myself the first night he stood in my kitchen. I've read clients. I've read strangers, and wolves, and a vampire duke from Mobile who wanted to know whether his wife was faithful.

But not him. Never him.

Whatever he wanted to keep, he could keep.

I slide out of bed.



His coat is on the chair by the door.

He folded it again. Of course he did. Inside pocket to the wall.

I don't touch the pocket. I can feel, somehow, that there's paper in there, more than one sheet, and I don't want to know what's on it badly enough to put my fingers in a man's coat.

I take a hair instead.

There's one on the collar, short and dark, caught in the weave. I pick it off with my fingernails and hold it up to the thin light from the window, and it shines.

Hair only works for a substitution if it's willingly given. For a reading, it doesn't have to be. A reading doesn't take anything from

the person being read. It takes from the one doing the reading.

That's the part I try not to think about on my way to the kitchen.



I don't turn on the lamp. I light a single candle on the table and sit down in front of it with a soup spoon and a bottle of olive oil.

It's a cheap working, the cheapest one I know. Oil for sight, a spoon for the bowl, a hair for the person, a flame to see by. My grandmother taught it to me when I was twelve, for finding lost rings. You could do it with a teacup, if you had to. You could do it with the bowl of your palm, if you were desperate.

I pour a spoonful of oil. I lay his hair across it, and it floats.

Then I cut my thumb, the same place I've been cutting it all week, and I let one drop of blood fall into the oil beside the hair.

"Show me," I tell it. "Show me what he means to do."

Nothing. A working wants its terms said plainly, every one, or it sulks.

"This is Ondine Marchand, reading for herself," I say out loud, to the spoon, to the dark kitchen, to my grandmother's ghost if she's listening. "The hair is Silas Roche's. I want to see what he means to do with his name. I'm the client. I pay what it costs. I won't argue the price."

I stop. My voice sounds very small in the empty room.

"I swear to God I won't argue it," I add. It's a lie, and the oil knows it.

The oil goes dark.

Then it starts to cost.



I t always costs. Every working costs the client. For a reading, the reader is the client, and the price is whatever the reading decides it's worth.

I feel it start to reach into me, a cold spoon scraping the inside of a pot. It goes looking. It goes through the shelves of me, as I go

through the shelves of my kitchen hunting the right jar, and I feel it pause at things and move on.

My grandmother's face. My first kiss. The smell of the bread I baked the morning after the step.

It moves on from all of them.

Then it stops.

My mother is singing.

I'm very small, in her lap on the back porch in the evening heat, and she's singing to me. Low and soft and a little off-key, as she always sang, a song with no words in it, just a hum that goes up at the end like a question. Her voice is rough from cigarettes. Her chin is on the top of my head. I can feel the song in her chest against my back.

I know what it wants.

"No," I whisper. "Please. God, please, anything but that. Take my first kiss. Take the goddamn bread."

The oil in the spoon doesn't move.

It doesn't bargain. Workings don't bargain. It's already chosen.

I close my eyes. I hold the song for one more second, her voice, her chin on my head, the rough low hum going up at the end.

"Mama," I whisper. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I need to see him."

Then, to the spoon: "All right. Take it."

And it's gone.



The oil clears.

I see him.

It isn't a picture. It's more like the bottom of a pond seen through clear water, wavering and deep. I see Silas in a front room that smells of clove, standing at the end of a table he won't sit at, with his fist full of broken glass and brandy running down his wrist.

I see Cray, in his chair, with one knee crossed over the other, smiling.

Think about it, Cray says, and I hear it, faint and far away.

I'll think about it, Silas says.

And I feel what's under it. The oil shows me.

No feint, no lie. He means it.

He's standing in Cray's front room thinking about giving his name away, and the thought doesn't horrify him. That's the worst of it.

It's almost restful. It feels like a man who's been carrying a heavy thing for a very long time, looking at a place where he might finally put it down.

He's really, truly fucking considering it, the stubborn son of a bitch.

I grip the edge of the table.

And then the oil shows me more.

A thread. Fine and red and bright, running out of the middle of his chest. It goes out of the spoon, out of the vision, and I feel where it goes.

It goes into me. Right under my breastbone. The place where I felt something knot the night he bled into my grandmother's lock.

I follow it with my mind, as you'd follow a string through a dark room. It's tied around his name.

His actual name. The one he'd have to give Cray.

And the knot is on my end.



I sit back.

The candle gutters. The oil in the spoon is just oil again, with a single dark hair floating in it and a drop of my blood gone brown at the edge.

His name is tied to me.

I don't know the terms. I still don't.

But I know what I saw. His blood went into my grandmother's lock and made a promise, and the promise is a knot, and the knot is in my hands.

He can't give his name away without me.

He'd have to stand in front of Cray with his name in his mouth, and it wouldn't come out, because it isn't only his anymore. He'd

need my yes. My consent, freely given, the same as any other working in this house.

Holy shit. I hold a veto.

I sit there in the dark with that for a good while.

He doesn't know. I'd bet anything he doesn't know. He bled into that lock without reading the terms, because he's the kind of man who does that, and he has no idea that what he signed was me.



I try to remember her voice.

It's the stupidest thing. I know it's gone. I felt it go. But I sit there in the candlelight and I try to remember what my mother sounded like, humming on the back porch in the heat, and I reach for it and there's nothing there.

I know she sang. I know it was a song with no words. I know her chin was on my head.

I can't hear it.

I remember the porch. I remember the heat. I remember the smell of her cigarettes and the scratch of her sweater against my back. And where her voice should be, there's just an empty space, clean and bare, a jar that's been scrubbed out.

What else will it take, next time? How much of her is left in me to spend?

I put my face in my palms and I cry without making a sound, so he won't hear me through the wall.



When I've finished, I blow out the candle. I pour the oil down the sink and wash the spoon and put it back in the drawer. I take his hair and burn it in the stove, so nobody can use it for anything else.

Then I go back to bed.

He's exactly where I left him. On his back on the covers with his palms folded and his eyes closed, still as a stone.

I slide back under the sheet. I'm naked. I pulled my nightgown off at some point, or he did, and I can still feel him in every inch of me: the ache between my thighs where he was so deep, the tenderness in my nipples, the faint bruises on my hips from his fingers.

His come dried sticky on the insides of my thighs. My pussy still aches when I shift.

What kind of fool lies beside a man like this and plans to lie to him? My kind, apparently.

I lie down beside him on my side and look at him.

He's going to try to give himself away. He's going to stand in front of that man and try to trade his name for mine, and he's going to find he can't, and he won't understand why. And when he figures it out, he's going to come to me and ask me for my yes.

I'm not going to give it to him.

I'm never, ever going to give it to him. He can beg on his knees in my kitchen and I'll say no, and I'll mean it, and I'll hate myself, and I'll say no.

If anybody walks into Cray's house at the new moon and pays for my grandmother's wolf, it's going to be me. It's going to be a Marchand. It's our debt.

It was always our debt. He's paid for enough things in his life that were never his.

I reach out in the dark and touch his face.

Just my fingertips, on his cheekbone, very lightly. His skin is cool. His jaw is rough with stubble. I trace the line of it down to his chin and back up, and I brush my thumb across his lower lip.

He doesn't open his eyes. I don't know whether that's because he's so deep in the stillness that he doesn't feel it, or because he feels it and doesn't want me to stop.

"I know what you're going to do," I whisper. "You stubborn, beautiful bastard. I know."

He doesn't move.

"You're going to walk into that man's house at the new moon and hand him your name, as if it's a coat you're done wearing. You

think nobody will miss it. You think it's the one thing you've got that's worth anything, and you think giving it away for me is the same as being worth something."

My voice cracks.

"It isn't. You hear me? You're worth something with it. You're worth the whole world right here, in my bed, with your stupid folded coat and your stupid bleeding palm."

He doesn't answer.

"And you're not going to do it," I tell him. "Because I won't let you."

His lips move. His eyes stay closed.

"Sleep, witch," he murmurs.

I freeze. My fingers stop on his jaw.

How much did he hear? How long has he been listening?

But he doesn't say anything else, and he doesn't open his eyes, and after a long time his breathing goes slow and even again, and I let mine start again too.

I lie down with my head on his shoulder and my palm flat on his chest, over the place where his heart beats slow and faint, and I close my eyes.

He doesn't know I read him. He doesn't know what I paid for it. He doesn't know I hold his name.

And I'm not going to tell him.

Not yet, and maybe not ever.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE



“

The Roche brothers own a boat,” Silas says, “and they owe me a night.”



I look up from the cutting board. He’s standing across the table in his coat with his bandaged palm in his pocket, and his face is set, as it gets when he’s decided something and is waiting for me to argue.

“A boat,” I say.

“A boat.”

“Describe the boat.”

“A fishing boat. With a cabin. And a deck.” He pauses. “And a blanket.”

I put down my knife.

“Silas Roche. Are you asking me on a date?”

He looks at the window.

I laugh. I can’t help it. I put both palms flat on the counter and laugh until my eyes water, and he stands there looking at the window with his jaw set, and I love him so much I could scream.

I don’t say that. I’ve been not saying it for a week now, and I’m getting very good at it.

"There are men at my gate, Silas," I remind him, when I can breathe.

"On the street side."

"So."

"The canal's on the back." He finally looks at me. "Anatole brings the skiff up to your back fence at ten. We go out through the garden. They never see us leave."

"And my house?"

"Your ward's up. Your door's locked. Your cat's inside." His voice goes lower. "A night, witch. That's all. Nobody's paper. Nobody's moon."

I look at him standing there. At the bandage on his palm and the shadows under his eyes and the paper I can smell in his coat, still, even now, even through the wool.

We both have secrets. I have his name knotted under my breastbone and the memory of my mother's voice scrubbed out of me. He has whatever Cray gave him in that envelope, and whatever he said to Cray in that front room, and a promise he made that he doesn't know I read.

The moon's a paring now. We don't have many nights left.

How many more nights like this do we get, before one of us walks into Cray's house?

"Okay," I say. "Tonight. Fuck it. Tonight."



Anatole Roche brings the skiff up to my back fence exactly on time, silent, a big dark shape at the tiller with his cap pulled low. He doesn't say a word. He nods to Silas, and he nods to me, and he helps me down into the boat by the elbow without looking at my face.

We slide out along the canal with the motor barely ticking, past the backs of houses with their lights out and their dogs asleep, and I watch my kitchen window go by.

The ward lamp's burning. The little blue glass lantern I keep on the sill, the one that only stays lit while the ward holds.

My grandmother's lamp. It's been burning every night of my life. I watch it until the canal bends and I can't see it anymore.



The boat's moored off the levee below the city, a sturdy old shrimper with a white cabin and a wide flat deck, rocking on the black water of the river. Anatole ties the skiff to her stern, hands Silas a key, and says the only thing he says all night.

"Don't break it."

Then he takes the skiff back upriver and leaves us there.

The river's huge in the dark. Holy shit, it's huge. I've lived beside it my whole life and I've never been out on it at night, and it's so much bigger than it looks from the bank, a wide black living thing moving under us, smelling of mud and rain and diesel and something green and ancient.

The lights of the city are a smear of gold on the left. On the right there's nothing but dark, and trees, and the far bank somewhere out in it.

The boat moves under my feet. Slow. A long lazy roll.

I stand on the deck with my arms around myself and look at all that water.

"Well?" Silas says behind me.

"It's beautiful."

"Yes."

"Do you do this often? Steal your cousins' boats and bring women out on the river to fuck them?"

"No."

"Not once?"

"Never."

I turn around. He's standing by the cabin door with the key in his fist, watching me, and the lights of the city are reflected in his eyes.

"Why tonight?" I ask.

He doesn't look at the window. There's no window out here to look at.

"Because out here," he says, "nobody owns anything."



There's a blanket. The blanket's real. It's old red-and-black plaid wool, folded on the bench in the cabin, and there's a thermos of coffee beside it and a paper sack of beignets that are still warm.

"Did you plan this?" I demand.

"Anatole's wife," he says. "She packs a bag."

"She packed *beignets*."

"She likes you."

"She's never met me."

"She's heard about you." A pause. "From Anatole. Who heard about you from me."

I stare at him.

"What did you tell him?"

He takes the blanket out to the deck. He shakes it out and spreads it flat on the boards in the middle of the deck, under the whole open sky, and he doesn't answer me.

I follow him out. I stand at the edge of the blanket and look down at him, kneeling there smoothing out the wool, and the boat rolls under us, long and slow, and my heart is going so hard I can hear it.

"Silas," I say. "Tell me what you told him."

He looks up at me.

"That I'd found somebody to stand at the end of a table for," he says.



I kiss him.

I get down on my knees on the blanket in front of him and take his face in my palms and kiss him, hard, and he makes that low wrecked sound into my mouth and pulls me in against him.

I push him down.

I don't let him think about it. I press my palm to his chest and push, and he goes, flat on his back on the plaid wool with the whole

sky over him, and I climb on top of him and straddle his hips.

"My turn," I tell him.

"Ondine—"

"You don't get to be in charge out here. You said so yourself. Nobody owns anything."

The corner of his mouth moves. That almost-smile. It lasts longer tonight.

I pull my sweater off over my head and throw it somewhere across the deck. My bra follows it. The night air hits my bare skin, cool and damp off the river, and my nipples go tight, and he looks up at me in the dark with his eyes gone black.

"Fuck," he breathes. "Look at you."

"Look all you want."

He does. He puts his palms on my hips and slides them up, slowly, over my ribs, over my tits, and cups them, and brushes his thumbs across my nipples, and I shiver down to my toes.

I unbutton his shirt. I push it open. I put my palms flat on his chest, cool and hard and scarred, and I lean down and kiss his throat, his collarbone, the scar across his ribs, the old burn at his shoulder, lower and lower.

I open his belt. I pull his trousers down his hips just far enough, and his cock springs free, hard and heavy against his belly.

I get out of my jeans. It's not graceful. The boat rolls and I nearly go over the side, and he catches me by the hips and I fall on top of him, laughing, one leg still tangled in denim.

"Very romantic," he says.

"Shut the fuck up. Help me."

He helps me. He pulls the jeans off my ankle and throws them after my sweater, and then I'm naked on top of him on a blanket on a boat in the middle of the river, and I've never been so happy in my whole life.



I take his cock in my fist and hold it steady and sink down onto it.

It's slow, and still too much. It always will be. Jesus Christ, it always will be. I have to work myself down onto him slowly, my thighs shaking, my palms braced on his chest, and he holds my hips and watches my face and doesn't rush me.

"Breathe," he says.

"I'm breathing."

"You're not."

"I'm *trying*. You're— Jesus, Silas, you're so big—"

He laughs.

It comes out of him low and rough and surprised, and I feel it in his chest under my palms, and I feel it in his cock inside me. It's the best thing I've ever felt.

"Don't laugh at me," I say, laughing too.

"I'm not."

"You are. You're laughing with your cock halfway up inside me—"

"Completely in, now," he says, and grips my hips and pulls me down onto the rest of him.

I gasp. My head falls back.

He's fully inside me. I'm sitting on his cock with my knees on either side of his hips and the whole sky above me, and the river is moving under the boat, slow and huge and dark, and I can feel him in my belly.

"Move," he says. "Ride me, witch."

"Say please."

"Ride my cock, Ondine. Please." His palms tighten on my hips. "Grind that wet pussy on me and let me watch you come under the stars."

I ride him.

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God," I gasp. "Your cock. On the water. I'm going to feel every wave in my pussy."

"Good," he says. "Ride it."

Here's what nobody tells you about fucking on the water: the boat helps.

Every roll of the river rocks the deck under us, and every time the deck rocks, he goes deeper, and I don't even have to do anything. I just rise and fall on him with the rhythm of the water, and he fills me every time.

"Oh, God," I gasp. "Oh, God, the *boat*—"

"I know."

"You planned this—"

"No."

"You *did*, you bastard, you knew—"

A big roll comes. A barge somewhere upriver sending its wake down, and the whole boat heaves under us, and I come down on his cock so hard I shout, and then the boat rolls the other way and I nearly slide off him, and he catches me by the waist, and we're both laughing so hard I can't breathe.

"Stop," I gasp. "Stop, I can't, I'm going to fall in—"

"You're not going to fall in."

"I'm going to fall in the goddamn Mississippi with your cock in me and they'll find us in the morning—"

"Nobody's finding us." He pulls me down against his chest, still inside me, both of us shaking with laughter. "Nobody owns the water, witch."

I stop laughing.

When did he learn to say things like that? Who taught him?

I lift my head and look down at him. He's looking up at me with his eyes wet and bright in the dark, and his mouth still soft from laughing, and for one second he looks so young I don't recognize him.

"Once more," I say.

"Nobody owns the water."

"Nobody," I say.

"Nobody."

"Not Cray. Not the account. Not my grandmother's paper."

"Not anybody."

I kiss him. I kiss him slow and deep, and I start to move on him again, slow now, rolling my hips in time with the river, and he groans into my mouth.



He rolls us.

He does it carefully, one palm behind my head so it doesn't hit the deck, and then I'm on my back on the plaid blanket with the sky over his shoulders and him inside me, and he's the one moving now.

"Your turn's over," he says.

"I thought nobody owned anything."

"Nobody does." He pulls back and thrusts into me, slow and deep, and I arch off the blanket. "I'm just borrowing you."

I laugh again. I can't stop laughing tonight.

I laugh and he fucks me, slow and deep and steady, and the boat rolls under us, and every roll pushes him deeper. I wrap my legs around his waist and my arms around his neck and hold on.

He gets his palm under my ass and tilts my hips up, and the angle changes, and I stop laughing.

"Oh," I say. "Oh. *Oh*. Right there. Don't move."

"I have to move."

"Then move exactly like that. Exactly like that, Silas, don't you dare change a thing—"

He doesn't change a thing.

He fucks me exactly like that, slow and relentless, hitting the same place deep inside me over and over, and the river rocks us, and I can feel it building low in my belly, huge and slow, like a wave coming a long way across dark water.

"I'm going to come," I whisper.

"I know."

"You always know."

"I always know," he agrees, and presses his thumb to my clit.

I come under him with the whole sky over me.

It's slow and huge and endless. It rolls through me in long pulses, my pussy clenching on his cock, my thighs locked around

him, my back arched off the blanket, and I'm not laughing now.

I'm crying. I'm crying and saying his name, over and over, into the wet night air over the river.

He comes with me.

He doesn't hold back. He pushes into me deep and groans against my throat, and I feel him pulse inside me, hot and deep, over and over, and his whole body shakes on top of mine.

The boat rocks us through it. Long and slow. As if the river's holding us.



Afterward, he wraps the blanket around both of us and pulls me against his chest, and we lie on the deck and look at the stars.

There are so many. You don't see them in the city. Out here, with the lights far off on the bank, there are more than I've ever seen in my life, and the river is moving under us, and his heart is beating slow and faint against my back.

He pours coffee out of the thermos into the cap and hands it to me. It's hot and black and bitter and it's the best coffee I've ever tasted.

"What is this?" I ask him.

"Coffee."

"No." I turn my head against his shoulder. "*This*. You. Me. The boat. What is it?"

He says nothing for a long moment.

"Stay on the boat till morning," he says finally.

It's the best answer he's got.

"Okay," I say, and drink my coffee, and don't ask again.



Anatole comes for us at dawn.

The sky's gone gray and pink over the far bank, and the river's turned from black to the color of weak tea, and a heron is standing

on the levee watching us with one yellow eye. We climb down into the skiff with the blanket around my shoulders and the empty thermos in Silas's fist, and Anatole takes us back up the canal toward my house.

I'm half asleep against Silas's shoulder. Holy shit, I'm happy. I'm sore and happy and sticky and warm, and I'm not thinking about anything.

The canal bends.

My house comes into view. The back fence. The garden. My kitchen window.

The ward lamp is out.

I sit up so fast the skiff rocks.

Oh, fuck. Oh, no.

"Silas."

He's already looking. His whole body has gone rigid against mine.

The little blue glass lantern on my kitchen sill, the one that's burned every night of my life while the ward held, is dark.

The back door of my house is standing open.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO



Her kitchen door is standing open to the canal, and for once she isn't behind it.



I'm out of the skiff before Anatole has it against the fence.

"Stay in the boat, witch."

She doesn't. I hear her climb out behind me, hear her boots hit the bank and the fence gate bang, and I don't stop to make her.

I'm already in her garden, already reading. The ground tells me first.

There are prints on the path from the back gate, a trio of them, made by good shoes with hard heels that don't give on gravel.

The same men who stood at her ward line without blinking. They came in from the canal side, the same way we went out, and they came after we'd gone. The dew's fallen on top of our prints and underneath theirs.

They waited. They watched the lamp. And the lamp went out because she left.

I stop on the path with that lodged in my chest.

Fuck. *Fuck.*

Her ward is laid in the salt and the bones and the old boards of this house, but it's tied to her. To the keeper. When she's on her own

ground it holds.

When she went out on the river last night, out where nobody owns anything, it thinned. It held as long as it could. Then, somewhere past midnight, while she was lying on a blanket on the deck with my cock inside her, laughing, it went out.

They were standing at the fence, waiting for that.

I took her out on the water to give her a night with nobody's name on it, and I handed them her fucking house.



The back door hasn't been forced. The lock's been opened, cleanly, by someone with patience and the right tools. Then the door was left standing wide, on purpose, so she'd see it from the canal.

I go in.

The smell hits first. Spilled workings have a smell, and I've never smelled this many at once: sharp and sour and sweet all together, a pantry after a flood, and under it a thick iron reek off the bottom shelf, where she kept the old blood-debts.

Then I see it.

The floor is glass, every inch of it, green and brown and blue and clear, in shards and chips and powder that glitter in the gray light from the window.

Salt everywhere, poured and spilled and ground into the boards. Twists of paper, a whole scatter of them, lying open in the wreck like dead moths, the names on them already fading.

The shelves are bare. Most of them, anyway. That's what I read first, and it's what makes my blood go slow.

They didn't sweep the shelves. They didn't smash everything in reach and run.

They chose.



I stand in the doorway and read the ruin.

They started at the stove. The green glass on the bottom shelf is gone, all of it, every jar with the Aldric mark scratched in the lid.

They went there first. I can see it in the spread of the shards: the green is underneath everything else, a broad fan of it across the boards, and the brown and clear glass lies on top.

They broke the Aldric jars first, deliberately, one at a time.

Then they moved along the wall, out of order. They skipped some shelves and emptied others. I can see the gaps on the shelves where a jar is missing, and the jars left standing on either side, untouched.

They read the labels. They picked.

A jar of wolf debt from Chalmette, broken. A jar beside it, a client's sister's debt, a small one, left alone. A vampire's oath from the old court, broken. The jar beside that, a child's naming, left.

They took the ones with weight, the ones that would matter in the morning. Court names. Pack names. Old debts between houses that have been sitting on this shelf for decades because this was the only place neither side could touch them.

They broke the names. On purpose.

And every one of those broken names is loose in the air right now. Every promise that was held here is free. Somewhere in this city, a lot of powerful men are going to wake up this morning owing nobody anything, and some of them are going to wonder why, and some of them are going to be very, very angry about it.

The Aldric house is going to be the angriest of all.

Vandals don't read labels. This was a letter.



The working is gone.

It was on the long table under its cloth. It's been there since the first night I came into this kitchen, half-finished, whatever it was.

I never asked. She never told me.

Now the cloth is on the chair. Folded. Neatly, in quarters, the edges squared, and set down on the seat as though someone meant to put it back.

On the table where the working was, there's only salt. A scatter of bone chips. A smear of something dark that might have been wax. Whatever she'd been making for a week, they found it and uncovered it and folded the cloth, and then they broke what was under it into pieces too small to read.

My fists close at my sides.

I know who folds things. The polite, patient, motherfucking bastard.

I know whose men have good shoes and the patience to read every label on a shelf and choose. I know whose hand is in this, even if his feet weren't.

I could be in Bywater before she finished her first scream.

I could have his head off his neck on his own rug before the sun was full up. It would take me less time than it's taking me to think it.

And then the paper would go home. To whatever sits above him. And whatever sits above him would have her name, and every name left on these shelves, and nobody to talk to at all.

I stand in the doorway with my fists shaking and my teeth coming down in my gums, and I don't go.

What kind of man stands in the wreck of a woman's house and does nothing? What was I bought for, if not this?

I fucking hate it. I hate it more than I've hated anything since the yard.

I don't go.



There's a sound under the stove.

Small. A scrape of claws on board. I crouch and look, and two green eyes look back at me out of the dark behind the stove leg, huge and furious.

It's the cat. He's flat against the wall with his ears pinned back and his fur standing up so he looks enormous, and he's alive. There's glass all around him and he's alive, and not a mark on him that I can see.

He hisses at me.

It's the first thing in this room that's made sense.

I leave him where he is. He's safe there. Safer than anywhere else in this kitchen.



The ledger is the next thing I think of. I crouch at the old stove, glass crunching under my boots, and read the third brick from the bottom. The soot along its edges is unbroken. Nobody has worked it loose. Behind it, the ledger sits where she put it, closed, with my blood still dried in the clasp.

They didn't come for the ledger, and they didn't come for her, either. They knew she was gone.

They waited until she was gone. They came for the jars, and the working, and the house's name.

They came to show her they could.

Why now? Why tonight, of all the nights he could have picked?

Did he know about the boat? Did he know before I did?

I take out my phone and I don't make a sound. I text the Roche brothers: *Bywater. His house. Watch it. Don't touch.* I text Lucian: *Aldric jars broken at the Marchand house. Expect letters.*

Then I put the phone away. There's nothing else it's good for.



I go back to the kitchen.

She's there. She's come in the back door behind me and she's standing in the middle of it, in the middle of all that glass, in her boat boots and yesterday's sweater with the river still in her hair.

She has the blanket from the boat around her shoulders. She's holding very still.

She's so still I can't read her.

I've always been able to read her. From the first night, she's been the clearest ground I've ever read, every thought in her face and her shoulders and where her weight falls.

Right now there's nothing. She's standing in her grandmother's kitchen as still as a post driven into the ground, and she isn't moving, and she isn't looking at anything.

Her eyes are on the far wall. On the smudge from the jar she threw. The only mark on that wall that's hers.

I understand. If she moves, she'll start sorting. If she starts sorting, she'll start counting. If she counts, she'll know.

So she stands there.

I don't say anything. I don't have anything.

I stand in her doorway with glass under my boots and her grandmother's broken names loose in the air around us, and I have no sentence for this. I've never had a sentence for anything that mattered.

I read the room one more time instead. I read which jar went first and which went last, and where they stood, and how long they took. I read it all and I keep it, every piece, because one day I'm going to walk into Absalom Cray's house and give it back to him.

Today, though, she's standing in the glass.



She turns her head.

Slowly. As if it hurts. Her eyes come off the smudge on the wall and find mine across the wreck of her kitchen, and they're dry, and they're enormous, and there's nothing in them but me.

Her lips move.

"Silas," she says. "Come here."

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE



He comes across the broken glass without looking at it.

Every step crunches. My grandmother's jars, my jars, other people's debts ground under the heels of a man who never walks into my kitchen without checking where he puts his feet.

He doesn't check now. He's looking at me.

I told him to come here, and here he comes.



The kitchen smells like everything I own broke at once. Bitter orange and lamp oil and smoked salt, lavender from the birthing jars, black pepper, vinegar, the iron tang of the old blood-debts off the bottom shelf.

The green glass by the stove was all Aldric. Those names are loose in the air now, promises with nowhere to live, and somewhere across the city people are waking up with the feeling of a missed stair.

How long before the Aldric people come knocking to ask where their debts went? Somebody will have to explain it to them, and it won't be the cat. And the child-naming for the woman on Esplanade, the one I put back on the shelf with my own fingers, is that on the floor too?

I don't look. I can't look.

The working under the cloth is gone. Somebody lifted the cloth to see what was under it, folded it into a neat square, and set it on the chair. Then they broke what it was covering.

Who breaks into a witch's kitchen and folds her linen?

Cray's people, that's who. Of course they fucking do.

The cat is under the stove. I can see green eyes and the tip of a tail. Alive, furious, alive.

I'm standing in the middle of it all in my boat boots and yesterday's sweater with the river still in my hair. I've been holding very still since we came through the door, because if I move I'm going to start sorting, and if I start sorting I'm going to know exactly what's gone.

"Don't," I say, when he reaches me. "Don't read it to me. I know what's gone."

He doesn't read anything. He takes my face.



His palm is cool and the scar is rough against my cheekbone, and his thumb slides under my jaw to tip my head back, and he kisses me as if the house is still standing.

It isn't gentle. Nothing in him is gentle this morning. I can taste the rage in it, cold and clean, the rage he carried around my kitchen while I stood still and he read which jar went first and which went last and who stood where.

He hasn't said a word since the door.

I bite his lip hard enough to taste him. He makes a low, wrecked sound into my mouth and hauls me up against him by my belt loops.

"Silas."

"I know."

"They were in my house."

"I know, witch." His forehead drops to mine. His voice is shaking, and Silas Roche's voice does not shake. "I know. I'm going to—"

He doesn't finish it. He never does. For once I'm grateful.

"Don't go to him," I say. "Stay in the room."

It's his line. I watch it land.

"I'm in the room."

He looks down at my feet, at the glass glittering around my boots, and his face settles into something I've only ever seen him point at other people.

"Boots off, witch."



I toe them off. He's already shrugging out of his coat.

It's a good coat. Black wool, heavy, older than my house, the only thing he owns that I've ever seen him treat with care.

He goes down on one knee and sweeps it across the floor in long hard strokes. Glass and salt and spilled names skitter away under the stove, where the cat hisses at all of it. He clears a stretch of boards between the table and the sink, and then he runs his good palm over every inch of it, slow, checking.

Twice he stops, picks a sliver out of the grain with his fingernails, and flicks it away.

Then he turns the coat clean side up and lays it down flat.

He's making me a bed out of the only thing in this kitchen that isn't broken.

"That coat," I say. My voice comes out thin. "That'll cost you."

"Lie down."



I lie down.

He puts me on my back on his coat on my kitchen floor, in the wreck of everything my grandmother built. Then he kneels over me and looks, and I let him, because I've learned by now that the looking is half of what he does to me.

His eyes go from my mouth to my throat to my chest under the sweater, down to the button of my jeans, and back up, slow, reading what passed through here and what's about to.

Nobody has ever read me like that. My thighs clench on nothing.
"Sweater," he says.

I drag it over my head. No bra, because I left it on a boat. Morning light off the canal comes through the broken door and lands on my tits, and my nipples pull tight in the draft, and he makes a sound low in his throat as if I've hit him.

He takes my jeans himself.

He pops the button, drags the zipper down, hooks his fingers in the waistband and hauls denim and underwear down my hips and thighs and off my ankles in one long pull, and flings the lot at the table. Then he spreads my knees wide with his palms and pins them open against the coat.

I'm naked and spread on a coat on the floor with the door wide open and a cat watching me, and I have never cared less about anything in my life.

"Look at you," he says. "Look at this pussy."

"Silas—"

"You're dripping." He drags his thumb up the inside of my thigh, through the wet there, and holds it up to the light so I can see it shine. "You stood in that glass shaking, and your cunt was soaking the whole time."

"Terror does things," I tell him. "It's chemistry. Adrenaline. It's just—"

He lowers his head and licks me.

One long flat stroke of his tongue from my hole to my clit, slow and heavy, and whatever it is goes straight out of my head and doesn't come back.

"It's what?" he says against my pussy.

"Oh, God. Oh, fuck. Don't you stop."

"I need to taste what they nearly took." He spreads me open with his thumbs and sucks my clit into his mouth, hard, and my hips jolt off the coat, and he pins them flat with his forearm and keeps sucking. "Hold still."

"I can't—"

"Then don't. Grind on my face."

"Tell me what I taste like," I gasp.

"Salt. Rosemary. Fear." He licks me, long and slow. "And you. Sweet as cane syrup. I could drink you for a week."

"More."

"More what, witch?"

"More talking. More tongue. More *everything*—"

I grind on his face. I grab his hair in both fists and grind my pussy against his mouth, shameless, glass and salt crunching somewhere under the coat, and he groans into me and fucks me with his tongue, deep, then drags it back up to my clit and flicks it, fast and relentless, until my thighs are clamped around his head and I'm panting his name at the ceiling beams.

He pushes two fingers into me while he sucks, curls them, and finds the place.

I come so hard my back buckles off the floor. I come on his fingers and his tongue with my thighs shaking around his ears, and he doesn't stop. He licks me through it, slow, lapping at every pulse, until I'm twitching and sobbing and shoving at his head because it's too much.

He lifts his head. His mouth and chin are wet with me, shining in the morning light.

"Every one of those jars can go," he says. His voice is wrecked. "Every name on those shelves. I don't care about a single one."

"Liar. You care about all of them."

"I care about this." He cups my pussy, his whole palm over it with his fingers still buried inside me, and squeezes. "This doesn't go. This cunt is mine. Say it."

"It's yours."

"Louder."

"It's yours, you bastard, it's yours, all of it's yours—"

"Has anyone else ever fucked you on this floor?"

"No."

"Good." Something dark and pleased moves across his face. "Nobody touches you in this house again but me."

"Nobody. Jesus Christ. Silas, please, I need your cock, I need it now —"



He opens his belt one-handed. I help, badly, my fingers skidding on the buckle.

He shoves my knees up and wide and settles between my thighs. He lines the head of his cock up against me, and he looks at me once.

Then he thrusts in.

All the way, in one brutal stroke.

It splits me open. I cry out, and my back buckles off the coat, and my heels dig into the backs of his thighs. He stays there, buried to the root, his balls pressed tight to my ass, shaking, with his forehead on my collarbone.

"Too much?"

"No. More. Move. Fuck me, you smug—"

He moves.

We've had slow. We had slow in my bed with him talking into my spine. This morning he fucks me hard and deep, pistoning into me with his fists planted on either side of my head and his hips slamming against my thighs, the coat bunching under my shoulders and sliding on the boards with every thrust. The wet slap of it is obscene in the wrecked kitchen.

Every stroke drives me further across the floor. My grandmother's floor, the floor I scrubbed on my knees as a girl, and a vampire is fucking me across it while the air smells like every promise I ever kept.

"Feel that?" He grinds into me, deep, and holds there, his pelvis rocking against my clit. "That's what's left in this house. My cock in you. Nothing else they broke matters."

"Don't stop talking."

"You like it when I talk."

"I like it when you finish a sentence."

"Then keep your eyes on me." He pulls almost all the way out and slams back in, and I shout. "You're going to come on my cock."

Then I'm going to fill you. Then you're going to sweep up every piece of that glass with me dripping down your thighs."

"Yes. God. Yes."

"You're soaking my coat," he says through his teeth. "You're going to ruin it."

"Buy another one."

"I'm keeping this one. I'm never washing it. I'm going to wear it with you all over it."

"*Fuck*, Silas, fuck me, fuck me harder, please—"

"There she is," he growls, and gives me harder.

His eyes have gone black. His mouth is open, and the tips of his fangs are down, and I clench so hard around his cock that he swears.

"Fuck."

"Your teeth," I say. "Silas. Your teeth are out."

"I know."

He shuts his mouth, and his jaw goes hard.

He keeps fucking me, and he won't open his mouth again, won't let me see.

I know what he's doing. He did it at my table the first night, with his fingers inside me and his hunger nailed to the floor.

I reach for his jaw. He catches my wrist.

Then he pulls out, grips my hip, and flips me.



It's fast. I'm on my stomach, and then he hauls me up onto my knees with my ass in the air, and my knees skid off the edge of the coat onto bare boards and salt.

It's coarse and gritty and it bites, and before I can complain about it he's back inside me from behind in one hard stroke that knocks the air out of my lungs.

He turned me over so I couldn't see his teeth.

"Why'd you flip me?" I gasp.

"Because."

"Because *why*?"

"Because if you see my teeth," he says, fucking into me, slow and deep, "you'll ask for them."

"Then I'm asking."

"Not like this. Not yet, witch."

"Then when, you bastard—"

He drives into me so hard the answer knocks clean out of my head.

I know him. I know exactly what that was.

He fucks me from behind with his fingers dug into my hips, dragging me back onto his cock every time he drives forward, his thighs slapping the backs of mine.

He slams into me so deep my knees slide in the salt, and it grinds into my skin. I'm going to have marks. I'm going to have his fingerprints on my hips and salt burn on my knees, and I want them, I want to look at them tomorrow and remember every stroke of this.

"Don't hide from me," I pant.

"I'm not hiding."

"You flipped me so I wouldn't see your mouth."

He doesn't answer.

He fucks me harder instead, and that's his answer.

Then he bends over me, his chest to my back, and his mouth is at my shoulder.

I feel the points of his fangs rest on my skin and lift off. Rest and lift. He's shaking with it.

He's never fed from me. He's never asked. In all the nights at the end of my table, he's never once looked at my throat as if it could be his.

Has he been afraid of what he'd find in it, or of what I'd find in him?

"Up," I say.

He hauls me up.

He's still inside me. He pulls me back against his chest until we're both kneeling, my back to his front, his arm locked across my ribs and his cock so deep I feel him in my stomach. My knees are in the salt. His are on the coat. My head falls back onto his shoulder.

My throat is right there, under his mouth.

I tip my head and give him the whole side of my neck, the pulse jumping under my jaw.

"Drink, Silas," I say. "That's an order."

He goes absolutely still.

"Ondine—"

"You heard me. I'm not asking." My voice cracks on it, and I don't care. "They came into my house. They broke my grandmother's house. I want one goddamn thing in this kitchen to be mine to give. Drink."

His mouth opens against my skin.

"If I start," he says, "I don't know what I'll—"

"You'll stop when I say stop. You always stop. That's the whole problem with you."

"You'll remember it," he says, rough. "All of it. I won't take any of it from you."

"I know. That's the point."

He bites.



It hurts for one breath. A hard bright pinch at the side of my throat, two points and then pressure, and I gasp—
And then it doesn't hurt at all.

Nobody tells you. Not the court, not the old books in my grandmother's hand. The pleasure comes up out of me with the blood, drawn in long hard pulls from somewhere under my ribs, and every swallow he takes is a stroke inside me that has nothing to do with his cock.

I feel him swallow. I feel every swallow in my clit.

"Silas," I sob. "Oh, God, drink. Drink. Don't stop. Take all of it, fuck, take it, it's yours—"

He growls into my throat without lifting his mouth. His cock jerks inside me.

I come almost at once, without warning, with his teeth in my throat and his cock in me and his arm crushing my ribs. I scream so

loud the cat bolts out from under the stove and straight out the open door.

He doesn't stop. He growls against my throat and keeps drinking, and his free palm slides down my belly to my clit and rubs it, rough and fast, while he fucks up into me in short hard thrusts that lift my knees off the boards.

I come a second time on top of the first, sobbing, writhing on his cock, salt grinding into my knees, my whole body spasming around him while he swallows and swallows.

Holy shit. Holy shit, nobody told me.

And through the bite, I feel him.

Register three: voluntary, aware, remembered. I've read the words in my grandmother's hand, and they don't come close. He's drinking me, and I can feel what my blood does when it reaches him. It pours in. My terror, my grief for every jar on this floor, my fury, how badly I want him, all of it going into him with every pull.

Is this what I taste like to him? Is this what he's been refusing all these nights, standing at his place at my table with his coffee going cold?

He takes it, and it doesn't knock him down.

He drinks it on purpose, swallow after swallow, choosing it.

And under that, faint, through the thread he bled into my grandmother's lock, something comes back the other way.

Him.

No words. He's never had words for himself. A pressure, a direction. Whatever has been swinging loose in him for weeks settles into place, heavy and final, like a lid seating on a jar.

What did he just decide? And why does it feel like he's already said goodbye to it?

I'm too far gone to read it. I keep it anyway.

He pulls his teeth free. He licks the bite, slow, twice, and I feel it close under his tongue.

"Ondine," he says against my neck. He sounds wrecked. "I'm going to—"

"Come in me. Come in me, Silas, I want it, give it to—"

He comes.

He slams up into me one last time and holds me down on his cock with his arm across my ribs. I feel him pulse, over and over, filling me, his cock jerking deep inside me and his whole body shuddering against my back. A sound comes out of him I've never heard from anyone, low and broken, a groan that turns into my name halfway through.

We stay there.

Kneeling in the salt. His forehead on my shoulder. His cock still in me, softening, his come beginning to slide down the inside of my thigh, and his arm around me so tight I can barely breathe. I don't want to breathe.

◆ ◆ ◆

Eventually he lays me down on the coat, on my side, and pulls me against his chest. Then he sits up.

"Knees," he says.

"What?"

He takes my ankle and draws my leg up and turns my knee to the light. It's raw, pink and pitted with salt, white grains pressed into the skin. He frowns at it as if it has personally offended him.

Then he picks the salt out.

A grain at a time, with the tips of his fingers. He's careful and slow and completely silent about it, and when he's done with one knee he does the other. Then he licks his thumb and wipes each one clean.

"Was that right?" he asks my knee.

It's what he asked against the wards, the night I didn't knock. He still asks it like a man checking a lock.

"My knees hurt," I tell him. "My neck doesn't. I think I'm a different person from the waist down. Yes, Silas. It was right."

There's blood on his mouth. Mine. I reach up and wipe it off his lip with my thumb, and he lets me.

The cat comes back through the open door. He sits down in the doorway, in the one clean patch of morning light, and considers us:

two naked people on a coat on the floor of a ruined kitchen, one with salt on her knees and a bite on her neck, one with her blood on his chin.

He blinks, slowly.

"The cat's judging us," I say.

"The cat has always judged us, witch." He doesn't look up from my knee.

I laugh. It comes out wet and wrong, and it's the first time I've laughed since the door. He looks up when I do, and his jaw loosens, for about as long as a breath.

Then he goes back to my knee.

I lie on his coat in the wreck of my grandmother's kitchen, with his palm warm on my ankle and the bite on my throat already closed, and I don't say a word about what came back to me through it.

He's decided something.

I felt it in the blood.

He doesn't know I felt it.

INTERSTITIAL

Cray



The letter came under my door before dawn, and I knew the hand before I had it out of the envelope.

It is a very beautiful hand, and it has never hurried. I have kept every letter in it for longer than this house has stood.

I have never read one without my fingers going cold.

I read it standing, in the front hall, in my stockings.

It was short. They always are.

The jars were not asked for.

That was all. No signature. There never is. Just the line, on good paper, folded once, with the mark pressed into the wax.



I made my tea. I sat in my chair by the window with the letter on my knee, and I read it again, and I considered it.

It was true.

The jars were not asked for.

The instruction names the witch and her house. Her name, and every name the house holds, delivered at the new moon.

Nothing was said about breaking anything before then. Nothing was said about the Aldric glass, which is now a scatter of green on a

kitchen floor on the far side of the city, with a great many old promises loose in the air above it.

The Aldric house will write to the King. The King will write back. There will be a certain amount of noise.

The principal dislikes noise.

I chose the jars myself.

I sent my men in when the lamp went out, and I gave them a list, and I told them which glass to take and which to leave. I told them to fold the cloth before they touched the working. I wanted her to see that it was done by someone with manners.

And I wanted him to see it. Him most of all.

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as it a mistake?

I have sat with the question all morning, and I find I do not think so. A man does not give up his name because he is asked nicely. He gives it up because he has stood in the ruin of something he loves and understood that he cannot mend it by killing anyone.

He stood in that kitchen this morning. I am certain of it.

He read every shard. He read the order they broke in and the shelves they skipped, and he understood exactly what it meant, and he did not come to my door.

That is a man who is almost ready.

The principal does not see it that way. The principal sees noise, and a broker who chose without being asked.

I am not in the habit of being rebuked.

I find, sitting here with my tea going cold, that my fingers are not quite steady on the cup.

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I have always been careful with the principal. I have been useful and prompt. I have delivered what was asked, on the night it was asked, and I have never once asked to be told why. I have brought a great many names to that account, and been thanked often enough to know the difference between thanks and this.

This is not thanks.

This is the tone one uses to a dog that has brought home the wrong bird.

I read the line again. *The jars were not asked for.*

What happens to a broker who makes too much noise? I have never had to find out.

I have seen the column of names in the account's register, and I know that none of them is still signing. They ran for a while, each in turn, and then the handwriting changed.

I have never wanted to be among the names that change.



So I will be very courteous.

I will write back this afternoon on my best paper and apologize for the noise, in terms so correct there can be nothing in them to object to. I will say the Aldric matter will resolve itself. I will say the witch will be delivered at the new moon, exactly as instructed, and that nothing more will be broken before then.

And I will choose where.

Not her kitchen. Her kitchen is hers, and she knows every board of it.

I have seen what she does with salt on her own ground. I have no wish to stand in it again.

Mine, then. My front room.

My chairs, my table, my good cups on the tray. Neutral ground has manners, and so do I, and my house has more manners than most.

I will invite her. I will write it on a pleasant card and have it left under her mat. *Miss Marchand is expected at the new moon. Tea at dusk.*

And I will invite him.

The principal did not ask for him. The principal asked only for the witch. But I have been rebuked this morning, and I find I would like very much to bring something home that nobody asked for and that nobody can call noise.

A King's enforcer, freely given, would be very quiet indeed.

I will set out a chair for each of them.

I will set out the good cups.

And I will be gracious to the very last. I have always been gracious.

What else would I be, this morning, with my fingers cold on the cup?

Grace is the only coat I own that fits over fear.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR



“

Same grammar,” Selene says. “Different grave.”



She’s bent over the long table in Tobias’s registry with her sleeves shoved to her elbows and her hair tied up in a knot, and she has the account’s register open in front of her. The real one. The heavy black-spined ledger from the bottom drawer of the Bywater firm.

I went back for it the night of the kitchen.

I didn’t tell anybody I was going. I went in through the back door with the new lock again, in the dead hours, with the smell of her broken jars still in my coat, and the file room was exactly as I’d left it.

The window still scraped loose around the frame. The Marchand file still thin in its drawer.

I took the register. I took it out under my coat as you’d carry a sleeping child, and I brought it here, to the three rooms under the east wing that smell of paper and lamp oil and strong tea, and I put it on Tobias’s table without a word.

Tobias looked at it for a long while. Then he took off his useless spectacles and polished them on his shirt and put them back on.

“Well,” he said. “That’s burglary.”

“Yes.”

"From a registered firm. Bloody hell, Silas."

It's the only time I've ever heard Tobias Vale swear.

"I'll need to repair the binding before anybody else can read it. The spine's cracked." He pulled it toward him with the tips of his fingers. "Give me a day."

He took two.



Now it's morning, and the binding is mended, and Selene has been reading the register for an hour without looking up.

She reads as she always reads, slowly, with her lips very faintly moving. She's a translator. She spent years in court rooms turning one language into another, and she hears what's under the words as I read what's under the ground.

She has her finger on the column of names.

"Look," she says. "Look at this one. And this one. And this one."

I look.

A name in brown ink, in an old French script, running for pages. Then a new name, in different writing, running for pages more.

Then another. Every one different.

"The hands don't match," I say. "I know. I read it at the firm."

"The hands don't match," Selene agrees. "The grammar does."

She moves her finger down the margin, where each name has a line of notation beside it. Short phrases.

Terms. Consideration received. Obligation discharged. Principal satisfied.

"It's the same sentence," she says. "Every generation. Different words, some of them. French, Spanish, English, something I think is Latin. But the construction is identical. Same order. Same weight at the end. Same habit of putting the verb last as if it's the only thing that matters."

"One writer."

"One writer across—" She stops. She looks at the front of the register, at pages so brittle and brown I'm afraid to breathe near them. "I don't know how long. As long as there's been writing in

this city. Longer, maybe.”

“Wearing different names.”

“Signing different names.” She sits back. “Not wearing them. They’re too careful for that. They’re signing *somebody’s* name. Every time.”

“Whose?”

That’s when Tobias clears his throat.



He’s been at the other end of the table the whole time, with the court registry spread out around him in towers: burial records, marriage records, property rolls, the city’s dead going back to the first burials, in his tiny immaculate script and the hands of every clerk before him.

“I have a thought,” he says, “about whose.”

He slides a sheet across to us. It’s a list, in his own writing. Two columns.

On the left, every name from the account’s register. On the right, a date, and a place.

“I ran them,” he says. “Against the burial rolls. It took me most of last night.”

I look at the column on the right.

A cemetery and a date. Another cemetery, another date. Saint Louis. Lafayette. A churchyard in Algiers. A wolf ground in the bayou.

Every one.

“They’re all dead,” Selene says slowly.

“They’re all dead,” Tobias agrees. “Every name that’s ever signed for the account belongs to somebody who was buried in this city. And every one of them was buried within a season of the name appearing in the register.”

Nobody in the room says anything.

“The account signs with the names of the recently dead,” Tobias says. “It takes a grave, and it puts the name on the page, and then it signs with it until the next one.”

"Same grammar," Selene whispers. "Different grave."



I don't like the fucking silence that comes after that.

It sits in the room like smoke, and I don't like where it goes.

"Whose dead?" I ask.

Tobias looks at me over his spectacles.

"That's the other thing," he says, and pulls another sheet across. "I cross-referenced the buyers. The ones I could find. Every person who ever took a consideration from this account, the ones with any paper trail at all."

He taps the sheet.

"Every one of them had just lost someone. A husband. A son. A sister. A pack-brother. Every buyer on the account was grieving. And every grief was fresh. Weeks. A season at most, before the purchase."

"And every one had access," Selene says. She's reading his sheet upside down. "Look. A court clerk. A pack's keeper of names. A priest with the parish rolls. A witch with a shelf of jars." Her voice goes flat. "Every one of them was holding something the account would want. Names. Records. Access."

"Grief and access," Tobias says. "Every time. The account never buys from anybody without both."

I look down at the list.

At the name halfway down. A widow in the wet years, whose husband died on the Tchoupitoulas levee on a Sunday.

Marchand, H.



I stand up.

I don't decide to. My body does it. I'm on my feet and walking to the window, the high little window in the registry wall that looks out on nothing but the bottom of a courtyard, and I stand there with my back to them.

The account doesn't only buy grief. It arrives with it.

A wolf kills a man on the levee on a Sunday. Everybody knows which wolf. Nobody says so.

The court won't ask. The pack won't ask. And within a week, a broker is standing in the widow's kitchen with his hat in his fingers, offering to introduce her to someone who'll see to the wolf. Within a week. Before she'd even buried him.

How did Cray know to be there? How did he know, that fast, which widow in the whole city had a shelf full of names and a husband cold on the levee?

Unless he knew before.

Unless somebody arranged the Sunday, and the wolf, and the levee, so that there would be a widow and a shelf and a grief fresh enough to buy.

Honorine Marchand sold her unborn granddaughter to pay for the death of the wolf who killed her husband. And the wolf who killed her husband may have been bought by the same account she paid.

She paid for her own grief twice over. Christ.

And Ondine is the receipt.

The glass is cool against my forehead. I didn't notice leaning on it.

I think of her in the salt on her kitchen floor, the morning after the jars. Kneeling in it with my arm across her ribs and her throat under my mouth, and her blood pouring into me with every feeling she had: the terror, the grief, how badly she wanted me.

She gave me that. She ordered me to take it.

And whatever sold her before she breathed may have killed her grandfather first, to make the sale.

I'm going to find it. I'm going to find the bastard, whatever the fuck it is, and I'm going to make it pay for every jar.

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Silas," Selene says behind me.

I don't turn around.

"Silas. Your palm."

I look down.

My right palm is flat on the stone of the windowsill, and it's bleeding. The old burns have split again, the ones Ondine picked the glass out of. The linen she tied has come loose and there's blood seeping through the ropes of scar tissue, dark and slow, onto Tobias's windowsill.

I didn't feel it. I never feel the fucking thing.

Selene is beside me. She takes my wrist in her fingers, as Ondine does, and turns my palm up to the light.

"You did that on the glass," she says. "At Cray's. And again at her kitchen. And you've been clenching it all morning." She looks up at my face. "You're going to have to tell her what this is."

"It's nothing."

"It's not nothing. It's bleeding on a registry windowsill." Her grip tightens. "And you're going to have to tell *him*."

I know which him she means. There's only one him in this house.

"Tell him, Silas," she says. "Tell Lucian. All of it. The paper, the collateral, the offer, whatever's in your coat. Tell him about this." She shakes the list in her other hand. "Tell him the account buys grief and brings it with it. He's the King. He needs to know what's been buying names in his city since before there was a King."

I open my mouth.

"Not—"

It stops. It always stops.

Not yet, and not until I know what I'm going to do with my own name. Not until I've decided whether what I'm going to do is what my king would forbid.

None of it comes out.

Selene looks at me for a good while with her translator's eyes. She's reading the grammar of what I didn't say. She's always been able to do that.

She lets go of my wrist.

"Not," she repeats softly. "Right."



Tobias wraps my palm in clean linen from a drawer, neat and tight, without saying a word. He's very good at everything that needs doing without fuss.

Then he goes back to his towers of paper.

"There are still questions," he says to the burial rolls, not to me. "I'll keep at them."

"Such as?"

"Who the account is. That's the obvious question." He turns a page. "What it wants with this city, specifically. Why here. Why every name it buys is a name that holds other names. And what happens at the new moon, when it gets the Marchand house, and every debt on those shelves."

He looks up at me.

"And why it wants you as well," he adds. "When it already has the witch."

I don't answer.

I pick up the list, the one with *Marchand, H.* halfway down, and I fold it once and put it in my coat, in the inside pocket, with the receipt and the index card and Cray's note.

My coat is getting heavy. Every pocket of it is somebody's grave.



Lucian is in the small study when I come up from the registry. The door's open. He's at his desk with a stack of letters from the Aldric house, and he looks up when my shadow crosses the threshold.

"Silas," he says. "Anything?"

I stand in his doorway with my palm wrapped in Tobias's linen and my pocket full of paper.

"Still confirming, sire," I say.

He studies me.

He doesn't need to say anything. He can see where my eyes went, and they went to the window behind his head.

I turn around and walk out of his study, and I don't tell him.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE



I go to Cray's house to sell myself, and he offers me a chair.



I walk the whole way. Down her street, past the watchers at her ward line who don't turn their heads, along the canal and through the Marigny and into Bywater with the heat coming up off the sidewalks in waves.

I read nothing. I don't let myself.

If I read the ground, I'll read my own prints going toward his house, and I'll know what they mean.

What does a man look like, walking to his own sale? I've seen it. I've tracked men to the edge of that. They walk fast at first, and then slower, and at the end they're barely walking at all.

I walk fast the whole way, with the memory of her in my body: her throat under my mouth on her kitchen floor, the salt on her knees, the way she said *drink* as if it were an order. I walk with my cock half hard and my jaw set, and I hate myself for both. I don't slow down once. I'm not sure what that says about me, and I don't want to fucking know.

He opens the door before I reach the step. He's in shirtsleeves again, and a gray waistcoat, and he looks at me standing on his walk in the late afternoon sun with my palm wrapped in Tobias's linen,

and his whole face lights up.

"Mr. Roche," he says. "Come in. Come in, please. You'll want the front room."

I go in.

The rug is gone. There's bare floorboard where it used to be, scrubbed pale, with a faint shadow in the grain where my blood and his brandy soaked through. He's put a new rug down by the window instead, a smaller one, deep red.

He hasn't set out the second glass today. He hasn't set out anything.

He didn't know I was coming.

I read that on him the moment I'm inside, and it's the first thing all week that's pleased me. For once in his long careful life, Absalom Cray didn't see me coming up the walk.

"Sit," he says. "Please. I know you won't. It's polite to ask."

I sit.



He stops.

He's halfway to the sideboard, reaching for a decanter, and he stops with his fingers just short of the glass and turns and looks at me.

I'm in the armchair by the fire. The good one, the one with the worn arms, the one I've seen him sit in through his window from across the street for longer than I'll ever admit. I'm sitting in it with my knees apart and my bandaged palm on the arm, and I'm looking at him.

His face does nothing, for a moment.

Then it warms.

"Well," he says softly. "Well. That is new."

He pours. Two glasses. He brings one to me and sets it on the little table at my elbow, and he takes the chair across from me, the lesser one, and crosses one knee over the other, and holds his glass without drinking.

I read him.

He's pleased. That much is on the surface, bright and easy. Underneath it, there's more.

His fingers aren't quite steady on the stem of his glass. There's a letter on the side table by his chair, folded once, with a seal I don't recognize pressed into the wax, and his eyes have gone to it twice since he sat down.

Somebody's frightened Absalom Cray.

I keep that, and I don't say a word about it.

"You've thought about it," he says.

"Yes."

"And?"

I look at the fire. It's burning low, even on a day this hot, as if he's cold.

"At the new moon," I say. "My name for hers."



He doesn't move.

I watch it land in him. It goes deep. His shoulders drop a fraction, as a man's shoulders drop when he's been holding a weight up for a long while and somebody finally takes it.

He closes his eyes, very briefly. When he opens them, they're wet.

He's so relieved it's almost indecent.

"Mr. Roche," he says. "I—" He stops. He laughs, softly, at himself. "Forgive me. I find I'm quite moved."

"Don't be."

"I can't help it. It's a very generous thing." He sets his glass down. "Freely given?"

"Freely given."

"At the new moon."

"Yes."

"Here," he says. "I've written to Miss Marchand. The signing is to be here, in this room, at dusk on the night of the new moon. I've invited her to tea." He smiles. "Now I'll set a chair for you as well. A good one. You can have this one, if you like it. You seem to."

I don't say anything.

I'm sitting in his chair in his front room with his brandy at my elbow, and I've just told him I'll give him my name, and I don't know whether I'm lying.

I came here to feint. I came to tell him yes so he'd stop sending men to her gate and breaking her jars, so he'd sit back in his chair and wait for the moon, and give me time.

Time to find another way. Time to read the paper one more time, and the register, and Tobias's list, and find the crack in it.

That's what I told myself on the walk over.

But I'm sitting here now, and the fire is low, and he's looking at me with his eyes wet, as if I've given him a gift, and I can feel how easy it would be.

To put it down.

To give him the name and let the account have it, and let her keep hers, and let her keep her house and her shelves and her cat and her life. To never have to stand in her kitchen again, knowing I could have saved her and didn't.

It would be so easy.

I've been somebody's dog before. The chain's the easy part. It's standing up that's hard.

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You won't regret it," Cray says gently.

"I will."

"Perhaps. A little. The first season." He picks up his glass again. "But you'll go on exactly as you are. You'll stand at your king's door. You'll read his rooms. You'll go home in the evening to wherever you like. The account is not a cruel master, Mr. Roche. It's a very patient one. It asks for very little, most of the time."

"Most of the time."

"Most of the time," he agrees.

"And the rest of the time?"

"The rest of the time, it asks you to bring what you notice." He turns his glass. "Who comes and goes at the King's door. What he

says when he thinks the room is empty. Which letters he burns. Small things. The kind of things you already notice, Mr. Roche, and carry home in your coat."

He's describing my life.

I drink the brandy. It's the Aldric vintage. I can taste the cellar in it, the cold stone and the oak.

"And she keeps her name," I say.

"She keeps her name, and her house, and every jar she has left. The paper is discharged. I never set foot on her step again." He tilts his head. "You have my word, and you know my word is good. It's the only thing I've ever had to sell."

"You don't sell."

"I introduce." He smiles. "And I've never been so pleased to make an introduction in my life."



I stand up to go.

He stands with me. He walks me to the door himself, as a host does at the end of a good evening, a pace behind my shoulder, and opens it for me onto the hot gold dusk of Bywater.

I step out onto his porch.

"Mr. Roche," he says.

I turn.

He's standing in his doorway with his fingers resting on the frame, and his face is pleasant, and fond, and almost apologetic.

"One more thing," he says. "Before you go. I'd hate for there to be any confusion at the signing. There so often is."

"What?"

"She's put her lock on you."

I go still.

"The night you bled into her grandmother's ledger," he says gently. "The lock took your blood and made a promise out of it. I felt it happen, from here. They're not subtle, those old Marchand locks." He tilts his head. "Your name is bound to her now. You can't give it away without her. You'll need her yes."

The street goes very far away.
"Did she not tell you?" Cray says.

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I walk.

I don't know where. I walk out of Bywater along the river with the sun going down red behind the warehouses, and I don't see any of it.

I don't read the ground. I don't read anything.

You'll need her yes.

The lock. The ledger. My palm on the brass, and the warmth under it, and the thread, pulled tight, under my breastbone.

I felt it. I felt it knot and settle, and she said *the promise*, and I asked what it said, and she said she didn't know.

She didn't know then.

Does she know now?

She's a witch. Her whole life is terms and costs and the fine print under the fine print. If there was a knot tied between my name and her lock, she'd find it. She'd go looking for it, as she goes looking for everything.

She knows.

Fuck. She's known, and she hasn't told me.

My phone is in my fist. I don't remember taking it out. I'm standing on the levee with the river going by below me, wide and brown and slow, and the lights of the boats coming on, and I call her.

She answers on the first ring.

"Hey," she says. She sounds breathless, happy. "You're late. The soup's done. Are you coming home?"

I don't answer.

"Silas?"

I stand on the levee with the phone at my ear, and I listen to her breathing, and I think about the knot under my breastbone and her hand on the end of it.

"Where are you, witch?" I ask her. It comes out very low.

"What?" She laughs, uncertain. "I'm at home. Where else would I be? What's wrong?"

I don't know how to say it. I've never known how to say anything.

"I'm coming," I tell her. "Stay there."

I hang up.

I stand on the levee with the river going by, and I look down at my bandaged palm, and I think: she holds my name.

She's held it for a week. She's slept beside me with it. She's let me come inside her with it.

I think of her on her front in her bed with my cock inside her, crying into the pillow while I told her about the yard. I think of her in her grandmother's chair, and on her kitchen floor in the salt with my teeth in her throat. All the ways she's opened for me.

All of it, with my name knotted in her fist.

And she never said a fucking word.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX



“

Name your price,” I tell him, “and don’t you dare say nothing.”



He’s standing in my kitchen doorway with the dusk behind him and Cray’s brandy on his breath. He’s been standing there for a full minute without coming in. He hasn’t said hello.

He hasn’t looked at the window. He’s looking at me, and I’ve never seen that look on him, not once, not even on the step the night the man in the sneakers died.

He knows. Oh, shit, he knows.

I knew he’d find out. I didn’t think it would be tonight.

“You put your lock on me,” he says.

“You told him yes.”

The words hit the kitchen at the same time, his and mine, and hang there over the table between us.

Neither of us moves.

“How do you know that?” he says, very low.

“How the hell do *you* know about the lock?”

“Cray told me. On his step. *You’ll need her yes. Did she not tell you?*” His jaw works. “He thought it was funny.”

"Of course he did. Of course the bastard thought it was funny." My voice is shaking already, and I hate it. "I read you. The night you came home with glass in your palm. I took a hair off your coat and I read you in a spoon, and I saw you in his front room saying *I'll think about it*, and I saw what was under it. You meant it."

"You read me."

"Yes."

"You said you'd never read me."

"I said a lot of things. I was wrong about most of them." I grip the edge of the table. "It cost me my mother's voice, Silas. Did you know that? That's what the reading took. I can't remember what she sounded like anymore. I paid that to find out you were planning to hand yourself to that man like a coat you were done wearing."

He goes absolutely still.

"Your mother's voice," he says.

"Yes."

"For me."

"Yes, for you, you stupid, stubborn, beautiful son of a bitch." I'm crying now. I'm crying and furious and I can't stop either one. "And tonight you walked back into his house and told him yes. Didn't you? Didn't you?"

He doesn't look at the window.

"Yes," he says.



I come around the table.

He doesn't back away. He stands in my doorway and watches me come, and I stop right in front of him, close enough to feel the cool of him, and I lay my palm on his chest and shove.

He goes back a step. He lets me.

I shove him again. He goes back again, into the kitchen, until his shoulders hit the shelves by the pantry door, the tall ones, the ones I restocked after the jars. The new labels in my own writing rattle behind him.

"Name your price," I tell him again. "You want to give yourself away? Fine. Everything costs. Tell me what it costs you."

"Ondine."

"Tell me."

"Nothing," he says. "It costs nothing. It's a name. I've never used it for anything."

"Liar."

"I'm not—"

"You're a *liar*." I grab his shirt in both fists. "It costs you everything. It costs you standing at the end of my table. It costs you every night you'd have had with me. It costs you *me*, Silas. You'd hand him my whole life with you in it, so I could keep a shelf of jars."

He says nothing.

"And you'd have done it without asking," I say. "You'd have walked in there at the new moon with your name in your mouth and found out at the last second that you couldn't give it, and you'd have stood there not understanding why. Because I've got it. Because it's mine. Because you bled into my grandmother's lock without reading the terms, and the terms were me."

His eyes have gone black.

"Then take it," he says.



I don't know who moves first.

His mouth is on mine, or mine is on his. It's not a kiss. It's a fight. I bite his lip and he groans into my mouth and hauls me up against him by the hips, and I climb him like the pantry shelves, my thighs locked around his waist and my fingers dug into his shoulders and the jars rattling at my back.

He turns us. He slams my back against the shelves. A jar goes over, high up, and rolls, and doesn't fall.

"Wait," I pant. "Wait. No. Put me down."

He stops instantly. His arms go still around me.

"Put me down," I say again, and he does, and I stand there with my back to the shelves and my heart slamming, and I look at him.

"You don't get to be in charge of this," I tell him. "Not tonight. Not after what you did."

"Then what?"

I reach behind me to the shelf by my shoulder, without looking, and my fingers find the spool of red thread I keep there. The one from the working they broke. The thread and the bone needle and a twist of salt.

I hold the spool up between us.

"Give me your wrists," I say.



He looks at the thread for a good while.

He knows what it is. He's lived long enough. A witch's red thread, and salt, and the blood-knot already tied between his name and my lock.

He knows that if I bind him with it, it'll hold. He knows it'll hold because of the promise he made without reading it. His own blood's the rope.

"Tell me to stop," I say, "and I'll stop. I swear it. The second you say it."

"I know you will."

"Then give me your wrists, or don't. It's your choice."

He looks at me.

Then he holds out his wrists.

Both of them, together, the scarred one and the whole one, palms up, the linen from Tobias still wrapped around the right one. He holds them out to me in my own kitchen, like a man offering something at an altar, and my breath catches in my throat so hard it hurts.

I wrap the thread around them.

I do it slowly. Around and around, crossing it between his wrists, pulling it snug. I prick my thumb on the bone needle and press one drop of blood into the knot, and I sprinkle salt over it, and I say the

words, plain, the way every working in this house has to be said.

"Bound by his own promise, to the one who holds it. Until I let go."

The thread tightens by itself.

I feel it catch. I feel it tie off against the knot under my breastbone, the one he made when he bled. His wrists are bound together in front of him, and he pulls, once, testing, and nothing gives.

An Elder, bound by a witch with a spool of kitchen thread.

He looks down at his wrists. Then he looks up at me, and his eyes are very dark.

"Now what?" he says.



I duck under his arms.

I step in close and duck my head and come up inside the loop of his bound wrists, so his arms are around me, trapped around my back, and I'm pressed against his chest. He can't let go of me. He can't push me away. His wrists are tied behind my back, and he's holding me whether he wants to or not.

"Lift me," I tell him.

He lifts me.

He can't use his hands. He does it with his forearms and his body, hauling me up against him by the bound wrists at the small of my back, and I wrap my legs around his waist, and he pushes me back against the shelves.

The jars rattle. The wood digs into my shoulder blades.

"You're in my house," I tell him. "You're in my arms. You're tied with my thread. And you're going to listen to me."

"I'm listening."

"You want to give yourself away?"

"Ondine—"

"You want to give yourself away?" I grab his jaw and make him look at me. "Then ask me. Ask me for my yes. Go on. Beg for it."

He stares at me.

"Beg, Silas."

His jaw works. I watch him fight it. Then it breaks.

"Let me," he says. His voice cracks down the middle. *"Ondine. Let me give it. Please."*

"No."

"Please—"

"No." I slide down his body, out of the loop of his arms, and stand on my own feet in front of him with my skirt rucked up and my thighs slick. *"That isn't how you beg."*

"Kneel," I tell him.

He looks at me.

"You want to beg? Beg properly. On your knees, Silas Roche. Now."

He kneels.



He goes down on my kitchen floor with his bound wrists in front of him and his cock straining against his trousers, and he looks up at me with his mouth open.

I put my back against the shelves. I lift my leg and hook my knee over his shoulder and pull his face into my pussy.

"Now ask," I tell him, and spread my pussy open with my fingers right in front of his mouth.

He doesn't ask. He licks me.

One long flat drag of his tongue through my wet, and I buck against the shelves so hard a jar tips over and rolls.

"Ask," I gasp, grinding my wet cunt on his mouth.

"Let me give it," he says against my clit, and sucks it into his mouth, hard, and pushes his tongue deep into my pussy.

"No—oh, fuck, no, no, don't stop—"

He eats me like a starving man. He can't use his fingers. He can't hold me open. He uses his mouth and his tongue and his jaw, and he buries his face in me and licks and sucks and fucks me with his tongue, and I grind my pussy against his mouth with both fists in his hair.

"Look at you," I pant down at him. "The King's enforcer. On his knees in my kitchen, tied up with my kitchen thread, eating my pussy."

"Yours," he says into me.

"Mine?"

"Your enforcer. Your knees." He licks me, slow, from my hole to my clit. "Your thread. Your fucking kitchen."

"Then say it. Say you're mine."

He stops. He looks up at me with his mouth wet and his eyes black, and I watch him reach for it, the whole sentence, and I watch it not come.

"Yours," he says again. It's all he can get out.

It's enough. God help me, it's enough.

"Lick my clit," I tell him. "Slow. Now suck it. Harder. Put your tongue in me. Deeper. Yes. *Yes*, like that, don't you stop. Ask me again," I pant, riding his face, my thighs shaking on his shoulders.

"Please," he says into me, and licks my clit, and sucks, and licks. His voice is wrecked, muffled against my cunt. "Let me."

"No," I sob, soaking his chin.

He sucks my clit harder, his tongue flicking it fast and wet between every pull of his lips.

"*No*— God, Silas, no, I'm never letting you, never, you hear me, *never*—"

"Please."

"No—"

I come on his tongue with *no* in my mouth.

It rips through me. My thigh locks around his neck and my pussy clenches against his mouth, and I scream, and he doesn't stop. He licks me through it, bound and kneeling on my kitchen floor with my come on his face, and when I try to push him away he follows me, his tongue working my clit until I'm sobbing.

"Enough," I gasp. "Enough. Up. Get up."

He gets up. It takes him a moment with his wrists bound.

His mouth and chin are soaked. His eyes are black.

I open his belt. I get his cock out, and he's so hard he's leaking, and I duck back into the loop of his arms.

"Lift me," I tell him. "Put your cock in me and fuck me against these shelves till they fall down."



He lifts me.

He hauls me up by his bound wrists at the small of my back and pins me to the shelves, my thighs spread wide around his hips and my wet pussy open for him, and this time he's the one who finds me. He drives his cock into me in one hard stroke that punches a shout out of my lungs, and then he doesn't stop.

It turns into a fight again, right there against the jars.

"You think you can fuck me out of it?" I pant.

"I think you want me to try."

"I want you to *stop*."

"Then knock," he says, "and I'll stop."

I don't knock. We both know I won't. I grab his hair and pull his mouth to mine and bite his lip, and he laughs into my mouth, rough and furious, and drives his cock into me again.

"That's what I thought," he says.

He can't use his hands, but he can use everything else. He fucks up into me with his hips, hard and brutal, long thick strokes that slam me into the shelves, and I ride him back just as hard. Neither of us will give an inch.

His bound wrists crush me against his chest. My nails are in his shoulders. The jars are rattling so loud the cat bolts out of the kitchen.

"You're not going in there," he snarls against my throat, and fucks his cock up into my pussy so hard my ass hits the shelf. "You're not walking into that room."

"Watch me."

"No."

"You don't get a say. I hold your name." I grab his hair and pull his head back and look into his eyes, and I clench down on his cock

as hard as I can, on purpose, and watch his face break. "I say no, Silas Roche. You can beg me every night till the new moon and I'll say no every night. You can fuck me every night and I'll say no with your cock in me. Ask me again."

"Let me give it."

"No," I say, and drop down onto his cock so hard he sobs.

He pounds into me. The shelf behind my back creaks.

"Harder," I tell him. "Fuck me harder. Break the shelf. I want every jar on the floor."

"You'll have to relabel them again."

"I don't *care*. Harder, Silas. Make me feel your cock in my teeth."

"Yes, witch."

His cock slams into me, and my tits bounce against his chest with every thrust, and my nipples drag against his shirt, and I'm so wet I can hear it, the slap of him driving into me loud and filthy in my kitchen.

"You feel that?" I pant. "You feel how wet I am? That's what you'd be giving up. That's what you'd hand him. This pussy. My mouth. Every morning at the far end of my table. Every fucking night."

"I know."

"Then *why*—"

"Because I'd rather you had it without me," he grits out, "than lost it with me."

I stare at him.

That's almost a sentence. That's almost the whole of him, in one breath, and it hits me so hard I nearly come from it alone.

"Well, I wouldn't," I tell him. "I'd rather have you. You stubborn, stupid, beautiful bastard. I'd rather have *you*."

I'm going to come. I can feel it building, furious and enormous, with his cock hammering into me and the shelves shaking and the broken working's salt still gritty in the floor under his boots. I'm going to come screaming *no* in his face.

He sees it. He reads it on me. Of course he does.

"Name your price, witch," he says, rough, his mouth right against mine.

I look at him.

"You," I say.



I come.

It tears through me, clit to spine. My pussy clamps down on his cock so hard he shouts, in hard shuddering pulses, and I'm sobbing and grinding down on him and holding his face in both palms, and I don't let go of his eyes the whole time.

He comes with me.

He can't hold me. He can't grab me. He can only drive up into me one last time and hold there, buried to the root, with his bound wrists crushing me to his chest, and groan into my mouth while his cock jerks and pulses inside me, over and over, hot and thick and deep, until his come is running out of me down the backs of my thighs.

He's shaking. I'm shaking, my pussy still pulsing around his cock, my thighs trembling on his hips. The shelves are shaking.

One jar falls from the top shelf. It hits the floor beside his boot, and it doesn't break.

We both look at it.

Then we both start to laugh.



Afterward, there's nothing to say.

I let go of the working. I say the words, and the thread goes slack, and I unwind it from his wrists, slowly, around and around, and there are red marks on his skin where it was.

He doesn't rub them. He lets me see.

We don't go to bed. We don't make it that far.

We end up on the pantry floor, somehow, in the dark, among the sacks of flour and the jars of pickled okra. I'm lying on my back with

my skirt still rucked up and his come sliding down my thigh. He's lying beside me with his head on my shoulder.

We don't talk.

There's nothing left to say that we haven't already screamed at each other against the shelves. I hold his name. He'd give it. I won't let him. He won't let me go instead.

Neither of us is going to win. What happens when two people who won't lose walk into the same room at the new moon?

His breathing slows, eventually. My fingers are in his hair.

"Then it'll be you," he says into the dark, very low.

I lie there with my heart slamming.

He means I'll give him my yes, and he'll give his name, and I'll stand beside him while he does it. He means he's heard me say no and he's decided I'll change my mind. He means *you* the way a man says it when he's already let go of something.

That's not what I mean. Christ, that's not what I mean at all.

When I walk into Cray's house at the new moon, it's going to be me. Not my yes. *Me*. My name, my salt, my grandmother's debt, and my hand on the paper.

"Yes," I tell him.

And he hears it wrong.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN



I ask my king for help, which in two hundred years I have never done.



He's in the small study at dawn. He's always in the small study at dawn now. He doesn't sleep much since the crown, and when he does it's in the afternoons, with the shutters closed and Selene's coat thrown over his feet.

She's in the window seat. She's always in the window seat. She has a cup of coffee going cold on the sill and a stack of Aldric letters in her lap, and she's reading them with a pencil in her teeth.

They both look up when I come in.

I stand in the doorway, and my coat is heavy as hell. Every pocket of it has a grave in it now. The receipt. The index card. Tobias's list with *Marchand, H.* halfway down. Cray's note. They sit against my chest like stones.

"Silas," Lucian says. "You're early."

I don't answer.

I look at the window behind his head.

Then I make myself look away from it.

What happens to a man who stops hiding? I don't know. I've never tried.



It's the hardest thing I've done since I stood up out of the mud in that yard. I feel it in my neck, every muscle that's been turning my head toward glass my whole life, pulling, and I don't fucking let it.

I look at my king instead.

He's gone very still. He's watching my face. He's learned what I do with windows, and he's watching me not do it, and I see him understand that something is about to happen that's never happened before.

Selene takes the pencil out of her teeth.

"Sire," I say.

"Yes."

"I lied to you."

"I know."

"More than once."

"More than you're counting," Selene says from the window seat, low. "You're forgetting the one about the brandy."

I close my eyes for a second.

"More than I'm counting," I say.

"Sit down," Lucian says.

I don't sit. I've never sat in this room.

But I come in, and I stand in front of his desk, as I've stood more times than I can count with a report in my mouth, and this time there's no report. There's just me.

"Tell me," Lucian says.

So I do.



I tell him everything.

I tell him the collateral is Ondine. Her own name, signed away by her grandmother before she was born, in the broker's hand. Every name her house holds goes with it. Half the debts of both

courts, sitting on her shelves.

I tell him the paper can't be broken by killing Cray. I tell him why. I tell him what's above Cray, and that it has no face and a column of names and a patience older than the city.

I tell him Cray offered me the substitute. My name for hers. I tell him I went to Cray's house and sat in his chair and said yes.

Lucian's face doesn't change. But his fingers go flat on the desk.

I take the receipt out of my coat and lay it in front of him. The brown ink. The clerk's bad hand. The catcher's word.

He reads it. He reads it twice. When he looks up, his eyes are black.

"Cray," he says.

"He stood at the edge of the pen."

"He sold you to my father."

"He introduced me," I say, and my voice cracks, and I hate the bastard for it. "He'd want me to be accurate."

"He's going to want a lot of things," Lucian says softly. "He won't get them."

Selene makes a sound in the window seat. I don't look at her.

I lay the index card beside the receipt. Then Tobias's list, with the dead names down one side and the graves down the other, and *Marchand, H.* halfway down.

"The account buys grief," I say. "And access. Every time. Tobias found it. It arrives with a fresh grief and buys it off whoever's holding something it wants. It bought Honarine Marchand's. And her grief may have been bought before she ever lost anything."

Lucian looks at the list.

"And the veto," Selene says.

I turn.

She's put down the Aldric letters. She's looking at me with her translator's eyes, and she's heard it. She heard it before I opened my mouth.

"Tell him about the veto," she says. "You haven't yet. It's in your face."

“



When I opened her grandmother's ledger," I say, "I bled into the lock."

"Silas," Lucian says.

"It took the blood. It made a promise. I didn't read the terms." My jaw goes tight. "The terms are that my name is tied to her. I can't give it away without her yes."

Lucian goes very still.

"She knows," I say. "She read me. It cost her the memory of her mother's voice, and she read me, and she found out. She's held my name for a week and didn't tell me."

"And she won't give you her yes," Selene says.

"No."

"She told you no."

"She told me no a great many times," I say, "very clearly," and Selene's mouth twitches.

"So you can't give your name," Lucian says slowly. "And she won't let you."

"Yes."

"And she means to go in herself."

I stop.

I hadn't said that. I hadn't let myself think it. *Then it'll be you*, I said, on the pantry floor, and she said *yes*, and I heard what I wanted to hear, and I've been carrying it around since, a yes I thought meant she'd stand beside me while I gave it.

"She said yes," I say. "Last night. I said *then it'll be you*, and she said yes."

Selene closes her eyes.

"Oh, Silas," she says. "Oh, honey. She didn't mean yes to *that*."



I

stand in front of my king's desk with my coat full of graves, and for the first time in my life, I don't know what to do.

I've always known. I've been a tracker since before I was a man. There's always a trail. There's always a direction and an intent and a place where the ground tells you which way it's going. I read it and I follow it and I do what I'm told.

There's no trail here. Where the fuck is the trail? There's a woman who holds my name and won't give it back, and a paper that can't be broken, and a moon getting thinner every night, and I've run out of ground.

"Sire," I say.

Lucian waits.

I've asked him for almost nothing. A week, once, that he didn't notice. A writ, that he signed without reading. An account, the morning all this started.

I've never asked him for this.

"Help me," I say. "Sire. Help me."



The room goes very still.

Selene doesn't move. Lucian doesn't move. The plane tree outside the window doesn't move.

Then my king stands up.

He comes around the desk. He doesn't hurry. He comes and stands in front of me, close, and he puts his palm on my shoulder.

Never the back of my neck. That's where his uncle used to put his, on Lucian's, as you'd hold a dog by the scruff. I watched Cassian do it more times than I can count, and I watched Lucian not flinch from it.

On my shoulder. Flat. As a man puts his palm on another man, to hold him up.

"You asked me for a week once," Lucian says. "When all this started. You said you were still confirming a name. I didn't notice."

His grip tightens.

"I'm noticing now."



After that, it goes fast.

Lucian sends for Tobias, and Tobias comes up from the registry with ink on his fingers and his useless spectacles pushed up in his hair. Lucian sends for the Roche brothers, and three of them come, big and silent, and stand at the study door. Selene gets up out of the window seat and takes a pen and starts writing.

It's the crown mobilizing. I've seen it before. I've been part of it before, standing at the edge, reading the room while other men planned.

This time I'm in the middle of it.

"Cray's house," Lucian says. "Watched. Every door, every window. Nobody in or out that we don't see."

"Already," Anatole says. "Since the jars."

"Good. The Marchand house. The same."

"The watchers at her ward line," Selene says. "Cray's men."

"Leave them," I say. "They'll tell him if we move them."

Lucian nods. "Tobias. The paper. The original terms. Everything you can find about how a debt like this is discharged. Every precedent. Every loophole. If it can be broken by a witch, I want to know how."

"It can't be broken by decree," Tobias says, very low.

Lucian stops.

"I checked," Tobias says. "The night Silas brought me the register. A witch's debt sits outside the Code. It was made on neutral ground, between a witch and a broker, and the Code has no jurisdiction over it. You can't void it, sire. Not by writ, not by law, not by crown."

Nobody says anything for a moment.

"Then what can I do?" Lucian says.

"You can witness," Tobias says. "Under the Code, a King's witness makes anything done at a signing lawful. Whatever happens in that room, if you're there, it happened under the crown."

Lucian looks at me.

"Then I'll be there," he says.

I look at him. My king, who stood in a chamber and killed his own uncle with a blade I sharpened for him. Who has never once asked me why I look at windows.

What does it cost a king to stand in a broker's front room and watch? What will it cost him in the court, in the letters from the Aldric house?

He doesn't ask. He's decided.

I know that look. I taught it to him.



It takes most of the morning. I stand in my king's study while he and Selene and Tobias and the Roche brothers pull the city tight around one house in Bywater and one house on the canal, and I read all of it, and for once none of it is mine to carry alone.

Selene catches me at the study door before he does.

She puts her palm on my arm and looks up at me with her translator's eyes, and her voice is very low.

"She's going to walk into that room alone," she says. "You know that. She's a Marchand. She thinks this is her grandmother's bill and she's the only one who gets to pay it."

"I know."

"Then don't be a fucking idiot about it." Her grip tightens. "Don't lock her in. Don't try to carry her out over your shoulder. She'll never forgive you, and she'll be right."

"Then what?"

"Be in the room," Selene says. "Just be in the goddamn room."

When she lets go, Lucian comes back to me.

"She means to go in herself," he says. "You know it."

"Yes."

"Then go home." His palm comes back to my shoulder, heavy and flat. "Go home, Silas. Don't let her out of your sight."

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT



Isabeau Vale arrives at my door with a box of her father's letters and a face like a closed piano.



I find the card first.

It's under my mat at dawn, where the envelope was the first night. A small white card, heavy stock, the edges gilded. No envelope this time. Just the card, lying face up on the boards, so I'd see it without having to bend.

Miss Marchand is expected at the new moon. Tea at dusk.

Beneath it, in the same patient script: *Mr. Roche, as well.*

I stand on my porch in my nightgown and read it twice. Then I pick it up by the corner and carry it into the kitchen and prop it against the sugar bowl, where I'll have to look at it every time I want coffee.

The goddamn cheek of the man. Tea. The polite, pralines-bearing, jar-breaking son of a bitch has invited me to *tea*.

I'm still staring at it, cursing it in two languages, when the knock comes.



Isabeau's on my step with a cardboard box in her arms.

It's an old box, the kind stationery used to come in, soft at the corners and tied with string. She's holding it against her chest as though it might get away from her. She's in gloves, as always, and a gray coat buttoned to the throat despite the heat, and her face is shut. Completely shut. The lid down, the keys covered.

"Good morning, Ondine," she says.

"Isabeau. Come in. I'll make—"

"No tea. Thank you." She doesn't come in. She stands on my step with her box. "I shan't stay long. I've brought you something, and then I'm going to go home and lie down for most of a day."

"What is it?"

She looks down at the box. She doesn't say anything.

"My father's," she says finally. "His correspondence. With the broker."

My whole body goes cold.



I make her come in anyway. I make her sit in her chair by the window, and she does, very straight, with the box on her knees and her gloved fingers flat on the lid.

"You saw the seal," I say.

"The first day. On the envelope."

"Yes."

"You knew it."

"I knew it." She's looking at the floor between her shoes. She's been looking at the floor since she sat down. "My father kept a drawer. In his study, at the house. He kept it locked, and he thought I didn't know where the key was." A breath. "I've known where the key was since I was nine."

"Isabeau."

"He wrote to the broker for years. Long before the poison. Long before any of it." Her voice is very level and very low, and it doesn't shake at all, and somehow that's worse than if it did. "When my father died, the King's people searched his study. They didn't find

the drawer. I'd already taken it."

"Why?"

"I don't know." She finally looks up at me. Her father's gray eyes, in her pale shut face. "I didn't want anybody to read them. I didn't want to read them myself. I've had them under my bed for a season and I haven't untied the string."

She holds the box out to me.

"Then Silas came to the registry," she says, "and my cousin Tobias told me what he's looking for, and what the paper says, and whose name is on it." She's still holding the box out, and her arms are trembling now, very slightly. "Tobias said you'd need the broker's writing. Something from his own pen, to put against the line."

I take the box.

It's heavier than it looks.



There are a great many letters in it. Bundles of them, tied in black ribbon, sorted by year in neat writing that must be Cassian's.

I don't read them.

I don't want to read them. I leaf through the bundles with my fingertips and look only at the signatures.

Cray. Cray. Cray.

The same patient slope on every capital. The same small hook on the bottom of the *y*.

"Take what you need," Isabeau says. "Only what you need. Please."

I take four.

I choose them carefully. Long ones, with his name signed full at the bottom, and a good sample of his writing in the body: the capitals, the loops, the particular way he crosses a *t* as if he's drawing a line under something. I tie them together with a length of the black ribbon.

At the bottom of the box, under the last bundle, there's a single letter by itself. It's older than the others. The paper's gone brown. I reach for it.

Isabeau's gloved fingers close over mine.

"Not that one," she says. "That one's mine."

I look at her. Her face hasn't changed. Her fingers on mine are shaking.

"All right," I say.

She takes the letter and puts it inside her coat, and buttons the coat over it.



I lay one of Cray's letters on the table beside the copy of my grandmother's debt.

I know what I'm going to see. I've known since Silas read me the ledger. *Written in the broker's hand*, he said, *not Honorine's*. But knowing and seeing are different things, and I've never had a line of Cray's writing in my kitchen to lay against it.

I lay it down.

I look at the collateral line on the copy of the debt. *Ondine*. My own name, short and bright, in brown ink.

I look at Cray's signature at the bottom of his letter to Cassian. *A. Cray*.

The *O* of my name and the *C* of his are the same. The same round, generous, patient loop. The same small flick at the end where the pen lifted. The same slope, the same weight, the same unhurried hand.

The bastard wrote my name.

I knew he wrote my name. But now I can see it. It's lying on my table next to his own signature, in the same ink, by the same fingers, a man sitting at a table and writing *Ondine* like a note for the grocer.

My grandmother signed at the foot. She signed her name, and she let him write mine.

It was never her writing on the line at all. Holy shit. Never once.

◆ ◆ ◆

Salt for bone.

It comes to me all at once, the way a recipe comes back when you smell the first onion hit the pan. The thing I couldn't get to, the week of the jars, sitting at this table working the paper. The three names.

Honorine, at the foot. Ondine, in the collateral line. And the broker's mark.

A name can't be substituted by anything but a name. That's the first rule.

But a line isn't only a name. A line is a name *and the hand that wrote it*.

If the line was written by the broker, then the broker's hand is part of the line. It's in the ink. It's in the working.

You can use salt for bone if you have to. But if you've got the bone, you use the bone.

His hand. His name.

If I put his own writing against the line he wrote, and answer it with the name that goes with that hand, the paper has to take it. A name the broker wrote, the broker answers. It's the same rule the whole paper runs on.

Any name of equal weight. There is no name of more equal weight to a line than the name of the man who wrote it.

And if the holder is the collateral, there's nobody left for the paper to pass up to.

It voids.

I sit very still at my kitchen table with Cray's letter under my palm.

It'll cost. Every working costs.

A substitution this big, against a paper this old, with that thing at the top of the account watching, is going to cost me more than any working I've ever done. I don't know what.

A year. A name. A memory. A piece of myself I'll never get back. I don't care.

It's my grandmother's bill and my name on the line, and I'm the one who should pay it. Me. Nobody fucking else.

"Ondine?" Isabeau says softly.

I look up. I'd forgotten she was there.

She's looking at my face. Whatever she sees in it makes her stand up, very suddenly, and put her gloves back on.

"You've decided," she says.

"Yes."

"I won't ask what." She picks up her empty box. "Please don't tell me. If you'd be so kind as to never tell me how it ends."

"Isabeau—"

"Thank you for the tea." There wasn't any tea. "All of it. Always."

She goes. She goes out my door and down my step, past the men at my ward line, who don't look at her, and she walks away up the street toward the canal in her gray coat with her father's last letter buttoned over her heart.



Silas comes home at noon.

I hear him on the walk. I know his step now better than my own. He comes up onto the porch and stops, and I hear him read the step, and the mat, and the empty place where the card was.

Then he comes in.

He stands in my kitchen doorway, and he looks at me. At the table. At the four letters tied in black ribbon beside the copy of the debt. At the white card propped against the sugar bowl.

Mr. Roche, as well.

He doesn't say anything for a long while.

"Lucian sent me," he says finally. "I'm not to let you out of my sight, witch."

"Is that so."

"Yes."

"Then sit down," I tell him, "and watch."

He doesn't sit. He never sits. He stands at the end of my table with his coat on and his wrapped palm in his pocket, and he watches me.

He watches me all afternoon.

He watches me put the letters in a paper sleeve and put the sleeve in my bag, the canvas one I take to the market. He watches me measure out salt from the marsh-sack into a twist of paper. He watches me take a knucklebone from the ossuary jar and wrap it in linen. He watches me slide the knife that has never cut food into the side pocket.

He reads everything I do. I can feel him reading it. I can feel his eyes on my fingers and my face and every move I make, taking it all in, trying to find the trail.

I don't give him one.

At one point he comes up behind me while I'm wrapping the knucklebone. He doesn't touch me. He stands so close I can feel the cool of him all down my back, and he breathes in, slow, at my hair.

I lean back against him before I can stop myself.

He's hard. I feel it against my ass through my skirt, thick and heavy, and my pussy clenches on nothing, and I'm wet in a heartbeat, soaking, remembering him on his knees on this floor with his wrists bound in my thread and his tongue in me.

What would it take to tell him? One word. *Silas, listen*. And he'd stop me, and he'd give his name, and I'd lose him anyway.

Shit. Shit, shit.

I step away from him and pick up the salt.

My pussy's still clenching. My nipples are hard against my blouse. I can feel his come from the pantry floor last night, still in me, still slick on my thighs when I shift, and I want to drop the salt and bend over the table and let him fuck me until I forget every word of my plan.

I don't.

"What are you making?" he asks, late, when the light's going gold.

I look up at him from my bag.

Where is he going to be at dusk on the new moon? In that room, with his name in his mouth, ready to hand it over? Or somewhere I've put him, where he can't?

"Supper," I say.

It's true. I'm going to make supper. I'm going to make him the best supper he's ever had, and pour him his coffee at the foot of my table, and take him to bed.

And I'm not going to tell him what's in the bag.

INTERSTITIAL

Cray



The reply to my apology came at dusk, on the eve of the new moon.

I had written very carefully. I had used my best paper and my best pen, and I had said all the correct things in all the correct order, and I had never said *I was afraid*, because one does not say that to the principal.

One simply lets it be understood.

The reply was shorter than my letter. They always are.

The witch is required. The enforcer is a courtesy.

That was all. No reproach this time, and no forgiveness either. Only the terms, restated, in that beautiful unhurried hand, as though I might have forgotten them.

I sat with it in my chair by the window until the light went.



A courtesy.

I have always been fond of courtesies. They are the smallest things one can offer and the ones people remember longest. A glass of the right wine. A name remembered. A chair set for a man before he knocks.

The principal does not want him, and never has. The principal wants the witch, and her name, and the whole city's debts on her shelves, and the enforcer is simply something I may bring if I like, as one brings flowers to a dinner.

I would like to bring him.

I have been rebuked this season. I have been reminded, in a hand that has never hurried, that I am useful and not necessary. I have looked at the column of names in the register and counted the ones that stopped signing, and I have not slept well since.

A man in my position ought to have something in his pocket.

A King's enforcer, freely given, sitting at the King's door and bringing me what he notices. That is not a courtesy. That is a door of my own.



He will not be given freely.

I know that now. I knew it the moment I told him about her lock, and watched his face on my step. She holds his name. She will not let him give it. He did not know until I told him, and I watched him walk away down my street toward the river not knowing what to do with his own feet.

I chose to tell him.

Was it cruel, or only honest? I prefer to think it was honest. A man ought to know what he's signing, even if it's too late to read it.

And now he knows, and she knows he knows, and they will both walk into my front room tomorrow at dusk with their faces set, each of them meaning to save the other.

It will be very moving.

Why do I find that I'm looking forward to it? I have always liked a signing with feeling in it.



The King's hand is coming.

I know this too. My men at her ward line have been counting the Roche brothers, and there are more of them each night, standing at corners, pretending to wait for streetcars that do not run. There are more of them at the end of my own street.

Big men, patient men. They stand very still and they do not blink, and I recognize the posture. I taught it to my own.

And behind the King's hand, the King.

He will come to watch. He will stand in my doorway with her at his shoulder, the translator, and he will say *witnessed*, and whatever is done in my front room tomorrow will be lawful under his crown.

I find I don't mind. I have never done anything in my life that would not bear witnessing. I have only ever introduced people to what they already wanted.

◆ ◆ ◆

So tonight I set the room.

I move the small table to the center of the rug, the new red rug, the one without any stains. I polish it. I set out the good cups on the silver tray, the thin ones with the gold rim that I have not used since before the war, touching each rim with my fingertip.

A cup for me. A cup for her. A cup for him.

I bring out a bottle of wine. A very good year. The same year I left on her step, and he poured out, and I replaced.

I draw the cork now, so it will breathe.

Then the chairs.

I set my own at the head of the table, where I always sit. I set one on either side of it, facing each other, for the witch and the enforcer, so they'll have to look at one another across the paper.

A chair for each of us. No more.

I stand back and look at it in the lamplight.

It's a lovely room. It has always been a lovely room. I have made a great many introductions in it, and every one was gracious, and every one was correct.

Tomorrow will be the most correct of all.

I put out the lamp.

On the table, the cork lies beside the bottle, and the wine breathes
in the dark, and somewhere in the city a very old patience is waiting
for the moon to go out.

I will be gracious to the last. I have always been gracious.

What else is there to be?

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE



“

Get in behind me,” she says, and the bath is already running.



She made me supper first.

I’ve never been fed like that, not in my whole fucking life. She set a plate in front of me at the end of her table, the first plate she’s ever set there, and stood over me until I sat down in front of it. Red beans she’d had going since noon. Rice. Andouille she’d browned in the skillet until it spat. Cornbread with the edges gone crisp and dark in the iron pan, and a jar of her own pepper jelly, and a cold beer she’d bought from the corner store because she doesn’t keep any in the house.

I don’t need to eat. She knows that.

She fed me anyway, and I ate every bite of it, sitting at her table with her watching me across it, and neither of us said a word the whole time.

Then she stood up and went down the hall, and I heard the taps.



Her bathroom is small and old, black and white tile, a claw-foot tub under the window with the enamel worn thin at the bottom. The window's open to the garden. I can smell her mint, and the frog's green water, and the last of the jasmine. There's a candle on the sill, and the steam is rising off the water in slow white coils.

She's undressing.

She does it with her back to me, unhurried. The cardigan. The blouse under it. Her skirt, sliding down her hips to the tile. She's naked in the candlelight, all that soft warm skin, the curve of her spine and the dip at the small of her back and the round of her ass, and she steps into the tub and sinks down with a sigh.

Then she looks at me over her shoulder.

"Get in behind me," she says again. "I'm not going to ask you nicely a second time."

"Yes, witch."

I take off my coat.

I fold it. I lay it over the towel rail with the inside pocket turned to the wall, as I always do now, and she watches me do it and doesn't say anything. My shirt. My boots. My trousers.

The water's hot enough to redden a human. She's pink with it already, from the breasts down. I step in behind her, and the water rises to the lip of the tub, and I sit down in it with my back to the curve of the enamel and my knees on either side of her.

She leans back against my chest.

She fits there. I didn't know that until tonight. Her head fits under my jaw, and her spine fits against my chest, and her hips settle between my thighs as if the bath was made for exactly this, and her wet hair is spread across my shoulder.

I put my arms around her.

She sighs, long and slow, and her whole body goes loose.

◆ ◆ ◆

We stay like that for a good while.

I don't move. She doesn't either.

The candle burns on the sill and the steam rises and the water laps at the enamel every time one of us breathes. I can feel her heart beating through her back into my chest, slow now, slower than I've felt it all week.

I have my palms flat on her belly under the water. The right one, the scarred one, is still wrapped in Tobias's linen, gone gray and soaked. She takes my wrist and unwinds the linen, slowly, around and around, and drops it over the side of the tub onto the tile.

Then she puts my bare palm back on her belly.

"There," she says.

The hot water stings the old burns like hell. I don't give a fuck.

"I asked my king for help," I tell her.

She goes still against me.

"Today," I say. "This morning. I told him all of it. The collateral. The offer. The lock." I breathe in the smell of her wet hair. "The receipt."

"What receipt?"

"The one in my coat."

She says nothing for a long moment.

"You told Lucian," she says.

"Yes."

"Everything."

"Everything."

She turns her head against my shoulder and looks up at me, and her eyes are wet, and none of it is steam.

"You asked for help," she says. "You. Silas Roche. You stood in front of the King and asked for help."

"Yes."

"Oh," she says softly. "Oh, thank God."

She turns her face into my throat and presses her mouth there, and holds it there, and I feel her breathing against my skin, shaky and relieved.

I read it on her, all of it. The relief is real. It's pouring off her. She's so relieved her whole body has gone soft against me.

And under it, another weight. She's holding it very still, down deep, where she thinks I can't reach.

What is it? What's she carrying that she won't set down, even in the bath, even with her face in my throat?

I don't reach for it tonight. God help me, I let it lie.



I'm hard. Of course I'm hard. I've been hard since she stepped into the water, and she knows it. She shifts her hips, slow, and I feel her hum low in her throat.

"I can feel you," she says. She reaches back under the water. "Let me—"

I catch her wrist.

"Not tonight."

She goes still. "Not?"

"Not like that." I bring her hand back up out of the water and lay it on her own belly, under mine. "I don't want anything tonight, witch. Hold still. Let me hold you."

She makes a sound. It's half a laugh and half a sob.

"You," she says. "You're turning me down. In my own bathtub."

"Yes."

"Silas Roche, who once stood between my knees and said *not* and then couldn't tell me why."

"I can tell you why tonight." I put my mouth against her wet hair. "I want to know what this is like. Just this. Nobody's paper. Nobody's cock. You, in the water, and me holding on."

She doesn't say anything for a long moment.

Then she lets her head fall back on my shoulder, and her whole body gives up the last of whatever it was holding, and she lies against me like a woman who has finally been allowed to put something down.



It's the stillest I've ever held anyone. Who knew I had this in me? I didn't. Christ, I didn't.

The water holds us. It laps at her breasts. Her head is on my shoulder and her eyes are closed, and I can feel all of her through my chest: every breath, every small hitch, the beat of her heart slowing down under my palms.

"You're holding me," she says.

"Yes."

"You're holding me," she says again, as if she can't believe it. "You're sitting in my bathtub, and you don't want anything, and you're holding me."

"Yes."

Her tears fall onto my forearm, hot, and roll off into the bathwater.



I don't know how long we stay like that.

The candle burns down. The water cools a little. Her breathing slows until it matches mine, and I don't need to breathe, and I breathe anyway, because she's breathing, and I want to feel her chest rise against my arm when mine does.

"Silas."

"Mm."

"This is the best night of my life," she whispers. "Isn't that stupid? The night before. Of all the nights."

"No."

"We haven't even done anything."

"We're doing this."

She laughs, wet. Then her fingers close over mine on her belly, tight.

"God," she breathes. "God, I love—"

She stops.

I feel her stop. I feel her bite it back, the whole rest of the sentence, and swallow it down, and I feel what it costs her.

I kiss her shoulder.

She's crying again. So am I.

Can a man like me still do that? I didn't know. I didn't know it was still in me, after the yard and the fire and all the years since. But there's water on my face that isn't bath water, and it's running down into her hair.



She turns her head and looks up at me. She sees my face. She reaches up and touches my cheek, wet, with her fingertips, and her own face crumples.

"Oh," she says. "Oh, Silas."

I look down at her in my arms in the water. At her wet hair, and her flushed face, and her mouth that's hers and her grandmother's, and her eyes, swimming.

"I lo—" I say.

It stops.

It comes right to the edge of my mouth and stops there, and I feel it catch, and I can't get it past. It's the biggest thing I've ever tried to say, and it won't come out.

She puts her fingers over my lips.

"I know," she whispers. "Don't. Save it. Say it when you can say the whole thing."

I kiss her fingers.



I dry her hair.

She sits on the edge of the tub wrapped in a towel, and I stand behind her with another towel, and I dry her hair. Slowly. A section at a time. I squeeze the water out of it and rub it gently between the folds of the towel, and she sits there with her eyes closed and lets me.

Nobody's ever let me do this. I've never done it. I've never touched a woman's hair except to hold it out of her face.

I don't know what I'm doing. I do it slowly, and carefully, as I'd follow a trail I didn't want to lose, and when I've got most of the water out I take her wide-toothed comb off the sill and start to work it through from the ends.

"You're good at that," she murmurs.

"I've never done it."

"You're still good at it."

I comb her hair in the candlelight until it's smooth and dark and damp down her back. Then I put the comb down and put my palms on her shoulders.

She reaches up and puts her fingers over mine.

"Tomorrow," she says, without opening her eyes.

"Tomorrow."

"You can walk me to Cray's door."

I bend and kiss her shoulder, right where the towel's slipped. I don't say anything.

She squeezes my fingers and lets go.



I lie beside her in the dark and don't sleep.

She sleeps. She falls asleep almost at once, curled on her side with her damp hair across the pillow and her palm flat on my chest, and her breathing goes slow and even, and I lie there with my eyes open and listen to it.

Tomorrow, the Roche brothers will be at every corner of Cray's street. Lucian will be at the King's house by noon, waiting on my word. Tobias will have the paper. Selene will have a knife she says she keeps in a drawer and never does.

And I'll walk her there myself. What the fuck could go wrong?

Tomorrow she'll let me walk her to Cray's door.

That's what she said. *You can walk me to Cray's door.*

I heard it, every fucking word of it. I heard the grammar, the *to*, the *door*, the place where the sentence stopped.

And I didn't read it.

CHAPTER THIRTY



At four in the morning I make him coffee for the last time, which is a dramatic thing to think about coffee.

It probably isn't the last time. I've run the working in my head from both ends, and my odds are a dark roux: risky as hell, and most mornings you don't burn it.

But you don't make a roux thinking about the time it burned. You make it like it's the only pot you'll ever get.

So. Coffee.



The kitchen is half rebuilt. There are new shelves Silas put up with the Roche brothers' tools, jars I've relabeled twice since the break-in, and the smudge from the jar I threw is still on the far wall because I haven't decided whether I'm allowed to paint over it.

There's no moon tonight. There won't be a sliver of one tomorrow either. That's the whole point of tonight.

Here's the recipe, since I've been saying it to myself all week, bead by bead. The collateral line on my grandmother's paper was written in Cray's hand, not hers. Isabeau's box proved it, and she looked at the floor the whole time she handed it over. A name the broker wrote can be answered with the broker's own name. Salt for

bone. His hand, his name.

It'll work, or it won't. It'll cost something, because everything does. I just don't know what yet, and that's the part I keep turning over in the small hours. Which drawer will it open: a year, a memory, a piece of my own name?

Jesus. Coffee first. Theology later.

I grind the beans by hand because the grinder is loud, and he's asleep in my bed with one arm flung over his face like a man shading his eyes from a lamp. Water, kettle, the chicory tin. He drinks it black. Selene told me that as if it were obvious, and it was.

I almost ask him how he takes it.

I've never asked. It was the first thing I ever got right about him without being told, the first night Lucian walked him into my kitchen and he stood at the end of my table instead of sitting down. If I ask now, he'll hear it. He reads everything.

Would he, though? Last night in the bath I told him he could walk me to Cray's door, and he kissed my shoulder and said nothing, and I lay against his chest wondering how a man who can read a footprint in a wet street could miss a whole sentence in my mouth.

He wasn't reading me. He was holding me. Those turn out to be different skills.



He comes into the kitchen when the kettle starts to tick. Barefoot, in yesterday's trousers and nothing else, his hair flattened on one side.

"You're up."

"Couldn't sleep."

He takes the cup from the end of the table, where I've always put it, and drinks. He watches me over the rim.

What does he see? A woman in her grandmother's cardigan with her hair up in a pencil, barefoot, and no flour on her anywhere, because I haven't cooked a thing. That alone should tell him something's off. I've cooked every goddamn morning of my adult

life.

"Tonight," he says.

"Tonight."

"You'll let me walk you."

"I said you could walk me to the door."

He nods, once, and sets the cup down.

He doesn't hear it. For a man who reads ground for a living, he's hopeless at reading me when he's scared.

I take the cup out of his fingers before he's finished it and put it on the table without looking. Then I press my palm to his bare chest and push him backward out of the kitchen, into the hallway, until his back hits the wall beside my grandmother's portrait.

The frame rattles. Honorine glares down at us in oils, painted in middle age in a high lace collar, her mouth set as if the painter owed her money.

"Ondine."

"Don't talk."

"You never want me to talk."

"I always want you to talk. Not now."

I kiss him. It's the kind of kiss people give each other on train platforms in films, which I've always considered overacting, and here I am overacting in my own hallway at four in the morning.

He kisses me back. His palms come up and frame my jaw and then slide down my throat, over the bite from the other morning, healed to two pale marks, down to the buttons of the cardigan.

"Here?" he says against my mouth.

"Here. Now. Fast."

He goes still.

"The rule first," he says.

"You say stop, I stop. I knock twice, you stop. I know the rule, Silas."

"Say it to me like you mean it."

"I knock twice on this wall and you stop, no matter what, no matter when." My voice wobbles on it, and I hate that. "Now take me hard enough that I don't have to think."



He turns us.

It happens in one movement: his arm around my waist, a half step, and my back is to the wall and his palm is flat beside my head. The portrait is over his shoulder now, watching me.

He rips the cardigan open. Buttons pop and skitter down the hall toward the kitchen. I'm naked under it, because I always am at this hour and he knows it, and even now, with the whole day waiting outside the door, he spends a long breath just looking.

"Silas."

"I'm looking."

"Look faster."

The corner of his mouth moves.

Then his mouth is on my tits, hot and open, sucking one nipple hard enough to hurt while he pinches the other, and his fingers are between my legs. I'm already wet. Of course I'm wet. I've been wet since the moment I decided.

He pushes two fingers into me and curls them, and I buck off the wall.

"Soaked," he says against my breast. "You've been like this all night."

"I was thinking."

"About what?"

About you, and the ward I'm about to put you in, and how angry you're going to be. "About your cock," I tell him, and it's true, if not complete.

He makes a sound that isn't quite a laugh.

Then he goes down on his knees in my hallway.

He hooks my thigh over his shoulder and spreads me open with his thumbs and puts his mouth on my pussy, standing me up against my grandmother's wall with one leg on the floor and the other draped down his back. He eats me like a man with a train to catch. His tongue drags flat and hard over my clit, and he sucks, and he pushes his fingers back into me and fucks me with them while he

licks, fast, relentless, and I slap both palms against the plaster to keep from sliding down it.

"Oh, fuck. Oh, fuck, Silas, fast, you said fast—"

"This is fast," he says into my cunt, and sucks my clit so hard my standing knee gives out.

He holds me up by the thigh. He doesn't slow down. I come on his tongue with my heel drumming his spine and my fingers in his hair, grinding my pussy against his mouth while the aftershocks rattle through me, and he licks me through every one of them before he lets my leg down.

He stands. His mouth is wet to the chin.

He opens his trousers. His cock is hard against my belly, hot and heavy, flushed dark and slick at the tip, and I get my fist around it and stroke him from root to tip. He drops his forehead to the plaster beside my head and swears into it.

"Fuck. Ondine."

"Lift me."

He lifts me. His palms go under my thighs and he hauls me up the wall as though I weigh nothing, and to him I don't. I lock my legs around his waist and my ankles behind his back. The plaster is cold on my shoulder blades. The gilt edge of the frame digs into my ear.

He lines up and drives into me.

It's too much, too fast, exactly what I asked for. I'm not ready, and I don't want to be ready. He splits me open in one hard stroke, and I cry out into his shoulder, and he doesn't wait for me to adjust.

He fucks me against my grandmother's wall, fast and deep and brutal, his hips slamming up between my thighs. The frame knocks on the plaster with every thrust, a sharp wooden rap like somebody at the door.

He stops dead.

"Was that you?"

"That was the frame." I'm panting. "That was my grandmother, banging on the wall. She always hated noise before breakfast."

He looks over at the portrait. Honorine glares right back at him.

"Take her down," he says.

"Fuck her, she can watch. Don't you dare stop."

"She's looking right at me."

"She looks at everybody like that. She looked at the priest like that at my christening." I squeeze around his cock, on purpose, and watch his eyes lose focus. "Holy shit, Silas, you are not going soft on me because of a painting."

"I'm not going soft."

"Prove it."

He proves it.

He hitches me higher and grips my ass with both palms and fucks up into me so hard my head knocks back against the plaster. The angle changes. He's hitting somewhere deep that makes my thighs shake around his hips and my heels drum on his back.

I writhe on him. I can't get away from it and I don't want to. He pins me with his hips and grinds in and holds me there on his cock, deep, and my whole body buckles.

"You're going to feel this all day," he says into my ear, and drives in deep. "Every time you sit down. Every time you walk up your own step. You'll feel where I was."

"Yes."

"Every time you think about him, you'll feel my cock instead."

"Yes. God, yes, keep going."

"Tell me you'll feel it."

"I'll feel it. I'll feel your cock in me all day. Every step. Every time I sit down." My voice breaks. "Fuck me so I never stop feeling it."

"Tonight I'll be right beside you, and you'll still be sore from me."

I almost tell him I love you. It comes all the way up my throat. I bite it back, because if I say it this morning, he'll hear exactly what it is, and he'll stop.

Instead I say, "Turn me around."

He sets me down. My legs nearly fold. He turns me to face the wall, and I spread my palms on the plaster on either side of the portrait's frame, and he kicks my feet apart and grips my hips and thrusts back into me from behind.

The breath goes out of me in a shout.

He fucks me like that, standing, my cheek against the cold wall and my ass pushed back into his hips, his thighs slapping the backs of mine. His fist wraps in my hair and pulls my head back so my throat is bared to the ceiling.

"Look at her," he says in my ear. "Look up. Let her watch you take it."

I look up into my grandmother's painted eyes with a vampire fucking me from behind in her hallway, and I come so hard I scream, my pussy clamping on his cock, my knees buckling, my palms squeaking down the plaster.

He catches me. He turns me back around and lifts me again, face to face, and pushes back inside me, and holds me against the wall with his forehead on mine.

"Look at me," he says. "Ondine. Look at me."

I look at him, and that's when I start crying.

I don't mean to. It comes out of the whole night, out of every hour I lay beside him running the working backward and forward in the dark. It comes out of the coffee. My face crumples and the tears spill over and run into my mouth, salty, and I'm sobbing while he fucks me, big ugly sobs, and I can't stop.

He sees it. He slows.

"Ondine—"

"Don't stop." I grab his hair in both fists. "Don't you dare stop. I'm not knocking. Do you hear me knocking?"

"No."

"Then fuck me. Please. I want it. I want you. I'm just—"

I can't finish. Of all the things to catch from him.

"Please," I say.

He looks at me for one long second, reading. Then he kisses the tears off my face, one side and then the other, and he gives me what I asked for.

He fucks me through it, hard and steady and relentless, his forehead on mine, his breath on my wet mouth, his cock driving up into me so deep I feel it in my throat.

"Cry," he says. "I'll hold the weight."

So I do. I cry, and I come, and I come crying, my pussy clenching around his cock in hard pulses and my whole body spasming against the wall. A sound tears out of me, half sob and half scream, that I'll be embarrassed about later if there is a later.

He doesn't stop. He fucks me through that one and into the next, and when I come again he comes with me. He slams up into me and holds there, buried to the root, groaning into my neck, and I feel his cock jerk and pulse inside me, filling me, until his come is running down my thighs and he's shaking and I'm shaking and the portrait has stopped knocking.

We slide down the wall together.

He ends up on the hall floor with his back to the plaster and me in his lap, still on him, the cardigan hanging off one shoulder and my face in his neck. He strokes my hair. He doesn't ask what's wrong. He never asks what's wrong. He waits.

What would I tell him, if he asked? That I'm about to lock him in my house? That I'm about to take the one thing he ever spent on me and turn it into a leash?



Eventually he gets up to dress. He has to be at the King's house by noon to set the Roche brothers along Cray's street. He buttons his shirt in the hallway, watching me the whole time, and I let him watch.

Then I go to the kitchen drawer where I keep the things I can't afford to lose, and I take out the writ.

It's lived in that drawer since the first night. The King's seal, the wax gone soft because Silas carried it in his coat so long, and Lucian's signature, still looking like it was written by a man with blood drying on his wrists.

I come back into the hall with it, and he stops buttoning.

"What are you doing?"

"Reading."

I stand in my front doorway, barefoot on the threshold where my grandmother laid the first salt line this house ever had. My back is to the street and my face is to him. The door is open behind me, and the air coming in is damp and dark and has no moon in it anywhere.

"Ondine."

I read it out loud.

"Under the crown of New Orleans, protection is extended to the Marchand house and its keeper."

The salt under my feet warms. I feel it through my soles, every line my grandmother laid and every line I've laid since, waking up and turning toward the voice of the house's keeper.

"What is that?" he says. "What are you doing?"

"I'm the keeper of this house. I have been since the day she died." I hold the paper up so he can see Lucian's signature. "A keeper can name a keeper. So I name you. Silas Roche, keeper of the Marchand house, until I come back through this door or the sun goes down again, whichever's first."

"Ondine, don't—"

He comes at me, vampire fast, down the hall.

And the house stops him.

The air in front of the door stops him. He hits it as if he's hit cold water, and it holds, and he stands there with his palm flat on nothing, close enough that I can feel his breath, and he can't come one step further.

"Keeper for keeper," I tell him. "A house keeps its keeper. You're the King's protection now, and you're protecting this house, and the house won't let its keeper leave."

His face.

I have never seen that face on him. It's terror, pure and naked, and all of it is for me.

"Take it off." Very low. "Ondine. Take it off me."

"I can't. It's done."

I fold the writ and put it in my cardigan pocket. It's only paper now. I felt it go when I spoke, the crown's protection pouring out of it into the salt, into the ward, into him.

"That was the cost," I say. "It doesn't protect the house anymore. All it does now is hold you."

"You spent it."

"You spent it first."

He hits the ward with his fist. It doesn't make a sound, and that's worse than if it had.

"I'll be back before dark," I say. I'm crying again. I didn't notice starting. "I'm not surrendering. I'm not giving him my name. I don't spend what isn't mine. You heard me say it."

"Then let me come."

"If you come, you'll give him yours." I make myself hold his eyes. "I felt it in the blood, Silas. The morning in the kitchen. I felt you decide."

He goes completely still.

"I won't let you give yourself away to save me," I say. "That's the one thing I'll never take from you. That'll cost more than I've got."

He puts his forehead against the ward. Against nothing. His eyes close.

"Please," he says.

It lands in me like a dropped plate.

He's asked for so few things in his whole life that the court keeps a list. A week, once, from his king. A writ, for me. The account, the morning all of this started. He's never asked anyone for anything for himself, and he's asking me now, with his forehead on my grandmother's air.

"Please, Ondine. Don't go in there without me."

"Oh, fuck you," I whisper, and it comes out as the softest thing I've ever said. "Fuck you for saying please."

"Ondine—"

I step backward onto the porch, off the threshold, out of the house.

And I close my grandmother's door.



The street is black going blue at the edges, the hour before a new-moon dawn when the sky can't make up its mind. The boards are slick with dew under my bare feet, and my fucking boots are inside, by the door, where I can't reach them.

Shit.

The bag I hid under the porch at midnight is exactly where I left it, and my old boots are in it, because I packed it knowing I'd forget something. Salt, bone, the letters Isabeau brought me, the knife. I sit on the step and lace the boots with fingers that won't work.

Behind the door, he's shouting.

"Witch!"

The whole house hears it. The windows shiver in their frames. Somewhere inside, the cat yowls back at him.

"Witch! Open this door!"

I pick up the bag. I don't look back at the house. If I look back, I'll go back, and if I go back he'll give that man his name before the sun is up.

At the gate I stop hearing him.

That's when I start to run.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE



The ward holds me the way a chain holds a dog, and I know exactly how long it takes to chew through one.



I stop shouting at dawn.

My voice has gone. I shouted *witch* through her grandmother's door until the windows shook in their frames and the cat fled under the stove, and then I shouted her name, and then I stood with my palm flat on the air in front of the door and listened to her step go down the walk, and the gate, and the street, and then there was nothing to shout at.

She ran. I heard her start to run at the gate, the stubborn, brilliant, infuriating witch.

She's gone.

I stand in her front hall with my forehead against the ward and my fists at my sides, and I read what's left of her in the house. The bag she hid under the porch at midnight is gone. The knife that has never cut food is gone from its hook.

The salt-sack in the kitchen is lighter than it was last night. A knucklebone is missing from the ossuary jar. The four letters in black ribbon are gone from the table.

She planned this.

She planned all of it. The supper, and the bath, and her head on my shoulder in the water. The hallway this morning, against her grandmother's wall, her thighs locked around me while she cried and begged me not to stop. She fucked me goodbye and I didn't read it.

You can walk me to Cray's door.

To the door. Not through it.

I heard it, and I didn't read it, and now she's out there in the city with a sack of salt and a dead man's letters, walking into that room alone, and I'm standing in her hallway on the wrong side of a spent writ.

The ward hums against my forehead. Low and steady and patient. It doesn't care that I'm here. It was made to keep a keeper in.



I try the door first.

The doorway is solid. It's not a wall, exactly. It's more like the edge of a floor, the place where the ground stops and the drop starts. My body understands that it can't go that way. I push against it, and it pushes back, exactly as hard.

I try the windows. Every one. The kitchen, the front room, the bedroom, the bath. Every window in the house has the same edge in front of it.

I try the back door. The same.

I try the workroom, her grandmother's, with its old gray threshold. I stand at the salt line and look at it. That ward won't let a non-Marchand in, and this one won't let a keeper out, and between them I'm exactly where she wanted me.

I try the chimney. It's warded too. Of course it is. A Marchand house has been warded against everything that might ever come down a chimney since before there were chimneys.

I stand in the middle of her kitchen, with the jars she relabeled and the smudge on the far wall and the pot on the stove with last night's red beans going cold in it, and I laugh.

It's a bad sound. The cat hisses at it from under the stove.

She's the best I've ever seen. She prepared the room.



The Roche brothers come at noon.

I hear them on the walk. Anatole first, heavy, then two more behind him, and then lighter steps I know.

Selene's. And behind her, a stride I've followed for years across courtyards and ballrooms and through the dark on the worst night of both our lives.

Lucian.

I didn't come to the King's house at noon. So the King came to me.

They come up onto the porch, and the door's open, as she left it. Anatole stops on the threshold and looks at me standing in her front hall.

"Silas?"

"Don't come in."

He comes in. He walks straight through the ward as if it isn't there, because for him it isn't. It was never made for him.

"What the hell happened?" he says. "You didn't come. The street's set. We're all waiting on you."

"She's gone."

Selene comes in behind him. Then Lucian. The three of them stand in her hallway, and I watch them read my face, and I watch them read where I'm standing, and the empty doorway, and my palm flat on it.

Lucian's eyes go to the air.

"That's my writ," he says.

"It was."

"She used it."

"She read it out loud on her own threshold," I say, "and she named me keeper of her house, and a house keeps its keeper. Then she walked out the door and shut it. Before dawn."

Lucian says nothing.

"She spent the crown on a lock," he says finally.

"Yes."

He looks at the ward, at me, at the door she went out.

"Good God," he says. "She's magnificent."



There's a note," Selene says.

She's in the kitchen doorway. She's found it on the table, propped against the sugar bowl where the tea card was, a folded sheet of Ondine's recipe paper with her grandmother's letterhead faded across the top. She holds it up.

I'd seen it. I couldn't read it. I don't read her script.

"Read it," I tell her.

Selene reads it out loud. She reads it as she reads everything, slowly, in two registers at once, and I can hear both.

"*Salt for bone,*" she reads. "*You can use salt for bone if you have to. But if you've got the bone, use the bone. His hand, his name. Take the pot off the heat before it catches. Don't wait up.*"

She lowers the paper.

"It's a recipe," Anatole says, confused.

"It's a recipe," Selene agrees. "And it's a plan. Look at it. *His hand, his name.*" She looks up at me. "She's not going in there to surrender, Silas. She's not handing him her name. She's going to answer his line with his own name. Salt for bone."

"How?"

"I don't know. The letters, probably. Tobias said she needed his writing." Selene's eyes are bright and furious. "She's not surrendering. She's *cooking.*"

I stand very still.

His hand, his name. The four letters in black ribbon. The copy of the debt, laid on her table beside them. *There are three names on this paper,* she said, the day she relabeled every jar. *That's all the paper knows.*

She found the crack. She found it and she didn't tell me, because she knew what I'd do.

I'd have gone in first.

“



What does it cost?” Lucian asks.

He’s asking me. As if I’d know. As if I’ve ever known anything about her craft but that she bleeds for it.

“Everything costs,” I say. “She says that. Every working takes something from the client. The bigger the working, the more it takes.”

“And this is a big one.”

“It’s the biggest she’s ever done. Against a paper that old. With that—” I stop. “With whatever’s at the top of the account, watching.”

“What will it take?”

“I don’t know. A year. A name. A memory. Something she’ll never get back. She paid her mother’s voice to read me. She’ll pay more for this.”

Nobody says anything.

Where is she now? Already in Cray’s front room, laying salt? Or still on the street, walking, with the sack on her shoulder? And what the fuck will he do when he sees his own name coming up out of the paper?

He’s older than me. He’s faster than me. He’s an Elder in his own house, and she’s a witch with a knucklebone.

A witch in a room with a hostile Elder is a dead woman. She told me that, the first week. *Unless she prepared the room.*

She prepared the room for the working. Not for him.



I look at the ward.

“Silas,” Lucian says. “Don’t.”

I put my scarred palm flat on the air in front of the door.

It’s the one part of me that doesn’t feel. The burns from the fire, turned before they healed, dead to everything but fire. I’ve kept it in my coat my whole life. I’ve been ashamed of it every fucking day.

The ward is fire. The ward is her grandmother's salt and the crown's protection and the keeper's name, and it's all holding against me, and the palm that doesn't feel anything is the only part of me that can stand to push on it.

I push.

The air gets hot.

It starts under the scar tissue, deep. A slow burn, and then not slow. It spreads out from the center of my palm along the old ropes and whorls, and the smell comes up, the smell I haven't smelled since I was lying in a road with my fists in the ashes.

Burning skin. My skin. The old burns are waking up.

"Silas," Selene says. "Silas, stop, your palm—"

I don't stop.

I push harder, and the ward pushes back, and the scars split.

They open along every seam. I feel it go, a line of fire from the heel of my palm to the base of my fingers, the old tissue cracking like a crust of bread, and blood comes up out of it, dark and slow. The ward drinks it. It hisses where my blood hits it. It's so hot now the air in the hallway shimmers.

I take my coat off with my other arm and wrap it around my wrist, around my forearm, and push again.

The coat catches. I feel it smolder. The smell of burning wool joins the smell of burning skin.

"*Silas—*"

It's giving.

It's a chain, and I know how to chew through a chain. You don't pull. Pulling is what a new dog does, and a new dog breaks its own neck. You lie down beside the post and you work at the same link, over and over, patient, for as long as it takes, until the metal goes thin.

I work at the same place in the air.

I lean my whole weight into my ruined palm and I hold it there. The blood runs down my wrist into what's left of my coat.

The burns split further, up my forearm now, along the old whorls toward the elbow, and I can feel them. For the first time since

the road, I can feel every single one of them.

It hurts like hell.

I laugh, because it hurts, and I can feel it, and she's out there alone.

Then the ward goes thin under my palm, and thinner, and my hand is through it.



I fall through the door.

Onto her porch. Onto the board that gives. I go down on one knee on it and it creaks under me and I stay there, breathing when I don't need to, with my right arm held against my chest, blistered and split and bleeding from the fingers to the elbow, and what's left of my coat in smoking rags around it.

I shake the coat off. It falls on the porch, black and burned through. Everything in its pockets is ash now. The receipt. The index card. Tobias's list.

Good. Let the bastard's paper burn.

Lucian is beside me. He's crouched on her porch in his black coat with his palm on my good shoulder, flat, as he put it there in the study.

"Can you use it?" he says. "That palm."

I close my fingers. It hurts so much the edges of the world go white. They close.

"Enough," I say.

"Can you use a blade with it?"

"Left."

He looks at my face. He reads it. I watch him do it, as I taught him to, and I let him.

"Cray's house," he says. "She'll be there already. She'll have been there all morning."

"Yes."

"Dusk is the signing. The paper comes due at dark." He glances at the sky. It's late afternoon. The light's gone thick and gold. "You don't have long."

"I know."

He stands. He pulls me up with him by my good arm, and holds me there until I've got my feet.

Selene's on the step with the recipe in her fist. The Roche brothers are at the gate.

The street's empty. Cray's watchers are gone from the ward line, all three of them, as if they've been called home.

Lucian looks at me.

"Go," my king says. "I'm right behind you."

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO



I always prepare the room.

I ran nearly the whole way across the city to get to this one.

Down my street in the blue dark, along the canal, through the Marigny with my bag banging against my hip and my lungs on fire. The whole time I could still hear him in my head, shouting through my grandmother's door.

It's amazing what you can outrun when you're scared enough. His voice isn't on that list. I can hear it right now, standing in this man's hallway, clear as the kettle.

Christ, what have I done to him?

Cray lets me prepare it, and that's the part I keep turning over while I work. He opened his door before I knocked, in shirtsleeves and a dark waistcoat, and took in my bag and my laced boots and my face, still blotchy from crying on my own porch.

Then he stepped back and said, "Miss Marchand. How lovely. You'll want the front room, I expect. The light's better."

The light is better. I'll give the bastard that.



His house smells of clove and cold ash and beeswax, with old paper under all of it, like an archive nobody has aired in a century. Under the rug by the table there's one more smell, faint, scrubbed at and not quite gone: brandy, and blood.

I know that blood. I opened my grandmother's ledger with it.

So this is where Silas broke the bottle. I stand on the stain a little longer than I need to, and I let myself be furious about it, because furious is easier to carry than scared.

Then I get to work.

Salt first, always. I lay a line across the threshold of the front room, fine and unbroken, poured from a paper twist with my wrist loose and never stopping, as I was taught.

Then a ring around the table, wide enough to take every chair. Then a short line under the window, because windows are just doors for people with better manners.

Cray watches from the hallway with his fingers laced in front of his waistcoat.

"Marchand work," he says. "I've always admired it. Your grandmother laid a line like that across my feet once. I was quite moved."

"She threw a jar at them, is what I heard."

"That too." He smiles. "The line came after. She was a very thorough woman."

"She was a lot of things."

"Yes." He says it gently, as if we're at her wake. "She was."

He watches me pour for a while. I can feel him deciding whether to say more.

"You have her mouth," he says at last. "Did anyone ever tell you? When you set it like that. I noticed it on your step, the first night."

"Don't."

"It was meant kindly."

"Everything you say is meant kindly. That's what's so fucking unbearable about you."

He inclines his head, as if I've paid him a compliment he'll treasure.

"Would you like tea while you work? I have a very good Assam."

"I'd like you to stay on your side of the salt."

"Of course." He takes one step back into the hallway, precisely one, and folds his fingers again. "Your house, your rules. Even here."

I don't answer him. I lay the bone.

It's a knucklebone from the Marchand ossuary jar, yellow and light as a dried bean, and I set it at the head of the table where the paper will lie.

You can use salt for bone if you have to. I'm not going to have to. I brought the real thing.



He's set three chairs.

One at the head, for himself. One on each side, for me and for Silas, facing each other across the table. Three good cups on a silver tray. A bottle of wine, the cork already drawn so it can breathe.

He set a place for Silas. He was so sure, the smug son of a bitch.

I drag a fourth chair in from against the wall and put it at the foot of the table, facing his, and I straighten it until all four legs sit square inside the salt.

He tilts his head.

"Who's that for?"

"The principal." I don't look up. "Every party at the table. You can't change the terms of a debt behind the creditor's back, or the creditor comes to collect the change. You taught my grandmother the forms. You know that."

For the first time since he opened the door, he looks at me as if I've said something he hadn't already guessed.

Then his whole face warms.

"How correct," he says softly. "How very correct. Nobody has thought to set that place in a long time."

The room shifts when he says it. The lamp flame leans a fraction toward the empty chair and then straightens again.

I pretend I didn't see that. Jesus Christ, I saw that.

What exactly did I just invite to sit down? And why does it feel so pleased to be asked?



He brings out the paper in a leather folder gone soft with age and lays it open on the table in front of the knucklebone.

There it is. My grandmother's obligation.

I've seen it copied in her ledger, and I've read it described in her dying script, but I've never seen the original. Honorine's signature sits at the foot, surname only, careful and upright. Above it, the consideration, delivered. And above that, the collateral line, one name, in writing that was never hers.

Ondine.

He wrote me down.

Before I was ever born, a man sat at a table and wrote my name like a note for the grocer. Eggs, butter, shit, a granddaughter.

"Whenever you're ready," Cray says. He takes his chair at the head, crosses one knee over the other, and folds his fingers on his knee. "There's no hurry at all. Mr. Roche will be along, I'm sure."

"He won't."

"No?"

"I locked him in my house."

Cray laughs, delighted, a warm real laugh I didn't expect him to have in him. "Oh, well done. With what?"

"The writ."

"The King's writ." He shakes his head, admiring. "You spent the crown on a lock. Your grandmother would have kissed you on both cheeks."

"My grandmother sold me to you."

"Introduced," he says. "She introduced you. I've never sold anyone anything, Miss Marchand. Mr. Roche will tell you the same."

"Mr. Roche will tell me a lot of things, after he's done yelling."

"I look forward to it."

I sit down in my chair, and I take out Isabeau's letters.



There are four of them, tied with black ribbon, and every one of them is in his hand.

Cassian's correspondence with his broker. Isabeau Vale brought them to my door in a box, with her face shut tight as a piano lid, and when she left, she asked me, very politely, never to tell her how it ends.

I untie the ribbon. I lay the top letter flat beside the collateral line, so that his signature sits right next to my name.

Same serifs. Same slope on every capital. Same patience.

Cray's eyes go to the letter, and then to me. His fingers stay folded on his knee.

"What are you cooking, Miss Marchand?"

"Salt for bone," I tell him.

I take out the knife that has never cut food, and I cut my thumb with it.



Blood on the salt. That's how every working starts in my house.

The client pays in, and the house holds the payment.

I press my bleeding thumb to the salt ring, then to the knucklebone, then to the paper just under the collateral line. Then I say the terms out loud, because you have to. Plain words, every one. A witch who hides the terms from herself pays what she didn't intend.

"This line was written by the broker's hand. The broker's hand is here." I touch his signature on Isabeau's letter. "A name the broker wrote, the broker answers. His hand, his name."

The ink moves.

It's small at first. The first letter of my name softens at its edges, as if the paper under it has gone damp. Then the whole word

loosens and lifts, just barely, a thread of old brown ink standing up off the page like a hair in a draft.

It's working. It's actually fucking working.

Across the table, Cray has gone very still.

And then the fourth chair pushes back.



The chair itself doesn't move. Whatever is sitting in it leans forward, and every flame in the room leans with it. The air goes heavy and cold, and suddenly it smells of river silt and wet stone and a candle burned down to nothing in a room without a window.

It doesn't speak. It has never needed to.

It looks at the paper, and at me, and at the thread of my name standing up off the page.

And it doesn't agree.

I feel the refusal as pressure, the weight under a pot lid a second before the pot boils over.

It's patient. God help me, it's so patient. It's older than my house and older than Cray's, and it has never once been in a hurry, and it has all night to wait me out.

I have until sundown, a cut thumb, and a knucklebone.

The thread of my name starts to settle back onto the paper.

"No," I say. "No, you don't. Not in my working."

I press down harder with my thumb. The cut opens wider, and I bleed into the salt, and I say the terms again, louder.

"His hand, his name. You took a line in the broker's writing. You don't get to keep it in mine."

The pressure doesn't lift. It changes. It stops pushing, and it starts asking.

Every working costs the client something enforceable. I know that better than anyone alive. I've charged a year, a name, a memory, a favor with no ceiling on it. I've sat on the paying side of my own table exactly once, and it cost me my mother's voice.

So what does it want? What would something that old even bother to take from me?

"Fine," I say, and my voice cracks right down the middle. "Fine. Take it. Take whatever you want and get the fuck off my name."



It takes her face.

I feel it happen. I'm thinking of her, because of course I'm thinking of her, at a table with salt and bone and her name at the foot of the page. I'm a little girl in her kitchen and she's teaching me salt for bone, her fingers over mine on the paper twist, her voice saying *wrist loose, chère, never stop pouring.*

I can see her fingers. I can see the salt. I can see the high lace collar from the portrait in my hall, the one she glared out of this morning while I cried against her wall.

Where her face should be, there's nothing at all.

No darkness, no blur. Her face is simply gone, lifted out of me clean, as neatly as I'd fish a bay leaf out of a pot before I serve it.

I make a sound I've never made in my life.

On the paper, the thread of my name comes clean off the page, a curl of brown ink hanging in the air above the table, and then it dissolves.

For one breath the collateral line is blank.

Then new ink rises into it from underneath, from inside the paper itself, in a patient hand with a familiar slope on every capital.

Absalom Cray.



He understands before I've finished reading it.

I watch it land in him. For a second his face does nothing, that pleasant nothing he wears for everyone.

Then it breaks.

He moves.

I don't see him do it. Nobody sees an Elder move. I'm in my chair, and then I'm not, and his fingers are around my throat and my back hits the wall so hard the plaster cracks behind my skull.

My boots are off the floor. I kick him, and it's like kicking a doorframe.

"Take it off."

His voice is still perfectly polite, and that's the worst part of all. His grip is crushing my windpipe, and his voice is the same one that offered me wine on my own step.

"Take it off, Miss Marchand. Please. You don't understand what you've put in that line."

I can't breathe, and I can't answer. I claw at his wrist and it doesn't give, not even a little.

A witch in a room with a hostile Elder is a dead woman. I've always known that. Every witch in this city learns it before she learns to pour salt.

I prepared the room anyway. I prepared it for the working, not for this, and I'm going to die of that distinction on a nice man's plaster.

Silas is going to be so goddamn angry with me.

"It's done," I croak, with the last air I have. "It was always your hand."

His grip tightens.

Behind him, the fourth chair sits perfectly still. Whatever is in it is watching the two of us now, a buyer at an auction with no preference at all about who wins.

Is this how she felt at the end, with the medicine rattling in her chest? Did she know what she'd signed me into, or did he tell her it was nothing?

Did I really have her mouth? I'll never know now. Oh, fuck.

My vision starts going gray at the edges.

And the front door comes off its hinges.



It doesn't open. It comes off. It slams into the hallway wall in two pieces, and the salt line I laid across the front-room threshold goes up in a spit of white sparks as a body crosses it without slowing down.

Silas.

His right palm is raw and open, blistered to the wrist, the old burns split and bleeding down his fingers onto Cray's floor. His coat is gone. His face is doing what I've only ever seen it do once, in my kitchen, standing in the glass.

He looks at Cray's fingers on my throat.

"Witch," he says, very low. "Look at me."

I look at him.

I try to think of her, so I'll have one thing to hold on to while the gray closes in. The kitchen. The salt. The lace collar. The voice saying *never stop pouring*.

I can't remember my grandmother's face.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE



“

Mr. Roche,” Cray says. “You’re early. I did so hope you would be.”

He’s holding her up against his wall by the throat, her boots clear of the floor, and his voice is exactly the voice he used on her step with a bottle of wine hanging from his fist.

Her lips are going blue.



I read the room because I can’t stop reading rooms, even now, with my palm split open and her face that color.

Salt across the threshold, broken where I came through it. Salt in a ring around the table, still whole. A knucklebone.

Three good cups on a tray, and one chair more than he set. The fourth chair sits at the foot of the table, empty, and every flame in the room leans toward it.

A presence sits in that chair. It has no interest in me. It’s watching the paper.

On the paper, in the collateral line, in Cray’s own patient slope, is his own name.

She did it. Fuck me, she actually did it.

And Cray is standing with his weight on his back foot. In all the nights I’ve watched this man from across his street, I’ve never once

seen him stand like that. Why would he? What has he ever had to be afraid of?

He's afraid now.

"Put her down."

"She's put me in the line, Mr. Roche." Polite. Reasonable. His grip doesn't shift. "Do you understand what she's done? Do you have the faintest idea what's sitting at the foot of that table?"

"Put her down."

"I'd like her to take it off first."

"She can't breathe, you bastard. She can't take off a fucking thing."

He considers that. He looks at her face, then at me.

Then he throws her.

He throws her across the room, low and hard, as easily as tossing a coat onto a chair, and she hits the floor inside the salt ring and rolls against the leg of the table. I hear her drag in air, one long ugly whoop of it, and then another.

She's breathing.

I don't look at her. If I look at her, he gets me.



He comes at me before the second breath is out of her.

I don't see him move. I read where he's going to be and I'm already turning when his fist lands on the side of my head, and it lands anyway. The room goes white. My shoulder hits the doorframe and the wood splits down its length.

He's fast. He's older than me and he's never once had to prove it, and he proves it now.

I get my left arm up. He takes it by the wrist and turns it, courteously, as if he's helping me into a coat, and the bone goes with a crack I feel in my back teeth.

"I introduced you to a king," he says in my ear. "I could as easily have introduced you to the river."

I put my forehead into his nose.

It breaks. It's back in place before he's finished stepping away, but it breaks, and his blood is on my face, and it smells of clove with an older rot underneath.

He looks surprised. Nobody has hit him in a very long time.

My left wrist knits while I watch. My right palm doesn't. The burns I tore open on Ondine's ward hang off the heel of it in strips, and every time I close my fingers the old wounds scream at me.

So I fight him left-handed.

My blade is out. I don't remember drawing it. Plain steel, a bone grip, the knife I've carried since Aurelian bought me out of that yard.

I go in low, and he's gone. I go in again, and he's gone again, and his good cups go off the tray and burst on the floor, and he doesn't so much as glance at them.

"Stand still, you polite fuck."

"I'd rather not," he says.

He's drifting toward the table. Toward the paper.

If he breaks her salt ring, does her working hold? I don't know. I don't know anything about her craft except that she bleeds for it, and I'm not finding out tonight.

I throw myself between him and the ring.

His knee takes me under the ribs and I fold over it. A rib gives, then the one below it. I feel them go into the lung they're supposed to be keeping safe.

He brings his elbow down on the back of my neck, and I hit the floor a hand's width from her salt.

I don't touch it. I don't let so much as my sleeve cross the line.



He puts his shoe on my right wrist.

The thin sole. The one that's never known mud. He stands on the open burns with his whole weight and grinds, slow and patient, and I make a sound I haven't made since I was chained low with my eyes on the ground.

He crouches beside me. He's barely breathing hard. He takes my chin between his finger and thumb and turns my face up to his, gently, and his eyes are pleasant again. Almost fond.

"You were a dog," he says.

The room goes still.

Nobody has said it to my face since the yard, because nobody has ever been close enough. And he says it in the same flat tone the man with the kennel keys used every morning, never cruel, just accurate, a man naming property that belongs to someone else.

"I never cared for the term," Cray says. "I never once used it. But it was always true, Mr. Roche. You were a dog. You wore his collar and you called it a house. You'll wear mine and call it a crown. You were—"

"I was a dog."

My voice comes out steady. I don't know where from.

He stops.

I look up at him from his own floor, with his shoe on my ruined hand and her breathing behind me, and I say the rest of it.

"Never yours."



It's the first sentence about myself I've ever finished out loud.

It sits in the room with us. I can feel it there, finished and whole, like a knot pulled tight. It doesn't need anything added. It doesn't trail off into the floor. It ends where I ended it.

Cray looks at me as if I've undressed at his table.

And behind me, from the floor, Ondine speaks.

"It's dark," she rasps. Her voice is wrecked, barely there. "Look at the window, broker. The sun's down, and there's no moon in it."

The window behind the table is red going black. Past the roofs, the last light is draining out of a sky with nothing in it.

"The Marchand obligation falls due at the new moon," she says. She's up on one elbow in the salt, her bleeding thumb pressed flat to the ring. "You wrote that. Your hand. Collect him."

She isn't talking to Cray.

She's talking to the fourth chair.



Every flame in the room goes flat.

The cold comes down off the ceiling, river silt and wet stone and a candle burned to nothing, and the presence in the fourth chair takes its attention off the paper and puts it on the man crouched over me.

Cray feels it. I watch it land across his shoulders.

He takes his shoe off my wrist. He stands, slowly, and turns to face the foot of the table, and he tugs his waistcoat straight.

"I have always been courteous to you," he tells the chair. "Always. I have never once refused you anything. I am—"

He stops.

"I am Absalom—"

The name doesn't come.

I see him reach for it. I've watched a thousand men reach for things they dropped, and I know the look: the small frown, the fingers going to a pocket that's suddenly empty.

"Forgive me," he says to the chair, bewildered. "I seem to have mislaid—"

He can't finish it.

He tries again. His mouth shapes the start of a word and nothing follows it. He looks down at the paper on the table, at the collateral line, at his own patient slope, and I watch him read his own name and not know it.

"Who wrote that?" he says. "Whose writing is that?"

He's losing the end of every sentence about himself, and he's losing it in front of me.

How long have I lived like that? How many rooms have I walked out of with half of myself left on the floor?

I get up.



My ribs grind like gravel. My wrist is whole and my palm isn't, and I don't give a fuck about either.

I take him from behind, my good arm around his throat, and haul him backward away from the table. He doesn't fight me. He's still looking at the paper, still trying to read it.

I put him down on his knees on his own rug, on the stain where I bled on his brandy.

The front doorway fills.

Lucian first, in a black coat, wearing the face he wore in the chamber the night his uncle died. Selene behind him with her knife out and her eyes going everywhere at once, reading the salt, the chairs, the paper, Ondine on the floor. The Roche brothers fill the hall behind them, blocking the street.

Lucian looks at me with my blade at Cray's throat. He looks at Ondine. He looks at the fourth chair, and whatever he sees there sets his jaw hard.

"Under the crown," my king says. "Witnessed."

Selene says it after him, low, in her court voice. "Witnessed."

Cray lifts his face to me. His eyes have gone soft and puzzled and very young.

"Mr. Roche," he says. "Would you — I'd be so grateful if —"

He doesn't know what he'd be grateful for. He's lost that too.

I take his head.



It doesn't come easy, and it shouldn't. The Code wants it complete, because a partial cut on an Elder grows back, so I do it the only way it can be done: left-handed, my knee in his spine, the plain blade and every ounce of weight I have behind it.

It takes two strokes. The second goes through into his own floorboards.

The body folds onto the rug. The head rolls a short way and stops against the leg of the fourth chair.

And the chair lets go.

The cold lifts off the room.

It rises out of the chair and out of the salt and out of the walls, unhurried as a guest leaving a party it found tolerable, with somewhere else to be and no reason to rush there.

The lamp flames stand up straight. The air smells of clove and ash and blood, and nothing older.

It didn't lose. It finished here, and it went.

On the table, the paper curls at its edges. The collateral line goes blank. Then the consideration, then the date in old Marchand calendar, then Honorine's careful signature, letter by letter, until the page beside the knucklebone is nothing but old cotton stock with a faint brown stain where a dying woman's medicine once fell on it.

The holder was the collateral. There's nobody left for it to pass to. It's void.



I'm on my knees beside her before I know I've moved.

She's sitting up in the salt with her back to the table leg and her boots splayed, her throat black with the shape of his fingers.

Her thumb is still bleeding. Her face is gray and streaked, and she's looking at the blank paper, and then at me.

"Witch." I don't recognize my own voice. "Breathe. Look at me and breathe."

"I'm breathing." It comes out a croak. "You finished a sentence."

"I know."

"About yourself."

"I know."

"I heard it." Her mouth wobbles. "I heard it, Silas. Out loud. In front of the goddamn King."

I take her face in my good palm and put my forehead to hers.

Behind me Selene is talking to Lucian, low. The Roche brothers are stepping over the broken door. Someone is lifting Cray's body off his own rug. I don't turn around for any of it.

"I can't remember her face," Ondine whispers.

"Whose?"

"Hers. My grandmother's. That's what it took. I paid it and I didn't even get to pick." She's crying now, the silent kind, with no breath behind it. "I can see the lace. I can see her fingers on the salt. I can't see her face."

I don't have anything to say to that. I don't have a sentence for it.

"I'm here, witch," is all I can manage. "I'm here."

I hold her and let her cry into my ruined shirt, and I read her the only way I know: where the weight goes, and where it's going next, and whether she's carrying something.

She's carrying all of it.

What do you give a woman who paid for her life with the face of the person who sold it? Two hundred years of trails haven't taught me that.



Selene finds the ledger in the writing desk under the window.

She brings it over and crouches beside us and opens it on her knee, so I can see without letting go of Ondine. Heavy stock, leather gone black at the spine. It isn't the register I took from Bywater. It's his own book, the broker's book: every introduction he ever made, and beside each one, in a column, the name the account was signing with that year. Hands that don't match. A patience that does.

Honorine is in there. So is the Aldric house, and Cassian, and names I don't know from cities I've never walked.

"He kept every one of them," Selene says.

Lucian stands over us with his coat open and blood on his cuffs that isn't his. He studies the ledger. Then he looks at me.

"It's still yours," he says. "The account. If you want it."

I look at the book on Selene's knee, at the first page, older than anything in this house, older than the King's house, in writing I've never seen.

Who keeps a column of names for that long and never once gets tired of it?

"Yes," I say.

Then I look down at the woman in my arms, and the account can wait until the end of the world.

She lifts her head off my shoulder. She looks past me, at the body under Lucian's coat, at the blank paper, at the fourth chair standing empty at the foot of the table. Then she looks at me, and her swollen mouth moves.

"Take me home, Silas."

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR



The cat forgives Silas before I do, and that's a betrayal I'll be addressing.



We come home at full dark, the night of the new moon, and there isn't a sliver of light in the sky. Silas carries me up my own walk. I tell him I can walk.

He ignores me. His right arm is wrapped to the elbow in linen that Tobias tied in Cray's front room, and he carries me with the left, and he steps over the board that gives without looking at it.

The door's open. The coat he burned through my ward is lying in black rags on the porch.

He carries me into the kitchen and sets me down in my chair.

And the cat comes out from under the stove, walks straight across the floor, ignores me completely, and climbs into Silas's lap the second he sits down at my table.

Silas goes rigid.

The cat turns around twice and settles on his thighs and starts to purr.

"Get off him, you little shit," I say. My voice is still wrecked. It comes out a croak. "He broke the ward. He's a vandal. He burned a hole in my house."

The cat purrs louder.

Silas looks down at it. Then he puts his good palm on its back, very carefully, as though it might explode.

"He likes me," he says.

"He's a traitor."

"He likes me," Silas says again, sounding faintly amazed.

I'd laugh, if my throat didn't hurt like hell. I sit in my chair and look at the two of them, the vampire and the cat, in my kitchen, in the dark, and I can't remember my grandmother's face, and I start to cry instead.



It's gone.

I knew it would be. I felt it go, in Cray's front room, with my thumb bleeding into the salt. But knowing a thing and waking up the next morning to it are different animals.

I get up at dawn. I walk down my own hallway in my nightgown to where her portrait hangs, and I stand in front of it.

I can see her. That's the cruelest part. I'm looking right at her. Oils, gilt frame, a woman in black with a high lace collar. I can see her face on the canvas, in the gray morning light.

And the second I look away, it's gone.

I look back. There she is. I look away. Nothing. I can't hold it.

It won't stay in me. It's water in a colander. Goddamn it. Every time I turn my head, there's just the lace and the black and a clean, blank space where her face should be.

I stand there in the hall turning my head back and forth like a goddamn idiot, crying, until he comes.

He doesn't say anything. He comes up behind me and stands there, not touching me, and looks at the portrait over my shoulder.

"Tell me," I whisper. "I can't hold it. Tell me what she looks like."

He doesn't answer right away.

"She's standing," he says finally. "Not sitting. Her shoulders are very square. The painter put her against dark green, almost black.

There's a window behind her, painted in, with rain on the glass."

I close my eyes.

"Her chin's up," he says. "She's looking a little to the left of whoever's in front of her. As if there's somebody behind you she'd rather be talking to."

A laugh comes out of me, wet and broken.

"That's her," I say. "That's exactly her."

"There's more," he says. "Tomorrow."



He tells me more the next morning. And the next. And the next.

Every morning, before I'm properly awake, he tells me a piece of her. He stands in the hall at night, I know he does, I've heard him, and he reads her as he'd read a stretch of road. In the morning he gives it back to me, a little at a time.

Her eyebrows. Her ears, which were small and close to her head, which I'd never noticed. The line between her eyebrows that the painter tried to hide and couldn't. The color of her dress, which was black but had a green sheen to it, like a crow's wing.

He never gives me the whole face at once.

I asked him why, the fourth morning.

"Because then you'd have it all," he said, "and I'd have nothing left to tell you."

I kissed him so hard he knocked the portrait crooked, and then I kept kissing him, my tongue in his mouth and my tits pressed against his chest and my thigh riding up his hip, until his cock was hard against my belly and his palm was under my nightgown on my bare ass. He fucked me against the hallway wall under her crooked portrait, fast and slow and fast again, with my knees locked on his hips and his mouth on my throat, and I came on his cock telling him about her eyebrows, and I didn't give a shit.



The kitchen gets rebuilt.

The Roche brothers come on the third day with a truck and new lumber and a box of tools, and they don't say much, and they build me new shelves. Deeper ones, of good cypress, stained dark, running up to the ceiling on the long wall.

Anatole's wife sends a pot of gumbo with them. Silas holds the boards while they drive the nails, with his left arm, because his right is still healing.

It's healing wrong.

Or right, depending on how you look at it. The new splits close up as vampire skin closes, quick and clean. But they close back into exactly what was there before. The same ropes and whorls. The same old burns from the fire. His body won't heal what was done before it was turned, and it won't make it worse, either. It just puts it back.

"Does it hurt?" I asked him.

"Yes."

"Good," I said, and he looked at me, startled. "It means you can feel it."

He thought about that for a long while. Then he nodded.

I relabel every jar that's left. There aren't many. The ones Cray's men skipped. I clean them and write new cards in my own hand, and I put them back on the new cypress shelves, and they look very small up there, a handful of jars on shelves built for a hundred.

The empty spaces don't bother me as much as I thought they would.

"You'll fill them," Silas says, standing at the end of my table with his coffee.

"Maybe."

"You will. People will come."

"After what happened? A dead man on my step, a broken ward, half my shelves smashed, and my name nearly sold to God knows what?"

"Yes," he says. "Because you won."



The Aldric house writes to the King.

Twice. Selene brings the letters over on the fifth day, in her bag, and eats half a plate of my beignets, and reads them out loud at my table in a voice so dry you could strike a match on it.

"The House of Aldric," she reads, "wishes to express its profound concern at the unilateral release of obligations held in trust at the Marchand house, which obligations were of long standing and considerable delicacy." She sets it down. "That's the polite one. The second one says *reparations*."

"Oh, shit," I say.

"And it's extremely *continental*."

"What does that mean?"

"It means the Aldrics have people overseas," Selene says, "and they've written to them." She licks powdered sugar off her thumb. "Lucian says not to worry about it."

"Is he worried about it?"

"He's extremely worried about it." She grins. "It's going to be a whole thing. It won't be this year, probably. But it's going to be a thing."



Lucian comes himself on the seventh day.

He comes to my kitchen door at dusk in his black coat, alone, and knocks, and waits on the step until I open it. The King of New Orleans, on my porch, waiting to be let in.

"May I?" he says.

"It's always open," I tell him. "Apparently that's the whole goddamn problem."

He comes in. He stands in my kitchen and looks at the new shelves and the few jars on them, and at Silas at the far end of my table, and at the cat asleep on Silas's boot. Then he takes a folded paper out of his coat.

"The old writ's spent," he says. "You spent it very well. I'd like to replace it."

He hands it to me.

It's heavy paper. The King's seal, fresh wax this time. And his signature, which doesn't look like it was written by a man with blood drying on his wrists anymore. It looks like it was written by a man who's had time to think.

I read the line.

Under the crown of New Orleans, protection is extended to the Marchand house, its keeper, and anyone she keeps.

I read it three times. My eyes go blurry on the third.

"Anyone she keeps," I say.

"The phrasing seemed appropriate." Lucian glances at Silas. "Given recent events."

Silas has gone very still at the end of the table.

"Sire," he says.

"You asked me for help," Lucian says to him. "I'm still helping."

He leaves before either of us can say anything else. He goes out my kitchen door and down my walk, and he steps over the board that gives without looking at it, just as Silas does. I wonder who taught him that.



That night, I make supper.

Nothing fancy, because I'm too tired for fancy and he'd eat a boot if I cooked it. A pot of white beans and a pan of cornbread and a salad from the garden with the frog watching. I set a plate at his place at my table. He sits down in front of it.

He does that now. It isn't every time, but it's more.

The new shelves go up behind him, dark cypress, floor to ceiling, with my few jars in my own writing on them.

He eats. I watch him. The cat sits on his foot.

When he's finished, he puts his fork down and looks at me across the table.

"Ondine," he says.

"Mm."

"Let me stay."

I stop with my spoon halfway to my mouth.

He's looking at me steadily. He isn't looking at the window.

He hasn't looked at the window once since Cray's house. His palms are flat on the table on either side of his empty plate, the scarred one and the whole one, and he's looking straight at me.

"Let me stay, witch," he says again.

I put the spoon down.

He's asking. He's asking me. Silas Roche, who's asked for so few things in his life that the court keeps a list. A week. A writ. An account. Help, from his king.

And now this.

"That'll cost," I tell him. My voice shakes on it.

"I know," he says.

He doesn't ask what it'll cost. He doesn't ask how much. He just sits there with his palms on my table, waiting.



I don't answer him right away.

I look at him. I read him the only way I know, which isn't his way but is mine. His jaw. His shoulders. The line of his mouth. The fingers of his scarred palm, flat on the wood, very slightly curled.

Holy shit, he's afraid.

He's more afraid than he was in Cray's front room with the man's shoe on his wrist. More afraid than he was on the porch with the dead man's blood on his hands. He's sitting at my table with his heart in his palms, asking to be let in.

"Silas," I say.

He waits.

"I love you," he says.



The whole kitchen goes still.

It comes out of him all at once. Whole.

Three words, and a full stop at the end, and nothing trailing after it into the floor. He says it as you'd set down a stone you've been carrying across a whole country, very carefully, because you're afraid that if you drop it it'll break.

It doesn't break.

It sits there on my table between us, finished.

I stare at him.

He's staring at me too. As if he can't quite believe he said it.

As if he's reading it on the air, trying to find the place where it stops, and there isn't one, because it didn't stop. It just ended.

That's two. Two whole sentences, in his whole life, about himself. *I was a dog. Never yours.* And this.

"Again," I whisper, before I can think better of it.

"I love you," he says.

It comes easier the second time. I watch it come easier.

I get up. I come around the table. I climb into his lap on the chair, and the cat leaps off his boot in disgust, and I put my palms on his face.

"Yes," I tell him. "Stay. Yes. Fuck, yes. Stay, you stubborn, impossible, beautiful man. Stay forever. I don't care what it costs. I'll pay it."

"I'll pay it," he says.

"We'll pay it."

"Yes."

I kiss him. He kisses me back, slow and deep, with his good arm around my waist and his healing one held careful against my back, and he tastes of cornbread and coffee and something older, and we sit there in my kitchen with the new shelves behind him until the candle on the table burns down.

Then he carries me to bed.

He does it one-armed, and he lays me down on my sheets as if I'm something he's been given and is afraid to drop, and he says it again in the dark. And again. He says it into my throat, over the fading bruises Cray left, and into my hair, and against my mouth, as if now that he's found the end of the sentence he never wants to stop

reaching it.

I stop counting somewhere after ten.



Much later, in the dark, in my bed, with his arm around me and his breath in my hair, I think of one last question.

Where does a man like him keep his things, now that the coat's gone? What does he own, besides me and a cat that loves him?

"Silas."

"Mm."

"You're going to have to give up the guest room."

He's silent for a moment.

"The one with the lock on the inside," he says.

"That one."

"I liked that lock."

"You never used it."

"I used it the night I was thinking, witch."

"You used it once."

"I liked knowing it was there." A pause. "What are you going to do with it?"

I think about it.

"Put the cat in it," I say, "when he takes your side."

EPILOGUE

MORNING, KEEPER



Ondine

The vampire in my bed has a tan, and I'm taking full credit for it.

It's faint, the color of weak coffee, and it stops in a hard line at his shirt cuffs and his collar. Every morning since we came home from Cray's house, he has lain across my bed in the sun from the east window like a cat that has opinions about cats.

Elders tan. That's the rule. I've just never met one who'd put up with it.

He puts up with it for me.

He's awake. He's always awake before me, and he always waits. When I open my eyes he's looking at the ceiling with one arm behind his head and the light full on his face.

"Morning," I say.

"Her collar is lace," he says, without looking at me. "Four rows. It goes up under her chin and pins with a jet brooch the size of your thumbnail. She's wearing black. Her hair is pulled back so tight it lifts her eyebrows."

This is what he does now. It's been a month of mornings since the paper voided, and he hasn't run out. I don't know how many pieces a face has. He seems determined to find out.

"Her eyes?" I ask.

"Dark. Heavy lids. Tired, but the painter wanted her stern, and she let him." He turns his head on the pillow and looks at me. "Her mouth is yours."

I stop breathing.

"Cray said that," I whisper.

"Cray was right about one thing." He reaches over and runs his thumb along my lower lip, slow. "When you set it. When you're about to tell somebody what a thing will cost them. It's hers. It's exactly hers."

Well, shit. My eyes sting, and I let them. I've cried more since the new moon than in the whole rest of my life put together, and I've stopped apologizing for it, because he has never once looked away.

"Morning, witch," he says softly.

I lay my palm on his bare chest, over the place where his heart would be beating if it could be bothered.

"Morning, keeper."



He goes absolutely still.

I've never called him anything, not once. He calls me *witch* in the tone other men use for *mine*, and I've called him Silas, and Silas Roche when he's being an ass, and that's all he's ever had from me.

"Keeper," he says.

"It's on the new writ. Lucian's own hand. *The Marchand house, its keeper, and anyone she keeps.*" I spread my fingers on his chest. "I keep you. So."

"So."

"So you're a keeper now. Keep up."

His jaw loosens. It lasts longer than a breath this time. It lasts long enough that I actually get to watch it, what he does instead of smiling, and then he rolls onto his side and pulls me across the bed

into the sun.



It's slow at first. We have time. That's the whole miracle of this morning: nobody at the door, nobody on the step, nothing due, and the light from the east window warm on my back.

I climb on top of him.

I straddle his hips with the sheet sliding off my shoulders and take his cock in my fist. He's already hard, heavy and hot against my palm, and I stroke him slowly while he watches me with his fingers laced behind his head, as if he were sunning himself on a dock.

"Don't get comfortable," I tell him.

"I'm very comfortable."

"I can tell." I rub the head of his cock through the wet between my legs, back and forth, slow, until he stops looking comfortable. "You're awfully hard for a man who's relaxing."

"Ondine."

"Mm?"

"Get on it."

"Ask nicely."

"Please get on my cock, witch, before I put you on it."

Oh, fuck me, he's learned to say please.

I sink down.

There's no hurry in it at all. I take him slowly, watching his face go, my thighs trembling, until he's all the way inside me. Then I sit on him in the sun with my pussy stretched full and aching, and I put my palms flat on his tan line and don't move.

"You're doing that on purpose," he says through his teeth.

"I'm admiring the view. Your tan stops at your collar. You look like a painted fence."

"Ondine."

"A very handsome painted fence."

He grips my hips and grinds me down onto him, one slow hard roll, and every word I had leaves my body at once.

So I ride him.

I rock my hips and grind down and lift, slow and then less slow, and his fingers dig into my ass and hold on. The bed creaks. My tits bounce every time I come down on him, and he watches them with the expression of a man reading scripture.

Then he sits halfway up and takes a nipple in his mouth and sucks, hard, and I buckle forward onto his chest.

"Jesus, Silas."

"Lean back," he says against my skin.

"Why?"

"Because I want to watch you come on me in the light."

I lean back. I brace my palms on his thighs behind me and arch, and it changes everything, the angle and the depth and the long drag of him inside me. He takes his thumb and wets it in his own mouth and sets it on my clit, and holds it there, barely moving, and lets me do the rest.

"That's it," he says. "Use me. Take what you want."

I take it. God help me, I take all of it.

"Come on my cock," he says, watching my face. "In the sun. Come for me, witch, so I can see your tits bounce and your pussy squeeze me."

"Fuck—"

On the windowsill, the cat turns its back on us with enormous dignity.

"The cat," he says against my breast.

"The cat has always judged us."

He huffs out a breath that's almost a laugh, and I clench around him on purpose, and the laugh turns into a groan.

I ride him until I'm slick and shaking and the sun has slid off my shoulders onto the pillow. I come the first time like that, rocking on him, my forehead dropped to his chest, a long low whimper dragged out of me. He holds my hips down on his cock through every pulse of it and doesn't move a muscle.

Then he moves.



He rolls us.

He does it in one motion, his arm hooked under my thigh, and I'm on my back in the sun with the pillow knocked to the floor and my knee shoved up to my shoulder. He's still inside me, deeper at this angle than he's ever been.

"My turn," he says.

"You don't take turns."

"I'm learning."

He fucks me.

"Look at me while I do it," he says, and I look, and he pulls almost all the way out and slides back into me, slow, deep, so I feel every thick inch of his cock open me up again. "In the light. I want to see your face when you take my cock. I've never seen it in the sun."

"You've seen it every night—"

"In the dark. By a lamp. On a boat." He grinds his hips into mine, slow, and my clit drags against him and I gasp. "Never like this. Never where I can see how wet you are." He looks down between us, at where he's buried in me, at my pussy stretched and shining around him in the full morning light, and his cock jerks inside me. "Fuck, witch. Look at you. Look how you take me."

I look. God help me, I look. His cock sliding out of me slick and dark and pushing back in, my thighs spread wide around his hips, my wet on both of us.

"Faster," I beg.

"No."

"*Silas.*"

"I'm going to fuck you slow," he says, "until you come twice, and then I'm going to fuck you hard until you scream the cat off the windowsill. And then I'm going to do it again after breakfast."

"You don't eat breakfast."

"I'll start."

The tenderness doesn't go anywhere. It just gets filthy. He drives into me long and hard and deep, every stroke hitting the place that makes my back arch off the mattress, and he watches my face the entire time in the full light of morning.

There's nowhere to hide. No dark, no candle, no broken glass. Just the two of us in a bright room, sweating, the wet slap of him fucking me, and the headboard knocking the wall so hard a picture frame jumps.

"Look at you," he says. "Look at you in the sun."

"Holy shit. Keep going. Please. Keeper, please—"

That word does it to him. His rhythm stutters. His fingers bite into the back of my thigh hard enough to bruise, and he bends down and puts his mouth on my throat, on the two pale marks there, and doesn't bite. He just holds his mouth there, open, and breathes.

"Tell me," I say. "Silas. You know what."

He lifts his head and looks down at me.

The light is on his face. His eyes are black at the center and the color of creek water at the edges. He has the face of a man who has decided something, and this time I don't need blood to read what.

"I love you," he says.

He says it whole. He says it the same way he said it the first time, at my kitchen table with the new shelves behind him, setting it down as carefully as a stone he's carried across a whole country.

"I love you, witch."

I come apart.

I come with his cock buried in me and his words in my ear, my whole body bucking under him, sobbing and laughing at once, clutching his back with both fists. My pussy clamps down on him so hard he swears into my neck.

He fucks me through it and into another one, deep and relentless, until I'm writhing under him and begging and I don't even know what I'm begging for.

When he comes, he says my name into my throat, *Ondine*, the whole name, and holds me so tight I can feel every rib that broke for me at Cray's.

We lie in the sun afterward, tangled and sticky and much too warm.

He's going to be browner by lunch. He doesn't move out of the light.

"I love you too, you painted fence," I tell his shoulder.

"I know."

"You're supposed to say it back."

"I said it first."

"That's not how it works."

"It's how it works in this house," he says, and I'm so happy I could throw a jar.



Later I make coffee.

He comes into the kitchen in his trousers and nothing else and stands at the end of my table, where he's always stood, and I pour his cup and set it down in front of him.

Then I look at him.

"How do you take it?"

He goes still, holding the cup.

"You know how I take it."

"I've never asked," I tell him. "Not once. Not from the very first night."

He looks at the cup. He looks at the window.

Then he looks back at me.

"Black," he says.

"I know," I say, and I'm smiling so hard my face hurts. "God, I know. I've always known. I just wanted to hear you say it."

He drinks it standing up, at the foot of my table, and he doesn't look away from me once.

The kitchen is finished now. New shelves, new jars, new labels in my own script, and the smudge from the jar I threw is still on the far wall, because I've decided I'm keeping it. Every house needs one honest stain.

Half the names that were on these shelves are gone for good. The Aldric debts went up in the air the morning Cray's people broke the green glass, and the Aldric people have written to the King about it twice, in a tone Lucian describes as *continental*.

Selene says it's going to be a whole goddamn thing. She said it with her mouth full of my beignets, and she did not sound sorry.

"That's going to cost somebody," I say, mostly to the cat.

"Not you," Silas says.

"Not me. Not this time."

The cat, on the sill, blinks slowly at both of us, and that's as close as the damn animal has ever come to a blessing.

Silas

She's asleep by the time I go out to the hall.

I stand in front of the portrait in the dark with my palms in my pockets and read Honorine Marchand as I'd read any ground: what passed through, how long ago, whether it was carrying anything.

Tonight it's the fingers. She's holding a fan she isn't using, closed, gripped too tight, the knuckles standing up white under the paint. The painter wanted her relaxed. She didn't give him that.

I'll tell Ondine in the morning. I'll tell her about the fan, and the knuckles, and the ring on the smallest finger with a stone too dark to name. I have a lot of mornings. I've started counting them as mine.

Delphine Thibodeaux calls while I'm still standing there, and she doesn't waste a word on hello.

"There's a grave in the Arceneaux woods," she says. "Somebody's been tending it."

"Rémy told me there wasn't a grave."

"Rémy told you what the pack says." A pause on the line. Behind her voice I can hear the bayou, frogs and wind moving in the cane. "It'll rain by midafternoon. Bring a coat."

In the bedroom, Ondine has woken up. She's sitting against the headboard with the sheet around her, watching me through the open door.

"Barataria," I tell her. "The wolf's grave. Delphine found it."

I don't look at the window when I say it. She notices. I watch her notice.

"Go on, then," she says. "Come back before the soup's done."

"Stay in bed, witch."

"Absolutely not."



The Roche brothers lend me the boat.

It's the same boat, the one where she laughed at me in the middle of everything with the whole river under us, and I take it down through the cut alone with the motor low and the sky going the color of wet slate in the south.

Delphine is waiting on the Thibodeaux dock with a thermos and a face like she's been expecting me since yesterday.

"Coffee," she says, handing it down. "Black. The witch told me."

"When?"

"She texted me." Delphine shrugs. "We split tea orders. She's funny. You're lucky, and you should know it."

"I know it."

She squints south at the clouds, and her nostrils flare once, the wolf in her reading air the way I read mud.

"Mid-afternoon," she says. "Maybe sooner. He's out there. Rémy. He went this morning and didn't say where, and he never doesn't say where." She looks at me. "Be decent to him, Silas. He's been carrying something a long time."

"Carrying what?"

"If I knew, I wouldn't need you."

The rain comes exactly when Delphine said it would.

The Arceneaux place is where I left it: a burned-out shell of a house at the end of a shell road, cypress knees standing up out of black water, a tin shed with a pair of nail holes in its door where Cray's envelope used to hang.

The woods start behind the shed.

I read the ground before I go in. A path, narrow, one person wide, worn to bare dirt through the palmettos. It's old. The edges have crumbled and grown back and crumbled again. Somebody has walked this line every week for a very long time, alone, and never once cut a corner.

Small feet. A careful stride. Whoever it is stops at the same spots every time, where the path crosses a root, as if they're reminding themselves to be careful.

Who walks a path this faithfully for a wolf the bayou pretends was never buried?

I follow it.

The rain comes down through the canopy, soft and warm, and the ground goes dark and smells of wet leaf and iron, with a crushed sweetness under that. Wild iris. The path is lined with it, both sides. Someone planted it a bulb at a time, right to the clearing.

The grave sits in a clearing no bigger than Ondine's kitchen.

A mound, grassed over and kept trim. A cypress board for a marker, silvered by weather, the letters cut deep with a knife by someone patient.

HIPPOLYTE ARCENEUX.

So he was buried after all.

Somebody buried the wolf who killed Jean-Pierre Marchand on the levee. Somebody planted iris along the whole path to his grave, and has walked out here week after week to cut the grass, and has never once told the pack.

I've spent my life reading what people leave behind. I've never read anything as stubborn as this.

A lover? A child? A sister who knew what he'd done and loved him anyway?

I crouch down in the rain for a closer look.

That's when I see the ink.

Under the carved name, on the silvered wood, somebody has written a second line. It's written, not carved, and the ink is fresh. The rain beads on it and it hasn't run.

It's a signature.

I know it. I read it on the last page of Cray's ledger, the night I took his head, in a column of names that changes every generation, over one account that never does. The hands don't match. The patience does.

The account signed the wolf's grave.

My skin goes cold under the rain.

Cray is dead. I took his head myself, in front of my king. The paper is blank. The fourth chair is empty. And a name out of that ledger has been in these woods this week, kneeling in the iris, signing a dead wolf's marker as if it were a guest book at a wake.

It didn't lose at Cray's. I said that to myself on his floor, and I believed it, and I let myself forget it anyway. It finished there, and it went somewhere else, and this is where it went.

Why sign it? Who is it for? Is it for whoever walks this path with the small careful feet, or is it for the next man who comes out here reading ground?

Is it for me?

Fuck.

I reach for my phone to call Lucian.

A branch moves at the edge of the clearing.

I'm on my feet with the blade out before I've decided to stand. I read the treeline. Big man. Weight on the back foot, the stance of someone who doesn't want to be here and came anyway. Wet through. Sunburned even in the rain. One arm held a fraction stiff, the old injury he's never let heal right.

Rémy Thibodeaux steps out from between the cypress trunks with his palms open at his sides and rain running off his jaw.

He looks at the grave. He looks at the fresh ink. He looks at me.

"Yeah, no," he says. "We need to talk."

BONUS SCENE — CHAPTER 23, HIS SIDE

DRINK



She tells me to come here, and I cross her grandmother's glass without looking at it.



I don't look because I've already read it. Every shard. Which jar went first and which went last, the green Aldric glass fanned out under everything, the three men's hard heels printed in the spilled salt. I read it all standing in the doorway and I don't need to read it again.

I only need to read her.

She's standing in the middle of the wreck in her boat boots, with the river still in her hair and the blanket from Anatole's deck fallen off her shoulders, and she's gone so still I can't find her.

There's nothing on her. She's holding herself up by not moving.

Then she says my name. *Silas. Come here.* And I've been walking toward that voice my whole life.

I take her face in my palm.



I don't kiss her gently. I can't. I've been standing in her ruined kitchen for an hour with my fists shut and my teeth down in my gums, not going to Bywater, and all of it goes into her mouth.

She bites my lip.

I taste myself on her tongue.

"They were in my house," she says.

"I know, witch."

I'm going to kill him. I'm going to find a way around the paper and take his head off his polite neck on his own new rug.

I start to say it. It doesn't come. Nothing true about me ever comes.

"Don't go to him," she says. "Stay in the room."

My own words. She's giving them back to me.

I look down at her feet. At the glass around her boots.

"Boots off, witch."



I sweep the floor with my coat.

I do it on one knee, in long hard strokes, glass skittering under the stove where the cat spits at it, salt and names and green shards pushed back in a wide arc. I clear a stretch of her grandmother's boards between the table and the sink, and I run my good palm over every inch of it.

Twice I find a sliver in the grain. I pick them out with my nails.

She'll kneel on this. She'll lie on it.

Not one piece of glass is going to touch her.

I turn the coat clean side up and lay it flat.

"That'll cost you," she says. Her voice is thin.

It'll cost me a coat.

I have never in my life spent anything better.

"Lie down."



She lies down, and I look at her.

That's the first thing I do, every time, and she's learned it. She lies still for it. Her mouth, swollen from mine. Her throat, the pulse beating hard and visible in it. The sweater, the jeans, the soft rise of her under wool.

Her scent comes up off her, and it knocks the breath out of me.

Fear, first. Sour and sharp. Grief under it, heavy as wet earth. And under both of those, rising faster than either, the thick sweet musk of her pussy getting wet for me.

In the middle of all this glass. With her grandmother's names loose in the air. She's afraid and she's grieving and she's soaking, and all three of them are about me.

I've never been wanted like that. Who knew a man like me was allowed to be?

I strip her. I spread her. I put my mouth on her, because I need to taste what they almost took, and she's so wet it runs down my chin.

She grabs my hair. She grinds on my face. She comes on my tongue with her thighs clamped around my ears, and I lick her through it, and I want to stay there on her grandmother's floor with my face between her legs until the moon goes out.

"Every one of those jars can go," I tell her pussy. It's the truest thing I've ever said out loud.



Then she says *now*, and pulls at my belt with fingers that can't find the buckle, and I'm done waiting. I'm going to be inside her on this floor, where they broke her.

I push into her in one stroke, and she splits open around me, and cries out, and I bury my face in her collarbone and don't move until she tells me to.



My teeth come down.

I feel it happen. I've felt it happen more times than I can count, and I've always had it chained. With men on porches. With men in

yards. I've kept my mouth shut and my teeth up through things that would have made a new vampire tear out a throat.

With her, I can't.

She's under me on my coat with my cock inside her and her blood beating in her throat right under my mouth, and my fangs slide down all the way and ache in my gums like a wound.

She sees them. Her eyes go wide.

"Your teeth," she says. "Silas. Your teeth are out."

I shut my mouth. I flip her onto her knees so she can't see my face.

It's the most cowardly thing I've ever done, and I've done it on purpose. If she looks at me with my teeth out and her throat bare, she'll ask.

And if she asks, I'll do it. And I've never once in my life fed from somebody who wanted me to.

What's on the other side of that? What does a man find, drinking from someone who wants him to?

♦ ♦ ♦

She asks anyway.

She doesn't need to see my face. She's on her knees in the salt with me fucking her from behind, and she says *up*, and I pull her up against my chest, and she tips her head back onto my shoulder and gives me her throat.

"Drink, Silas," she says. "That's an order."

I can't breathe.

"You'll remember it," I tell her. "All of it. I won't take any of it from you."

"I know. That's the point."

I bite her.

♦ ♦ ♦

Her blood comes into my mouth, and she comes with it.

That's the only way I can say it. Every donor I've ever had was hypnotized, or frightened, or both. Their blood tasted like blood. Iron and salt and nothing.

Hers tastes like *her*.

It pours in hot and bright and heavy, and everything she's feeling comes with it. Her terror of the three men and their good shoes. Her grief for every jar on this floor. Her fury, white-hot, at Cray, at her grandmother, at the moon. The pleasure of my teeth in her, which is so fierce it makes her come again with my cock inside her, and I feel that too, from her side, a white wave going through a body that isn't mine.

And under all of it, what she hasn't said.

It's there. It's in every swallow. It's so big and so steady I don't understand at first what I'm tasting, because I've never tasted it before in anybody's blood, least of all aimed at me.

She loves me.

The witch who nearly killed my king loves me. She loves the dog from the yard, the scarred palm, the man at the end of her table who never sits down. She loves me as she salts a threshold: completely, with her wrist loose, never stopping.

I drink it. I choose to drink it. Every swallow.

And somewhere in the middle of it, with her love pouring down my throat and her body shaking against my chest, I decide.

Deciding makes no sound. It settles in me like a stone going to the bottom of a well. *If it comes to a name, it'll be mine.* Not hers. Never hers. Somebody who can love like that doesn't get to lose her name to a man who folds linen.

I don't say it. I don't have to. It's done.

Does she feel it? How could she? It's inside me, not her.



I lick the bite closed. Then I come inside her, so deep and so long I feel it in my spine, groaning her name into her neck, and we stay there, kneeling in the salt, with my arm across her ribs.

Afterward, I lay her down on the coat and pick the salt out of her knees.

A grain at a time. Her skin is pink and raw where the salt bit, and I pick every piece out with my fingertips, and I don't say anything, because I don't have anything big enough to say.

Her blood is still in my mouth. Her love is still in my throat.

The cat comes back through the door and sits in the light and looks at us.

"The cat's judging us," she says.

"The cat has always judged us, witch."

She laughs. It's wet and wrong and it's the most beautiful sound I've heard in two hundred years, and I keep my eyes on her knee so she won't see what it does to my face.

I've decided something. She doesn't know.

That's what I think.

THANK YOU



Thank you for reading *Vow of Poison*.

If Silas and Ondine got under your skin, the single best thing you can do for this book is leave a review. A line or two on Amazon or Goodreads helps new readers find it more than anything else in the world.

Tell a friend who reads dark romance. Post your favorite line. Tag it #VowOfPoison. And follow Aurelia Thorn on Amazon to hear the moment the next book is out.

Somebody has been tending a grave in the Arceneaux woods. Turn the page for the first chapter of *Son of Wolves*.

SNEAK PEEK — THE BLOOD CODE, BOOK THREE

SON OF WOLVES



The iris are a half-step flat this year, and I have been planting them long enough to hear it.



I come out to the Arceneaux woods at dawn on Thursdays, as I have every Thursday since before anyone in this bayou thought to count. I leave my bicycle at the shed, by the door with the pair of new nail holes in it, and I take the trowel and the bucket and I walk the path.

I know every root on it.

I stop at each one.

My father taught me that.

Not about roots.

About stopping. *A Vale doesn't hurry, Isabeau. A Vale arrives exactly when she meant to.* He said it as he said everything, in perfect tune, and I have spent my whole life a quarter-tone under him, trying to find the note.

He's dead now. I have found that the note is easier to hear without him standing in the room.

The rain came through on Tuesday. The ground is soft. I can smell the wild iris before I see them, green and sweet, a smell that sits in the air like a held chord.

I planted the first of them when this path was a deer track.

I have planted a few more every autumn since.

Nobody has ever asked me why.

Nobody knows to ask.

The clearing opens ahead of me, small and round, with the light coming down gray through the oaks. The mound.

The grass I cut last week. The cypress marker, silvered, with his name cut deep.

HIPPOLYTE ARCENEUX.

I kneel in the wet grass in front of it, as I always do, and set down my bucket.

Then I see the ink.



It sits below his name.

A signature. Written, not carved, in brown ink so fresh the Tuesday rain beaded on it and never touched it.

I know that hand.

I have held it in my own. I have read it by lamplight in my father's study, in letters he kept in a locked drawer and thought I'd never find. I have seen it at the foot of every letter the broker ever sent him, and above those, in the notations on the margins, and once, only once, in a letter older than all the others, one I kept back from the witch and buttoned into my coat.

That hand signs for the account.

It has never once signed for anything that was not about to be paid.

I stay on my knees in the wet. I am very still.

I have been told I go still like a clock stopping, and I suppose it's true. I can hear my own quiet, and it has a pitch to it, high and thin, the note a glass makes just before it breaks.

Who came here?

Who walked my path, on my roots, past my iris, and knelt where I kneel, and wrote on him?

And what are they going to collect?

//



Yeah, no."

I don't turn around. I know the voice.

Everyone in Barataria knows the voice. It comes from the treeline behind me, low and rough and bayou-flat, and it is exactly a whole step under every other sound in the clearing.

"Mr. Thibodeaux," I say to the marker.

"You're the one doing this." He's closer now. I hear the palmettos move. "The flowers. The grass. Every week. I've been out here watching the prints for a month trying to figure out whose feet were that small."

"How diligent of you."

"You're a Vale."

"I'm aware."

"You're a Vale," he says again, as though repeating it might make it make sense, "planting flowers on a wolf's grave. On *this* wolf's grave."

I stand up.

I do it slowly, as my father taught me. I brush the wet grass from my knees.

I pull my gloves straight at the wrists. Then I turn around, and there he is.

He's larger than I remember. He's been larger than I remember every time I've seen him, as though my memory keeps trying to make him a more reasonable size. Sunburned across the nose.

Wet to the knees from the path. His left arm held a fraction stiff against his side, where the old King broke it and it never healed right. He's standing at the edge of my clearing with rain in his hair, looking at me as if I am the most out-of-tune thing he has ever heard.

He killed two people once, because my father told him to.

He has never pretended otherwise. It's the only thing about him that has ever been in tune.

"Silas Roche was here Tuesday," he says. "He saw the ink. He went white as a sheet, and Roche doesn't go white."

"I imagine not."

"He's gone to tell the King."

"Then the King will know by noon." I take a step toward the path. "If you'd be so kind as to let me pass, Mr. Thibodeaux, I have somewhere to be."

He doesn't move.

He's standing on the path. On my path. Square in the middle of it, where it narrows between two palmettos, and there's no way past him that doesn't touch him.

"Yeah, no," he says softly. "Not this time."



I stop an arm's length from him.

I can smell him. Wolf and rain and river mud and something under it, warm and animal and alive, that makes the back of my throat ache.

It's been a very long time since I stood this close to a wolf. The last time, I was a girl and it was a matter of politics, and I didn't breathe.

I breathe now. I can't seem to help it.

"Move," I say.

"Tell me why."

"Why what?"

"Why a Vale's been tending Hippolyte Arceneaux's grave." His eyes are a pale bayou green, and they're on my face, and they don't leave it. "Why the account signed it. Why you looked at that ink like you'd seen a ghost. And why every wolf in this bayou's been lying about him having a grave for as long as I've been alive."

"You're asking a great many questions for a man standing in my way."

"I'm asking one. You just don't want to hear it."

He reaches out.

I think he's going to take my arm. I think he's going to put that big sunburned palm on me and move me, and I brace for it, and I am not at all certain I'd stop him.

He doesn't take my arm.

He takes the trowel. Out of my gloved fingers, gently, as though I might have forgotten I was holding it. He turns it over and looks at the mud on the blade, black and fresh, and then he looks at me.

His fingers brushed my wrist when he took it. Just the edge of them, through the glove. I can feel exactly where.

"Somebody's collecting, Miss Vale," he says. "You know it. I know it. And whatever's on that marker, it isn't paid yet."

The iris are a half-step flat. The rain is coming again.

I can hear it in the oaks. And the wolf who killed Selene Ward's parents is standing on my path with my trowel in his fist and his eyes on my mouth.

"No," I hear myself say. "It isn't."

"Then we need to talk."



Son of Wolves — *The Blood Code, Book Three. Rémy & Isabeau.*

Coming soon.

END OF BOOK ONE



The Blood Code continues with Rémy & Isabeau in
Book Three: Son of Wolves